

# Restart



## INTRODUCTION

### BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF GORDON KORMAN

Gordon Korman was born in 1963 in Montreal, Canada. In 1970, his family moved to a suburb of Toronto, the largest city in Canada. In middle school, he took English from a track-and-field coach who allowed the students to work on months-long, independent creative writing projects. During that time, Korman wrote the manuscript of his first novel, *This Can't Be Happening at Macdonald Hall*, about two young pranksters at a Canadian boarding school. Korman decided to send his manuscript to the publishing company Scholastic, because he served as the Scholastic Arrow Book Club monitor for his class and so felt he had a connection to the publisher. Scholastic bought the manuscript and published his book in 1978, when he was a freshman in high school. Korman wrote and published several more novels while in high school. After his high-school graduation, he went to New York University, where he studied film and graduated with a Bachelor of Fine Arts in 1985. He has continued to produce novels at a brisk pace; as of 2023, he has written more than 100 novels for children or young adults. Currently, he lives on Long Island in New York.

### HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The plot of *Restart* involves Chase Ambrose, the amnesiac middle-school protagonist, discovering that he stole a Medal of Honor from an elderly Korean War veteran named Mr. Solway. Japan conquered Korea in 1910 and ruled it until the end of World War II, when the global powers known as the Allies (e.g. the United States, the United Kingdom, and the USSR) defeated the Axis powers (Nazi Germany and Imperial Japan). From 1945 to 1948, the US occupied the southern part of Korea, while the USSR occupied the northern part. In 1948, these two zones became two nations, the capitalist South Korea and the communist North Korea. Each nation wanted sovereignty over the entire territory of Korea, and in June 1950, North Korea invaded South Korea. The ensuing conflict, called the Korean War, lasted from 1950 to 1953, during which time US soldiers fought on the side of South Korea. The Korean War was extremely brutal. In 1950, the US-backed South Korean government massacred tens of thousands—and perhaps hundreds of thousands—of its citizens on the suspicion that they were communists, carrying this out in the so-called Bodo League massacre. Meanwhile, North Korea tortured and killed prisoners of war. It may be due to the brutality of the war that Mr. Solway refuses to wear his Medal of Honor (a decoration given to only a little more than 3,000 soldiers in US history) and why he dislikes it when people call him a war hero.

## RELATED LITERARY WORKS

*Restart* is, broadly, a novel about a middle-school bully who becomes kinder and more thoughtful, rejecting his place in the social hierarchy, after a head injury gives him amnesia. One famous and influential novel about adolescent social hierarchies is William Golding's *The Lord of the Flies* (1954), which is about schoolboys marooned on an island who try—and dramatically, violently fail—to organize themselves into a functioning community. Another influential children's book whose protagonist participates in bullying is Judy Blume's *Blubber* (1974), about a girl named Jill Brenner who helps her friends bully an overweight classmate until Jill, too, is targeted for bullying. Yet both *The Lord of the Flies* and *Blubber* represent social hierarchies and bullying prior to the advent of phone cameras and social media, whereas a major plot point in *Restart* involves its protagonist trying to take an embarrassing photo of his neighbor on his phone. A middle-grade novel in the same contemporary and technological milieu as *Restart* is Sarah Darer Littman's *Backlash* (2015), which is about a girl whose crush bullies her over Facebook. Gorman Karman himself has also written several other contemporary novels about bullying, including *Schooled* (2007), a novel with a protagonist often too socially oblivious to realize he is being bullied.

## KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Restart
- **When Published:** 2017
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Children's Novel
- **Setting:** Hiawassee, Georgia
- **Climax:** Chase refuses to lie to the judge at his juvenile court hearing.
- **Antagonist:** Aaron Hakimian, Bear Bratsky
- **Point of View:** First Person (rotating between multiple characters)

## EXTRA CREDIT

**Help from Mom.** According to Gordan Korman, his mother typed up the manuscript of his first novel, which was published by Scholastic when he was only 14.

**Hoosiers.** In 2017, *Restart* won the Young Hoosier Book Award, an honor bestowed by the Indiana Library Federation. ("Hoosier" is a slang term for a person from Indiana.)



## PLOT SUMMARY

Thirteen-year-old Chase Ambrose wakes up in the hospital with no memory. His mother Tina, college-aged brother Johnny, and doctor inform him that he has developed amnesia due to a concussion: he likes to sit on his roof, and one day he fell off. When the doctor asks Chase whether he can remember anything, he only recalls a little blond girl. Tina and Johnny take Chase home, where his father Frank is waiting to greet him. When Frank gives Chase a noogie, Tina and Johnny explain that Chase has a concussion and can't play football on his doctor's orders. Frank, undeterred, insults the doctor and praises Chase's toughness.

Shoshanna Weber messages her twin, Joel, to let him know that Chase—who bullied Joel so badly that the Webers sent him to boarding school—fell off a roof and just left the hospital. Though Shoshanna is hoping to cheer Joel up, he's miserable at his new school. The day before school starts, Shoshanna runs into Chase at a frozen yogurt shop. When he smiles at her, she upends her frozen yogurt on his head and runs out.

On the first day of school, the football players who were Chase's closest friends, Aaron Hakimian and Bear Bratsky, take Chase aside. When Chase explains that he has amnesia, they seem suspicious and worried. The principal, Dr. Fitzwallace, summons Chase to his office and advises Chase to take advantage of his "fresh start," but Chase keeps hanging out with Aaron, Bear, and the football team. One day, Aaron and Bear mention having to do community service at an assisted living facility; Chase learns that all three of them were sentenced to community service for hiding cherry bombs inside Joel's piano during a school recital, though Chase doesn't have to go anymore because he's received a medical exemption.

Brendan Espinoza is filming cliques in the cafeteria when Chase comes to sit with him. Brendan's terrified because Chase and his friends have bullied him in the past—but it quickly becomes clear that Chase has amnesia and is much more polite now. When Brendan can't get other video-club members to help him film a video, he asks Chase for help. After Chase agrees, Brendan realizes Chase is excellent with a camera and invites him to join video club. When Chase shows up at a meeting, all the members but Brendan are horrified—none more so than Shoshanna. After making her displeasure known, she expresses a desire to enter the National Video Journalism Contest, which will require entrants to interview a senior citizen.

After filming a Saturday football scrimmage for video club, Chase goes to interview the football players in the locker room, where he has such an unexpectedly pleasant time that he decides to go to community service afterwards with Aaron and Bear. At the assisted living facility, Chase is fascinated by a photo he sees in one sleeping senior's room. The photo is of the man accepting a **Medal of Honor** from President Truman.

Later, Bear takes \$20 from an elderly woman in cognitive decline who thinks she's tipping hotel staff. Chase tries to get Bear to give the money back, but he won't. After leaving, Chase returns to the facility and slips his own \$20 under the resident's door. On his way out, he stops by the room of the man with the photo and sees a nameplate: Mr. Julius Solway. Mr. Solway asks what Chase wants. When Chase asks how Mr. Solway won the medal, he responds sarcastically but then explains it was during the Korean War.

Kimberly Tooley, who has a crush on Chase, sees him shove a bully into a wall for getting rough with Brendan. When Brendan and other video club members thank Chase, Shoshanna reminds them about what Chase did to her brother. After they disperse, Chase admits to Kimberly that he can't remember Shoshanna's brother. Ecstatic that post-amnesia Chase is talking to her, Kimberly joins video club. Brendan immediately develops a crush on her, but his attempts to impress her fail.

Aaron is upset that Chase has amnesia. He wants his old friend back, but in addition, Chase is in possession of a valuable object that he, Aaron, and Bear were supposed to split three ways. Aaron wants to ask Chase some questions at community service, but Chase is too busy helping seniors and chatting with Mr. Solway about the Korean War. Chase learns that Mr. Solway won his Medal of Honor for opening an enemy tank and throwing a grenade inside. Mr. Solway admits he can't remember throwing the grenade; the violent aftermath was so horrible that his brain repressed it. He also tells Chase that he lost the medal at some point.

At a video club meeting, Shoshanna is explaining how good the National Video Journalism Contest entries could be if entrants found the right seniors to interview. Chase suggests Mr. Solway. Shoshanna is suspicious but intrigued. She goes to the assisted living facility to meet Mr. Solway. Mr. Solway blows her off until Chase walks in with snacks. When Mr. Solway realizes Chase knows Shoshanna, he agrees to help with "their" project. Chase and Shoshanna have been interviewing Mr. Solway for three days when Shoshanna starts trying to find mementos they can film. At the back of Mr. Solway's closet, she finds the empty case for his Medal of Honor. Walking home from the facility, Shoshanna mentions to Chase that it's weird of Mr. Solway to stash his medal at the back of his closet. Abruptly, Chase guesses that the medal was stolen and the box was put in an out-of-the-way place to hide the theft. Because Bear took money from Mrs. Swanson, Chase wonders whether Bear and Aaron are the thieves.

Though it makes Shoshanna uncomfortable, she can't deny that post-amnesia Chase is a different, nicer person. One day, Shoshanna's mother spots Shoshanna and Chase working together. She drags Shoshanna home, where she and Shoshanna's father stage an intervention over Shoshanna befriending Joel's bully. Shoshanna argues that they should bring Joel back from boarding school: the Webers only sent

him away because of Chase's bullying, and Chase isn't a bully anymore. The Webers, though nervous, decide to bring Joel home.

When Chase and Shoshanna finish their video, the school holds an assembly to watch it. Aaron and Bear are furious: Aaron thinks Chase is boasting about being a stand-up guy, while Bear thinks it's suspicious that Chase chose Mr. Solway to interview. Aaron suggests they show Chase who "his real friends are." Later, Joel and Kimberly are helping Brendan film a video in the music room when Aaron and Bear burst in with fire extinguishers, spraying the other kids with foam. They claim Chase sent them to attack Joel. Kimberly runs to get Chase; when she returns with him, he and Bear fight over a fire extinguisher—and when Chase wins, he accidentally hits Joel in the face with it.

Teachers arrive. Aaron, Bear, and Chase are taken to Dr. Fitzwallace's office, where Aaron lies that the video equipment started a fire in the music room—he, Bear, and Chase were helping. Chase realizes that no one will believe he wasn't bullying Joel. When Dr. Fitzwallace asks Chase to confirm Aaron's story, he begrudgingly lies to save himself. Dr. Fitzwallace doesn't punish the boys—but Chase is kicked out of video club, and all the club members but Brendan now believe Chase's nice-guy amnesiac personality is an act. Meanwhile, a questionable doctor Frank found has cleared Chase to play football. One day at football practice, Chase gets into a big fight with Aaron and Bear and accuses them of stealing Mr. Solway's medal. Aaron, flabbergasted, reveals that Chase stole the medal, though the three boys planned to split the value three ways. Chase asserts that he'll give the medal back if he finds it, but Aaron claims that he and Bear have a right to two-thirds of the medal's value.

When Brendan tries to make another video, he discovers that the camera contains footage of the music room fracas proving that Chase hit Joel by accident. He urgently texts Chase, Shoshanna, Joel, and Kimberly to come to his house the next morning. As Chase leaves for Brendan's, he sees movers hauling stuff out of his neighbors' house, including a painting depicting the little blond girl he remembers. When he asks his neighbor about the painting, she tells him that it used to hang in an upstairs room in her house. Chase climbs onto his own roof to find the spot from which he must have spied the painting—and discovers Mr. Solway's Medal of Honor up there.

When Chase doesn't show up at Brendan's, Brendan screens the footage he found for Shoshanna, Joel, and Kimberly. Brendan calls Chase's mom and discovers he left for the assisted living facility. The kids decide to find Chase there. At the facility, Aaron and Bear spot Chase with the medal and try to grab it. After Shoshanna, Kimberly, Joel, and Brendan enter Mr. Solway's room, Shoshanna and Kimberly spot Chase running down the hall toward them—only to see Aaron knock Chase down and Bear start hitting him. Shoshanna and

Kimberly drag Bear off Chase; when Bear shoves the girls, Brendan jumps to their defense. Eventually, the facility authorities show up and call the police.

Chase, who has taken sole responsibility for stealing the medal, stays at home, full of self-loathing, until his juvenile court date. His hearing is packed with community members. To his great surprise, not only his mother and father—who unexpectedly praises Chase's new, less sports-obsessed personality—but also Shoshanna take the stand as character witnesses in his defense. It turns out *everyone* is there to speak in amnesiac Chase's defense. When the judge asks Chase whether he can promise he won't return to his pre-amnesia self, Chase realizes he could lie—but he decides to be scrupulously honest and says he can't promise that. The judge is about to sentence Chase when Mr. Solway bursts in with his Medal of Honor and claims that Chase never stole the medal—Mr. Solway lent it to him. The judge doesn't believe Mr. Solway, but he decides not to punish Chase. Everyone celebrates jubilantly.

Chase becomes a football player *and* a video club member. Kimberly starts dating Brendan because she appreciates his bravery in standing up to Bear during the fight at the assisted living facility. She also uploads a YouTube video of Brendan wearing a tuba while covered in fire extinguisher foam, which, to Brendan's great delight, goes viral.



## CHARACTERS

### MAJOR CHARACTERS

**Chase Ambrose** – Chase Ambrose is a middle-school football star who falls from his roof and sustains a concussion, giving him amnesia. Possessing almost no memories, he can't even recognize his mother, Tina, or his brother, Johnny. Tina, Johnny, and Chase's doctor want Chase to avoid football for a year, but Tina's ex-husband, Chase's macho father, Frank, disdains this medical advice and insists that Chase should play. As amnesiac Chase begins eighth grade, he reacquaints himself with his friends, football players Aaron Hakimian and Bear Bratsky. Aaron and Bear tell Chase that a juvenile court sentenced all three of them to community service but suggest that the court was overreacting to a funny "prank." When Chase befriends geeky video-club president Brendan Espinoza and joins the video club, however, he discovers that many video club kids consider him a bully. Chase bullied one boy, Joel Weber, so badly that Joel's parents sent him to boarding school, a fact that Joel's twin sister, Shoshanna, makes sure everyone remembers. Doing community service at an assisted living facility with Aaron and Bear, Chase befriends an elderly veteran, Mr. Solway. Chase and Shoshanna end up filming interviews with Mr. Solway for a video contest, a project that sparks a friendship between them. Eventually, Chase learns that, prior to his accident, he stole Mr. Solway's **Medal of**

**Honor**; he, Aaron, and Bear intended to sell the medal and split the earnings. Chase, horrified by his past behavior, returns the medal and takes sole responsibility for the theft; at his juvenile court hearing, he refuses to lie and claim that he's a completely different person than he was before his accident—a scrupulous honesty that demonstrates his personal growth. Mr. Solway bursts into the hearing and claims that he lent Chase the medal. Saved by Mr. Solway's fib, Chase becomes a video-club member *and* a football player, widely liked due to the improvements in his personality triggered by his memory loss.

**Shoshanna Weber** – Shoshanna Weber is an outspoken, proudly nerdy girl and the most ambitious member of her middle school's video club. When the novel begins, Shoshanna hates her classmates Chase, Aaron Hakimian, and Bear Bratsky for bullying her twin brother, Joel, so badly that their parents sent Joel away to boarding school. She hears about Chase's fall over the summer but doesn't realize he has amnesia at first. When Chase befriends video-club president Brendan Espinoza and joins video club, Shoshanna protests vociferously. She's irritated when Chase dares to suggest an interview subject—an elderly Korean War veteran named Mr. Solway—for her National Video Journalism Contest project. Yet she recognizes that Mr. Solway might be a great interviewee, and when Mr. Solway only agrees to be interviewed on the assumption that the video is Shoshanna and Chase's joint project, she resigns herself to working with a boy she loathes. Though it makes her feel disloyal to her family, Shoshanna realizes through working with Chase that he has changed since his accident. She persuades her parents to transfer Joel back to their old school, arguing that Chase isn't a threat to Joel anymore. When Aaron and Bear frame Chase for bullying Joel again, Shoshanna feels like she's been duped and judges Chase very harshly. After discovering Chase's innocence, though, she judges *herself* harshly for jumping to conclusions—and she testifies as a character witness in Chase's defense at his trial for stealing Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**. At the novel's end, it is implied that she and Chase have developed crushes on each other.

**Brendan Espinoza** – Brendan Espinoza, the president of his middle school's video club, is a bullying victim of Chase Ambrose, Aaron Hakimian, and Bear Bratsky, friend of fellow video club members Shoshanna Weber and Joel Weber, and eventual boyfriend of Kimberly Tooley. When Chase returns to school after a concussion causing amnesia, he sits with Brendan at lunch. Brendan quickly realizes Chase is nicer than he used to be. When the video-club kids won't help Brendan—whose ambition is to create a viral video—film a physically risky YouTube video, Brendan asks Chase to help. Chase agrees, and Brendan soon realizes he's a talented cameraman, so he invites Chase to join video club. The other video-club kids are reluctant to accept Chase, but Brendan argues that amnesia has changed him. Brendan and Chase become good friends. When Kimberly Tooley joins video club because she has a crush

on Chase, Brendan immediately develops a crush on her—but he doesn't resent Chase for being the object of her affections; he just tries to impress her by making zany videos. Moreover, when Aaron and Bear frame Chase for a new act of bullying, Brendan is the only member of video club who gives Chase the benefit of the doubt, believing Chase might be innocent and discovering video footage that exonerates him. By the novel's end, Brendan has managed to impress Kimberly, who becomes his girlfriend. Kimberly uploads a YouTube video of Brendan wearing a tuba and covered in fire-extinguisher foam, heling him finally go viral.

**Mr. Solway** – Mr. Solway is a sarcastic, lonely Korean War veteran who won a **Medal of Honor** for opening an enemy tank and killing the enemy soldiers inside with a grenade. He lives in the assisted living facility where middle-school bullies Chase Ambrose, Aaron Hakimian, and Bear Bratsky are sentenced to community service. When Chase steals the medal with Aaron and Bear's assistance, Mr. Solway assumes he lost it: a childless widower, he believes he's gone cognitively downhill since his wife died. After Chase develops amnesia due to a concussion, he notices a photo in Mr. Solway's room of Mr. Solway receiving the medal from President Truman. He starts asking Mr. Solway questions, eventually befriending him and becoming a kind of adopted grandson. Mr. Solway admits that he thinks the action for which he won the medal was stupid more than brave. In addition, he can't remember doing it: the subsequent violence so traumatized him that his brain repressed the memory. He doesn't like war and doesn't think of himself as a hero. Chase proposes to fellow video-club member Shoshanna Weber that Mr. Solway would be a good interviewee for her National Video Journalism Contest project. Chase and Shoshanna reconnect Mr. Solway to his life, which he thought was basically finished. When Chase realizes that he stole Mr. Solway's medal, he returns it and takes sole responsibility for the theft. Mr. Solway is initially devastated—but he appears at Chase's juvenile court and tells the judge he shouldn't prosecute. When the judge insists on sentencing Chase, Mr. Solway claims no theft occurred, lying that he gave Chase the medal himself.

**Aaron Hakimian** – A middle-school football player with unusually developed facial hair, Aaron Hakimian is best friends with fellow bullies Chase Ambrose and Bear Bratsky. The boys are sentenced to community service for setting off cherry bombs in their bullying victim Joel Weber's piano during a recital. While doing community service at an assisted living facility, Aaron and Bear help Chase steal elderly Korean War veteran Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**, and Chase promises them an equal cut of the medal's value. After Chase sustains a concussion and develops amnesia, Aaron and Bear—who don't know where the medal is—worry that they won't get their cut. Yet whereas Bear is immediately suspicious of Chase, wondering whether he's faking his amnesia to keep the medal for himself, Aaron defends Chase, whose friendship he misses.



Wondering whether friendship is only about shared memories or something deeper, he also feels unacknowledged, resentful jealousy over amnesiac Chase's new, likable personality and new friendships with the video club and Mr. Solway. In an attempt to show Chase "who his real friends are," Aaron masterminds a plan with Bear to frame Chase for bullying Joel again—and, in the aftermath, points out to Chase that all his new video-club friends immediately believed he was guilty. Yet this plan backfires: Chase is furious with Aaron and Bear and—realizing something suspect has occurred with Mr. Solway's Medal of Honor—accuses them of stealing it. When Aaron informs Chase that he himself stole it, Chase returns the medal despite Aaron and Bear's attempts to stop him. Though Chase takes full responsibility for the theft, not implicating Aaron or Bear, he permanently ends his friendship with them. By the novel's end, Aaron and Bear are ostracized even by their fellow football players.

**Joel Weber** – Joel Weber is Shoshanna's brother and the frequent target of football players Chase Ambrose, Aaron Hakimian, and Bear Bratsky's bullying. A video-club member and a talented pianist, he is sent away by his parents to a boarding school after Chase, Aaron, and Bear set off cherry bombs in his piano during their school music recital. Though Joel hated the bullying, he loathes his new school, where being a talented musician doesn't make him "special" and the students are too obsessed with their instruments. When Shoshanna suggests that post-concussion, amnesiac Chase won't bully Joel anymore, Joel immediately transfers back to their old school. Even after amnesiac Chase apologizes to Joel for the bullying Chase can't remember, Joel still loathes him. Yet when Aaron and Bear frame Chase for another bullying incident, during which Chase hits Joel in the face while trying to get a fire extinguisher away from Bear, Joel refuses to leave town again. Moreover, when video-club president Brendan Espinoza finds video footage proving that Chase hit Joel by accident, Joel is willing to watch and believe it. He even comes to support Chase during Chase's juvenile court hearing for stealing Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**. At the novel's end, Joel is furthering social cohesion among musicians, video club members, and football players by serving as the pep band's musical director, highlighting his strength of character and resilience in the face of bullying.

**Frank Ambrose** – Frank is father to Chase, Johnny, and Helene, ex-husband to Tina, and current husband to Corinne. A former middle-school football star, Frank peaked in adolescence and remains obsessed with maintaining a masculine identity based on sports, physical toughness, meat-eating, and cool cars. He has a tense relationship with his oldest son, Johnny, because he openly believes Tina's parenting turned Johnny into a "wimp." Frank's obsession with masculinity and football implicitly encouraged his younger son Chase's bullying. Frank focuses so intently on Chase's middle-school football career—even finding

a doctor to give a second opinion when Chase's physician advises Chase not to play after a serious concussion—that he inadvertently leads Chase to believe that he only likes him insofar as Chase is "a chip off the old block." Frank is even dismissive of post-concussion, amnesiac Chase's attempts to befriend Helene, Frank's four-year-old daughter with Corinne. Frank thinks Chase playing dolls or princess with Helene is an effeminate, embarrassing waste of time. Yet after amnesiac Chase realizes he stole a **Medal of Honor** from elderly veteran Mr. Solway, he turns himself in and takes sole responsibility, refusing to implicate his accomplices, Aaron Hakimian and Bear Bratsky; Chase's unswerving acceptance of responsibility forces Frank to acknowledge that Chase has more strength of character after his accident than he did before. Not only does Frank feel proud of Chase's moral bravery, but he also belatedly praises Chase's new kindness toward Helene and testifies during Chase's juvenile court hearing for stealing the medal that he wishes he'd had a personality-improving head injury when he was Chase's age. Thus, ironically, Chase models a better model of masculine strength for his father than his father ever modeled for him.

**Bear Bratsky** – A middle-school football player and unrepentant bully, Bear Bratsky is best friends with fellow football bullies Chase Ambrose and Aaron Hakimian. Yet unlike Chase or even Aaron, Bear demonstrates little capacity for deep thought or complex emotion, preferring action at all costs. He, Chase, and Aaron are sentenced to community service for setting off cherry bombs in Joel Weber's piano during a school recital. While doing community service at an assisted living facility, he and Aaron help Chase steal a **Medal of Honor** from elderly veteran Mr. Solway. After Chase sustains a concussion and develops amnesia, Bear immediately suspects Chase of faking the amnesia to keep the medal to himself rather than splitting its value with his accomplices. Bear participates gleefully in Aaron's plan to frame amnesiac Chase for bullying Joel again, though he seems more motivated by aggression than by the complicated mixture of grief, resentment, and nostalgia that motivates Aaron. After Aaron tells Chase that Chase himself stole the medal, Chase attempts to return it, and Bear and Aaron try violently to prevent Chase from getting the medal back to Mr. Solway—an attempt that fails due to the intervention of amnesiac Chase's new video-club friends. At the novel's end, Bear and Aaron are being ostracized due to their persistent poor behavior.

**Kimberly Tooley** – Kimberly Tooley is a peppy middle-school girl who loves football because she thinks boys look good in uniforms. She has a crush on her classmate, football star Chase Ambrose. After Chase suffers a concussion, develops amnesia, and joins video club, Kimberly joins too, hoping he's forgotten that he's "totally out of [her] league." Though Kimberly is terrible at film, video-club president Brendan Espinoza immediately develops a crush on her and tries to impress her

with the zany short films he makes for YouTube. Unfortunately, Brendan and Kimberly do not share a sense of humor; she's more confused than impressed by his videos. Yet during a fight at the assisted living facility where Chase is doing community service, Bear Bratsky shoves Kimberly and Shoshanna Weber into a wall—and Brendan, though much smaller and weaker than Bear, immediately jumps to their defense. Kimberly is impressed by Brendan's bravery—though she likes to tell him that she was just “amazed” Bear didn't kill him—and by the novel's end, they have become boyfriend and girlfriend.

**Tina (Chase's Mom)** – A dark-haired woman with glasses, Tina is mother to Chase and Johnny and ex-wife to Frank. Tina loves and supports Chase, believing him to be a good person “deep down.” However, she had difficulty controlling his cruel, reckless antics prior to his accident and, after the accident, hesitates to reveal to him how many bad things he did. When amnesiac Chase confronts her over her various omissions, she admits that she was trying to spare his feelings but judges his past behavior very critically, especially as it relates to him, Aaron, and Bear bullying Joel Weber. Tina's omissions and criticisms confuse Chase, making him wonder whether he should trust her or his father, who excuses Chase's previous behavior and accuses Tina of trying to coddle away Chase's toughness, the way (in his view) she did with their older son Johnny. Despite the occasionally tense relationship between Tina and Chase, she takes the stand as a character witness at his juvenile court hearing for stealing Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**, during which testimony she asserts that Chase has become a much better person since his accident.

**Helene** – Helene is Chase and Johnny's four-year-old half-sister, daughter of Frank and Frank's second wife, Corinne. When the novel begins, Helene fears Chase, who bullied her by tearing the head off her beloved teddy bear and making her cry. Post-accident, amnesiac Chase feels uneasy and guilty about scaring Helene; he tries to befriend her by playing dolls and princess with her, something that his rigidly macho pre-accident self would never have done. At first, Frank criticizes Chase's willingness to engage in girly activities with Helene; due to Frank's rigid ideas about traditional masculinity, he believes Chase is wasting time and losing toughness by indulging his little half-sister. Eventually, however, both Frank and Corinne come to appreciate Chase's attempts to treat Helene better.

**Corinne** – Corinne is second wife to Frank, mother to four-year-old Helene, and stepmother to Chase and Johnny. After Chase's amnesia-causing accident, he notices Corinne's cold attitude toward him, not realizing that he bullied Corinne's young daughter before. Eventually, amnesiac Chase's earnest attempts to befriend Helene, unselfconsciously playing dolls and princesses with her, win Corinne over. After Chase admits to stealing Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**, Corinne supports Chase in the lead-up to his juvenile court hearing, praising “the

kind of person” he has become since his accident. She also plays a pivotal role in the hearing itself: without telling Chase, she drives Mr. Solway from his assisted living facility to the court so that he can speak on Chase's behalf.

**Johnny Ambrose** – Johnny Ambrose is Chase's older brother. Johnny has a tense relationship with his father, Frank, who openly claims that his mother's softer parenting style made him a “wimp.” Johnny is very caring toward Chase in the immediate aftermath of Chase's accident; although he's a college student, he comes home to support Chase during his juvenile court hearing for stealing Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**. The care and support that Johnny gives Chase contrast with Chase's pre-accident attitude toward Johnny, whom Chase—under the influence of his overbearing, macho father—judged to be a “wuss.” Johnny's goodness and maturity indicate that there are better models of masculinity than the one that sports-obsessed Frank has been modeling for Chase.

**Dr. Fitzwallace** – Dr. Fitzwallace is principal of Hiawasse Middle School, which Chase Ambrose and many of *Restart's* other main characters attend. He tries but largely fails to punish Chase and his friends Aaron Hakimian and Bear Bratsky for bullying Joel Weber—perhaps because the bullies are football stars whose punishment would trigger pushback from the community. After Chase suffers amnesia due to a concussion, Dr. Fitzwallace encourages him to take advantage of his “fresh start”—but after Aaron and Bear frame Chase for another act of bullying against Joel, Dr. Fitzwallace tacitly encourages Chase to support Aaron's exculpatory lies due to the “major hassle” punishing them would entail. Dr. Fitzwallace's inability and occasional unwillingness to control bullying at his school illustrates how adults may fail to stop—or may even be complicit in—adolescent bullying.

**Nurse Duncan** – Nurse Duncan is the head nurse at Portland Assisted Living Residence, the assisted living facility where Mr. Solway lives and where middle-school bullies Chase Ambrose, Aaron Hakimian, and Bear Bratsky are doing court-ordered community service. At first, she dislikes the boys for their disrespectful and unhelpful behavior. Though she comes to like Chase after his personality-changing accident, she still calls the police on him when she realizes that he stole Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**.

## MINOR CHARACTERS

**Mr. Landau** – Mr. Landau is Chase's lawyer at his juvenile court hearing for stealing Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**.



## THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have

a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



## IDENTITY, MEMORY, AND RESPONSIBILITY

*Restart* suggests that taking responsibility for past actions is an important part of understanding and shaping one's own identity. Of course, the characters in the novel aren't necessarily *defined* by what they can remember about themselves or what they've done in the past, but there is a clear sense that everyone should be accountable for their past.

More specifically, the novel illustrates the complicated dynamics between identity and memory in the character Chase Ambrose, an arrogant middle-school football star and major bully who loses his memories in an accident. After the accident, Chase can't remember his macho father, Frank, obsessing over his football career or his jock friends Aaron and Bear encouraging his bullying. Due to this memory loss, suppressed elements of Chase's personality come to the surface: he's friendlier to "uncool" kids, more interested in "geeky" pursuits like video club, and happy to help his much-younger sister Helene play with dolls. Moreover, when he learns about his bad past actions, they disgust him, and he hopes to be a better person in the future. Some of his former bullying victims think Chase's identity remains unchanged—they compare him to an animal and say things like "a leopard never changes his spots"—but Chase's amnesia makes clear that his past behavior doesn't express his core personality.

Although Chase can't remember his past actions and doesn't want to repeat them, he's still responsible for them. The novel makes this clear by revealing that Chase, prior to his accident, stole a **Medal of Honor** from an elderly Korean War veteran named Mr. Solway. When post-accident Chase becomes aware of his crime, merely disavowing his past actions isn't enough to undo the damage. It's only when Chase has returned the medal to Mr. Solway and refused to lie to a juvenile court judge about whether his old self is dead—something Chase doesn't believe he can promise—that he truly matures beyond the "old" Chase, who would have lied and promised anything to get out of trouble. Through Chase's character arc, *Restart* suggests that we should hold ourselves accountable for our past mistakes without feeling that we're doomed to repeat them, illustrating that people really *can* shape their own identities.



## REPUTATION VS. REALITY

*Restart* suggests that judging people solely based on their reputations is often an inaccurate way to assess them. By spotlighting Chase Ambrose and Mr. Solway, the novel illustrates how misleading these external perceptions can be. When the novel begins, 13-year-old Chase

has more than earned his reputation as a bully—yet after a serious accident, he develops amnesia, forgets the forces that incentivized his bullying, and becomes a much kinder, more thoughtful person. Nevertheless, people continue to judge him by his bad reputation. For example, when Chase helps the unpopular video-club president, Brendan Espinoza, film a comedy short about driving a tricycle through a car wash, the car wash manager assumes Chase bullied Brendan into it and threatens to call the police on him. Brendan, who was responsible for the car-wash idea but has a reputation as a good kid, has to talk the manager into leaving Chase alone. Similarly, when Chase accidentally hits his former bullying victim Joel Weber while trying to protect him from other bullies, Joel and his sister Shoshanna assume Chase hit Joel on purpose. They only realize they misjudged Chase when Brendan shows them video footage proving it was an accident. By contrast, everyone assumes that elderly Korean War veteran Mr. Solway is a hero because President Truman awarded him a **Medal of Honor**, which serves as a physical symbol of his sterling reputation. Yet Mr. Solway himself denies that he's a hero: the violent act that won him the medal severely traumatized him, and he's ambivalent about the morality of war. Thus, Chase and Mr. Solway illustrate how people's reputations can conflict both with reality and with how they see themselves.



## MASCULINITY

In *Restart*, too much devotion to traditional masculinity leads to reckless and unkind behavior. It is only when characters broaden their definitions of masculine strength to include behavior beyond conventional toughness that they improve as people. The novel's paradigmatic macho man is Frank Ambrose, a former football star obsessed with the idea of his 13-year-old son Chase following in his footsteps. Frank openly, cruelly claims that his ex-wife Tina's softer parenting style turned their sensitive older son Johnny into a "wimp," and he cautions Chase not to let her do that to him too. When Chase's doctor, Dr. Cooperman, advises Chase not to play football for the rest of the season after he sustains a concussion, Frank takes Chase for a second opinion because he believes "Ambrose men" are tough, special, and deserving of athletic spotlights—recklessly ignoring that another head injury might endanger his adolescent son's long-term health. What's more, Chase's concussion has given him amnesia, which leads him to stop bullying his much younger half-sister, Frank's daughter Helene—an obviously positive development. But when Chase tries to make friends with Helene by helping her play with her dolls, Frank expresses distaste at Chase's un-macho behavior. Thus, the novel not only makes clear that pre-accident Chase was a bully but also hints that Frank's fixation on masculinity—in the form of sports stardom, physical toughness,

and the rejection of anything soft or feminine—encouraged Chase to become a bully in the first place.

Frank only realizes his own faults when Chase forces him to think about strength of *character*. When amnesiac Chase realizes he stole a **Medal of Honor** from an elderly veteran named Mr. Solway, Chase returns the medal, admits his own guilt, and refuses to implicate his accomplices, his former friends Aaron and Bear, because he feels he bears the most responsibility. Belatedly, Frank realizes that the “new” Chase—who plays dolls with Helene and cares less about playing football than doing the right thing—is a stronger person, mentally and morally, than the “old,” macho Chase. On the stand at Chase’s juvenile sentencing for stealing the medal, Frank tells everyone that Chase’s new strength of character makes him wish *he’d* had a head injury at Chase’s age—a humorous admission that nevertheless illustrates how letting go of rigid masculine ideals has improved Chase’s personality (and may improve Frank’s personality in the future).



## SOCIAL HIERARCHIES AND BULLYING

*Restart* represents social hierarchies as harmful not only because they can lead to bullying but also because they encourage people to stereotype themselves and others, thus closing off possibilities for new interests and friendships. In the novel, Hiawassee Middle School has a clear social hierarchy, and the football players sit at the top of it. This hierarchy enables bullying. The school’s star football player, Chase Ambrose, bullies musician and video-club nerd Joel Weber so badly that Joel’s parents move him to a different school, yet Chase is really only punished because his cruel antics cause the destruction of a costly piano and a mass panic at a school recital. The novel repeatedly hints that the school’s principal and other authority figures try to avoid punishing Chase because suspending the football team’s popular star player would annoy the community and hurt the school’s chances in football. Yet social hierarchies are bad for other reasons. After Chase sustains a concussion and develops amnesia, he becomes friends with video-club president Brendan Espinoza, realizes he really enjoys film, and joins the video club—a club that pre-amnesiac Chase would have automatically written off because he was a cool athlete while the video-club kids were considered “losers” and “dweebs.” When Chase stops caring about his place in the social hierarchy, he ultimately makes more friends, gains interests (he plays football *and* likes film), and expresses more of his individual potential. Thus, the novel suggests that rigid social hierarchies limit everyone—not only the bullying victims at the bottom of the hierarchy but also the bullies at the top.



## LOYALTY

While people often think of loyalty as a virtue, *Restart* suggests that loyalty can lead people to behave badly and distort their judgment. For example, when middle-school football star and popular bully Chase Ambrose develops amnesia after an accident, he loses his memory of all his football friends and thus his loyalty to them. Thus, when he sees his team’s quarterback Joey pushing around geeky video-club president Brendan Espinoza, he gets between them physically and puts a stop to the bullying. Afterwards, fellow football player Aaron Hakimian criticizes Chase’s disloyalty to Joey despite their long-term friendship—a criticism hinting that loyalty to the football team and to each other prevents the football players from intervening in one another’s bad behavior. In the same vein, Shoshanna Weber, twin sister to Chase’s former bullying victim Joel, refuses for a long time to believe that Chase’s amnesia has altered his behavior and personality, even though it clearly has, because she feels that altering her negative opinion of Chase would constitute disloyalty to her brother. It is only when Chase realizes that his loyalty to the football team encouraged his bad behavior, and when Shoshanna realizes that her loyalty to her family is distorting her judgment, that each character is able to choose the right path and clearheadedly decide what they should believe. Thus, *Restart* suggests that loyalty, unless it’s governed by moral judgment and responsive to new evidence, can actually be a vice.



## SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



## MEDAL OF HONOR

Mr. Solway’s Medal of Honor represents the gap between someone’s reputation and their sense of self. The medal first appears in the novel when 13-year-old Chase Ambrose, suffering from amnesia after a bad concussion, is doing community service for delinquent behavior he can’t even remember. Mr. Solway, who lives in the facility, has a picture of himself receiving the medal from President Truman in his room at the assisted living facility where Chase does community service. Chase, curious about history, begins pursuing a friendship with Mr. Solway. Eventually, Mr. Solway confesses to Chase that he thinks the behavior that won him the medal—opening the hatch of an enemy tank and tossing a grenade inside—was idiotically dangerous and not what he would have done if he’d had time to reflect. Moreover, he found the ensuing violence so traumatic that his brain has repressed the memory; he can’t remember the event that won him the medal. While Mr. Solway has a reputation as a brave man and a



war hero, then, that reputation doesn't accord with his sense of self.

Later, Chase learns that, prior to his amnesia-causing accident, he stole the medal from Mr. Solway's room and hid it. The theft of the medal represents everything that was negative about Chase's pre-amnesia personality, on which his bad reputation is based. When Chase learns that he stole Mr. Solway's medal, he decides that his current sense of self doesn't accord with his past destructive behavior or bad reputation. He thus decides to give the medal back. By getting rid of the medal—returning it to Mr. Solway and accepting blame for the theft—Chase addresses the gap between his reputation and his sense of self, which the medal symbolizes: he brings his outward actions into line with the person he thinks he is.

"know[s]" about his fall, he worries that he fabricated a memory of it based on second-hand knowledge. Later in the novel, amnesiac Chase will have to try to figure out who he was based on second-hand knowledge. Therefore, this quotation foreshadows the difficulty Chase has trying to tease out the objective truth from patchy memories, second-hand accounts, and other forms of subjective evidence.

☞ I note the window I must have climbed out of, since it's the only one with roof access. For some reason, I expected it to be higher, and I'm embarrassed. Like it's an insult to my manliness that such a puny fall scrambled my brains.



## QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Scholastic edition of *Restart* published in 2018.

### Chapter 1: Chase Ambrose Quotes



I remember falling.

At least I think I do. Or maybe that's just because I know I fell.

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose (speaker)

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 1

#### Explanation and Analysis

This quotation opens the novel. The protagonist, Chase Ambrose, has fallen and suffered a head injury causing amnesia. Though the quotation is brief, it reveals a lot about Chase and his preoccupations.

First, Chase may seem like an unreliable narrator because he claims to remember falling and then contradicts himself. In fact, however, he's a very honest narrator: though his knowledge is limited, he tells the truth as he sees it and corrects himself when he realizes he may have made a mistake. Later in the novel, Chase will learn that he used to be a bully, try to make amends for his past actions, and—on several occasions—have to decide whether to face punishment or lie to protect himself. Thus, Chase's fixation on correcting his mistakes and telling the truth at the very beginning of the novel foreshadows his character arc throughout.

Second, Chase is aware that the past is important but that his memory is unreliable and suggestible: though he

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose (speaker), Frank Ambrose

**Related Themes:** 

**Page Number:** 8

#### Explanation and Analysis

When Chase returns home from the hospital, he sees the window that he climbed out of before falling from his roof, and he feels "embarrassed" that "such a puny fall" gave him amnesia. This quotation reveals that Chase, though he has no memories, is an intelligent boy who still possesses certain cultural beliefs and attitudes. He proves his intelligence by immediately deducing which window he must have used based on its "roof access," and he proves that he still has cultural beliefs and attitudes in his amnesiac state by wryly suggesting that it's almost "an insult to [his] manliness" to have gotten amnesia after a short fall: if he truly remembered nothing, he wouldn't have any preconceptions about what is or isn't manly.

This is the first time Chase brings up the question of "manliness," which will be an important one throughout the novel. Chase recognizes implicitly that the definition of "manliness" he uses here—imperviousness to concussions after falls—is a little silly. When he says that this is "like" an insult to his masculinity, he's acknowledging that getting a concussion after a fall isn't really an insult to his manliness. Yet he still feels humiliated and describes the fall as "puny," which suggests that he wants to measure up to this standard of manliness he remembers, even if it's absurd.

Chase's ambivalence about stereotypical masculinity here—recognizing that some of its demands are silly but still wanting to fulfill those demands—foreshadows his complicated relationship with his demanding,

stereotypically masculine father, Frank, whose influence the novel will later reveal contributed to Chase's reckless and cruel "macho" behavior prior to his accident.

## Chapter 2: Shoshanna Weber Quotes

☹☹ I still can't figure it out. Chase isn't Darth Vader or Voldemort; he doesn't have the Force or dark magical powers. And yet he, Aaron Hakimian, and Bear Bratsky made Joel's life so miserable that my parents had no choice but to find him a school in another town.

**Related Characters:** Shoshanna Weber (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Aaron Hakimian, Joel Weber, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 14-15

### Explanation and Analysis

Chase Ambrose's classmate Shoshanna Weber is reflecting on how Chase, Aaron, and Bear bullied her twin brother, Joel Weber, so badly during his seventh-grade year that Mr. and Mrs. Weber sent him away to boarding school. The quotation reveals the implicit tensions in Shoshanna's view of Chase.

On the one hand, in trying to understand how Chase bullied her brother, Shoshanna draws on highly negative cultural figures like Darth Vader, a major villain in George Lucas's *Star Wars* franchise, and Voldemort, the head villain in J. K. Rowling's *Harry Potter* series. These comparisons imply that Shoshanna doesn't see Chase as fully human: though Darth Vader was once a good Jedi knight named Anakin Skywalker, by the time he has become Darth Vader, he constantly wears a helmet so no one can see his human face and speaks with a distorted mechanical voice. Voldemort, meanwhile, is a quasi-undead, snakelike, genocidal dark wizard.

Yet even as Shoshanna places Chase in the same category as Darth Vader and Voldemort, she acknowledges that Chase "doesn't have the Force" (the science-fictional power wielded by Jedi knights in *Star Wars*) or "dark magical powers": Chase is just an ordinary 13-year-old bully. Shoshanna's early acknowledgment that Chase isn't a one-dimensional villain—even if she's not yet ready to admit he's a full human being—foreshadows her later realization that Chase is a person capable of moral growth and change.

## Chapter 3: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☹☹ "This is an awful thing that's happened to you, but it's also presenting you with a rare opportunity. You have the chance to rebuild yourself from the ground up, to make a completely fresh start. Don't squander it! I'm sure you're not feeling very lucky, but there are millions of people who'd give anything to stand where you stand right now—in front of a completely blank canvas."

**Related Characters:** Dr. Fitzwallace (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Mr. Solway, Joel Weber

**Related Themes:**   

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 27

### Explanation and Analysis

On amnesiac Chase's first day of eighth grade, the middle-school principal Dr. Fitzwallace summons him to his office and gives him a speech about not "squander[ing]" his "completely fresh start." Dr. Fitzwallace's speech is thematically important for what it implies about identity and memory.

When he says that Chase can "rebuild [himself] from the ground up" because he has lost his memories, he's making two implicit claims. First, he's claiming that Chase's identity is based on his memory. With his memories gone, Chase's identity is like a demolished building that must be completely rebuilt "from the ground up" with new memories. Second, he's claiming that Chase's prior reputation and what other people remember about him don't affect his identity: Chase is a "completely blank canvas" because he can't remember *himself*, even if other people remember all kinds of things about him.

Over the course of the novel, both of Dr. Fitzwallace's claims will be proven false. Chase will have to take responsibility—and make amends—for his own past actions, such as bullying Joel Weber and stealing Mr. Solway's Medal of Honor. His life isn't a "blank canvas," since his past actions still affect the people all around him. Moreover, what other people think, believe, and remember about Chase matter very much to who Chase is: his identity is based partly on his relationships to other people, so he can't simply disregard his reputation or what other people think about him even when they're wrong. Dr. Fitzwallace's speech thus proposes a naïve theory of memory and identity that the novel will go about methodically disproving.

## Chapter 4: Brendan Espinoza Quotes

☞ “But where’s their leader? The apex predator? Could that be him paying for a pack of Fig Newtons at the cash register? Yes, it is—the king of beasts, Footballus herois.”

**Related Characters:** Brendan Espinoza (speaker), Chase Ambrose

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 29

### Explanation and Analysis

Video-club president Brendan Espinoza is filming various cliques in the cafeteria and commenting on them as if they were species of exotic animal in a nature documentary. When he sees Chase, he calls him the “leader” of the football players, “apex predator,” “king of beasts,” and “Footballus herois.” Brendan’s mocking commentary on Chase reveals both Chase’s status in the social hierarchy and the way that less popular kids tend to stereotype more popular kids.

Brendan’s mocking names for Chase clearly suggest that Chase was popular due to his athletic prowess—and a bully. “Apex predator” is a biological term for an animal species at the top of a food chain, one that preys on other animals but has no natural predators of its own. This description implies that Chase “preys on” other kids, but never vice versa. “King of beasts” is usually a term for lions; applied to Chase, it implies both that he occupies the highest place in the school hierarchy, like a king in a monarchy, and that he’s an animal. Finally, “Footballus herois” is a fake-Latin, fake-scientific binomial name for a “football hero.” This final description implies that Chase is the “king” of the school and capable of bullying anyone he wants because he’s a sports star. Thus, Brendan’s descriptions quickly sketch both what Chase was like before his accident and what their middle school does and doesn’t value (it values athletics; it doesn’t value kindness).

Yet by repeatedly describing Chase and other students as animals, Brendan suggests that the middle-school social hierarchy is as natural and unchanging as a stable ecosystem and that bullies are just like predators eating other animals on instinct, not human beings capable of moral choice and personal growth. The dehumanizing, animalistic stereotypes that Brendan applies to Chase show how “uncool” and bullied kids can—understandably, but mistakenly—deny the humanity of “cool” kids and bullies.

## Chapter 5: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☞ When I got amnesia, I lost thirteen years of myself. I have to replace those memories using what I can pick up from other people. But everyone has a slightly different version of me—Mom, Dad, my friends, the kids at school, even frozen yogurt girl. For all I know, the lunch ladies know me better than anyone else.

Who should I believe?

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose (speaker), Shoshanna Weber, Aaron Hakimian, Frank Ambrose, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 43

### Explanation and Analysis

After Chase learns from his friends Aaron and Bear that all three of them were sentenced to community service for blowing up a piano as a “prank,” he confronts his mother Tina about hiding his past legal troubles from him. He realizes that Aaron and Bear represented the “prank” as much funnier and less serious than Tina thinks it was, which makes him wonder: “Who should I believe?”

Chase’s question here illuminates the tense relationship between individuals’ identities, memories, and reputations. When seeking to understand their identities, people can usually take into account their present sense of self, their memories of how they’ve acted in the past, and their reputations (i.e. what other people say about them). As an amnesiac, Chase has some sense of who he is in the present but no sense of who he’s been in the past, which has destabilized his sense of self—his identity is like a three-legged chair with one of the legs removed!

Chase tries to compensate by relying more heavily on his reputation to understand his identity—but, unfortunately, “everyone has a slightly different version” of Chase in their heads: his mother thinks he’s a good kid who’s done bad things; his dad thinks he’s a tough-guy sports star; his friends think he’s a fun prankster; and “frozen yogurt girl” (Shoshanna Weber) utterly loathes him. Because Chase can’t remember any of the people who have these different opinions about him, he doesn’t have enough information to decide whose “version” he can trust. Thus, Chase’s amnesia destabilizes his identity not only by taking away his memories of the past but by hampering him in deciding whose opinion of him he can trust in the present.

## Chapter 6: Brendan Espinoza Quotes

☝ I'm blown away. My record as a nerd and goody-two-shoes never seemed like much to me before. For sure, it didn't compare to Chase's—athlete, bad boy, big man on campus. But it was my reputation, not his, that got us out of a jam back there.

**Related Characters:** Brendan Espinoza (speaker), Chase Ambrose

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 51

### Explanation and Analysis

Chase just helped Brendan Espinoza film a stunt video for YouTube, in which Brendan rides a tricycle through a car wash. The car wash manager, knowing Chase's reputation as a bully, assumed that Chase bullied Brendan into the dangerous stunt and threatened to call the police. Brendan, a "nerd and goody-two-shoes," saves Chase from legal trouble by explaining that he, Brendan, is video-club president and offering to put an ad for the car wash in the school yearbook. This short sequence of events illustrates how believing people's reputations can often lead to mistaken judgments. It also illustrates how social hierarchies relevant in one context aren't necessarily relevant in others.

Chase and Brendan have both earned their reputations: until his accident, Chase really was a "bad boy" (i.e., a bully), and Brendan really is a "nerd" (i.e., an academically inclined student). Yet when the car wash manager interprets the boys' behavior according to their reputations, he completely misunderstands what they're doing: he thinks that bully Chase forced nerd Brendan into a dangerous situation, when in fact the dangerous stunt was Brendan's idea—Brendan is willing to risk the danger because he really wants one of his videos to go viral on YouTube, something the car wash manager can't guess about him based on the broad strokes of his reputation. Thus, this scene shows that reputations can be misleading even when they're largely accurate.

The scene also shows that middle-school social hierarchies aren't relevant in every context, no matter how important they seem to middle-schoolers. In middle school, Chase is a "big man on campus," one of the most popular boys in his class, while Brendan is considered deeply uncool. Chase has a far higher social status than Brendan in the middle-school context. Yet in the adult world beyond middle school, Brendan has a higher social status than Chase because adults consider Brendan better-behaved and more trustworthy than Chase. Thus, the incident with the car-wash manager emphasizes that social status in one context,

such as middle school, doesn't necessarily translate to status in other contexts.

## Chapter 7: Shoshanna Weber Quotes

☝ Shosh466: C'mon, little bro. U were miserable at home.

JWPianoMan: At least there I was special. Here I'm just another 2nd rate piano player.

**Related Characters:** Shoshanna Weber, Joel Weber (speaker), Chase Ambrose

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 61

### Explanation and Analysis

Shoshanna is messaging her twin brother Joel, a talented piano player who currently attends a boarding school, Melton Prep and Musical Conservatory, focused on musical education. Shoshanna and Joel's parents sent Joel to Melton primarily to protect him from bullying by Chase Ambrose, but Joel seems to hate attending Melton even more than he hated his hometown middle school where he was bullied. Joel's claim that he's "special" at home but "2nd rate" at Melton illustrates how people's sense of themselves varies according to their social contexts.

In one sense, Joel was very low in his hometown middle school's social hierarchy: Chase Ambrose and other football players bullied him, and most of his classmates didn't fully appreciate his musical talent. Yet Joel's claim that he was "special" at home implies that, despite his low social status, he was still one of the best musicians in his class at home—and being one of the best conferred on him an identity that he valued. Even his messaging handle, "JWPianoMan," emphasizes how important being "the guy who plays piano" was to his identity at home.

By contrast, Joel is not "special" for being a talented piano player in the context of a boarding school for musically gifted students. Even though Joel has presumably only gotten better at piano since going to Melton, the skills that made him "special" in the context of his hometown only make him "2nd rate" relative to the other musical prodigies who attend Melton. At Melton, Joel has lost his identity: he is no longer "the guy who plays piano." With these details, then, the novel reveals that individuals' identities are based not only on their past, present, and future selves but also on their social contexts.



## Chapter 8: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☞ “That’s who we are, Champ. We’re Ambrose men. We’re the doers. Other people take pictures of us!”

**Related Characters:** Frank Ambrose (speaker), Chase Ambrose

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 65

**Explanation and Analysis**

While filming a preseason football scrimmage for video club, Chase runs into his father, Frank, who—oddly enough for an adult—follows the middle-school football team closely even when his son isn’t playing. Frank criticizes Chase for filming the scrimmage instead of playing football himself, even though Chase is recovering from a concussion and has been benched on his doctor’s orders. To appease Frank, Chase avoids mentioning his interest in film and instead simply claims he’ll play football as soon as the doctor allows. Frank responds approvingly with the above quotation, which reveals how Frank restricts Chase’s explorations of his identity by insisting that Chase adhere to his father’s narrow, athletics-focused definition of masculinity.

Frank tells Chase who he is instead of letting Chase figure it out for himself. He calls Chase “Champ”—short for “champion”—presumably because Chase’s team won the state football championship the previous year, something that only Frank’s team has done before in their hometown school’s history. This nickname suggests that Chase’s athletic success is his defining feature, the most important thing about him.

Moreover, Frank talks to Chase about who “we” are—assuming that he and Chase are functionally the same—and claims that they are “men” and “doers.” It’s strange for an adult to call an eighth-grade boy a “man;” that Frank does so betrays the importance of traditional masculinity to who he is and who he thinks Chase should be. He doesn’t value “tak[ing] pictures”—that is, film, something in which Chase has a technical and artistic interest—because it seems to him to be insufficiently active and macho.

Frank’s strident negative reaction to Chase exploring an artistic interest and his insistence on defining Chase solely as a sports star exemplify how Frank’s narrow definition of masculinity has prevented Chase from exploring his own interests and developing a personality independent from Frank’s.

## Chapter 10: Kimberly Tooley Quotes

☞ Aaron eyes Chase with a long face. “You shouldn’t have done that, man. Joey’s your friend. He’s had your back plenty of times.”

Chase is still defiant, but a little more subdued than before. “So I should just let him beat up a kid half his size for no reason?”

Aaron stands his ground. “If you’d told him to stop, he would have stopped. You didn’t have to *attack* him.” He shakes his head. “None of us are perfect—not even you. Next time, take a second to think about who your friends are.”

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose, Aaron Hakimian, Kimberly Tooley (speaker), Brendan Espinoza

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 84

**Explanation and Analysis**

When Chase sees a member of the football team, Joey, shoving and bullying his new friend Brendan Espinoza, he pushes Joey into a wall. Aaron, another football player who was one of Chase’s closest friends before his accident, criticizes Chase’s behavior in two ways: he suggests that Chase is being disloyal to Joey, and he argues that Chase’s reaction was disproportionately violent. These criticisms shed light on the dubious value of loyalty and the difficulty of responding well to bullying.

Aaron believes that Chase shouldn’t have pushed Joey because Joey has “had [Chase’s] back plenty of times” in the past—a claim that implies Chase owes loyalty to Joey even when Joey is doing something wrong, like (as Chase puts it) “beat[ing] up a kid half his size for no reason.” Though people usually think of loyalty as a positive quality, excessive loyalty to Joey in this situation might have led Chase to stand by and let Joey hurt Brendan—which clearly suggests that in some situations, loyalty leads to bad outcomes, not good ones.

When Chase “defiant[ly]” points out to Aaron that loyalty to Joey would have led to a bad outcome, Aaron shifts his criticism, claiming that Chase could have stopped the bullying using his words rather than escalating immediately to physical conflict. Readers can’t know whether Aaron is right that Joey would have stopped if Chase had asked, but it is reasonable of Aaron to point out that Chase could have *started* with words before escalating to physical conflict.

Aaron may have bad motives for criticizing Chase here—later events suggest that he wants Chase to return to his pre-amnesia, bullying self—and his claim that Chase should “think about who [his] friends are” implies that he is

still hung up on the question of Chase's loyalty. Yet some of his criticism is legitimate, showing how difficult it is for adolescents to respond to bullying like Joey's in the moment without resorting to bullying tactics themselves.

in fact, he tends to use his smarts to rationalize—and get away with—his bad behavior. Readers may infer that Chase before his accident was something like Bear: a smart kid who used his good qualities for bad ends.

## Chapter 11: Aaron Hakimian Quotes

☝ I get that his memory is erased. But is our whole friendship erased too? Being boys with someone isn't just a bunch of stuff you did together in the past. There has to be more to it than that! But right now, it's like we've got zero in common with the guy.

**Related Characters:** Aaron Hakimian (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Brendan Espinoza, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 87-88

### Explanation and Analysis

After Chase saves Brendan from a football player who is bullying him, Aaron broods on whether Chase is still his and Bear's friend. Aaron's thoughts explore the relationship between memory and friendship; they also show how an intelligent, sensitive kid like Chase could become a bully—as Aaron is a bully who shows surprising intelligence and emotional depth in this quotation.

Aaron wonders what it means to be someone's friend: he wants it to be "more" than "just a bunch of stuff you did together in the past"—that is, more than shared memories. Yet—even though he believes friendship ought to be more than shared memories—he feels that he and Bear have "zero in common" with Chase anymore. Aaron's tortured questioning suggests that, in fact, memories aren't enough to sustain a friendship: to stay friends with someone, you need to share something "in common" in the present as well as sharing a past. This suggestion foreshadows the end of Aaron and Bear's friendship with Chase: the three boys do share a past, but Chase is different from Aaron and Bear in the present and doesn't want to be like them in the future.

Up to this point in the book, Chase has seemed like a thoughtful and intelligent kid, albeit one vulnerable to peer pressure, whereas Aaron and Bear have seemed like shallow, callous jerks. Yet in this scene, Aaron's internal questioning of what it means to be someone's friend and his obvious grief over losing Chase's friendship reveal that he, too, has brains and a complex emotional life. Notably, however, brains and a complex emotional life don't stop Aaron from bullying kids and pulling mean pranks with Bear;

## Chapter 12: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☝ "They're always the enemy when they're shooting at you, kid. But a dead man doesn't care what uniform he's wearing. I'm better off forgetting the whole rotten business, medal and all."

**Related Characters:** Mr. Solway (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Aaron Hakimian, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:**  

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 97

### Explanation and Analysis

Chase has struck up a friendship with Mr. Solway, a veteran of the Korean War (1950-1953) living in the assisted living facility where Chase, Aaron, and Bear were sentenced to do community service. Mr. Solway won a Medal of Honor—the highest military decoration in the United States—for single-handedly killing a tankful of enemy soldiers with a grenade, but he found the violence so traumatic that he has repressed the memory. When Chase tries to comfort him by reminding him that the men he killed were enemies, Mr. Solway refuses the comfort and calls the war a "rotten business." Mr. Solway's attitude toward war and his own medal serve to criticize both traditional masculine values and the concept of a good reputation.

Traditionally, bravery during wartime is considered a masculine virtue. Men, like Mr. Solway, who risk great danger to kill enemy soldiers are considered heroes. Yet Mr. Solway rejects these traditional assumptions: when he says that "a dead man doesn't care what uniform he's wearing," he implies that the enemies he killed were fellow human beings not reducible to their "uniform"—that is, the side they fought for. Ergo, killing them isn't something to be celebrated—even if killing them required bravery, and even if he had to kill them because they were "shooting at" him.

Because Mr. Solway rejects wartime bravery as a false value, he also rejects the reputation he has earned as a "war hero"—a reputation physically symbolized by the Medal of Honor he received for his brave wartime actions. Thus, although the Medal represents Mr. Solway's good reputation, it also represents the gap between his

reputation and how he sees himself.

## Chapter 13: Shoshanna Weber Quotes

☞ That's how I always looked at it. We are who we are, and we're good with it. I figured the others felt the same way. Who cares what the popular kids think of us?

Was I ever wrong about that! As soon as someone from the A-list showed even the slightest interest in video club, we all went weak in the knees and lined up to love him.

**Related Characters:** Shoshanna Weber (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Brendan Espinoza, Joel Weber

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 102

### Explanation and Analysis

Shoshanna is angry that Brendan and the other video-club kids have warmed up to Chase, even though Chase bullied many of them in the past—and bullied Shoshanna's twin brother Joel so badly that their parents sent him away to boarding school. Her angry thoughts reveal that social hierarchies are more complicated than a simple ladder, with some people on the top and others on the bottom; they also reveal that her loyalty to Joel is clouding her judgment about Chase, Brendan, and the other video-club kids.

Though people often think of social hierarchies as fixed ladders, Shoshanna's rhetorical question—"Who cares what the popular kids think of us?"—reveals that participants in a given social sphere can subvert its hierarchies by refusing to accept the values by which the hierarchy is ordered. Shoshanna and the other video club kids can be "good with" themselves and recognize their own talents even if their wider social sphere, Hiawassee Middle School, doesn't see those talents as valuable. When video club kids assert their own values, they deny that they should be considered lower status than "popular kids" whose talents they don't value and whose values they don't share. Thus, even when social hierarchies seem fixed, they can be contested.

Yet Shoshanna is wrong to assume that the video club kids are accepting values they claimed to disdain by becoming friends with "someone from the A list," i.e., Chase. She is being an unreliable narrator when she claims that the club "went weak in the knees and lined up to love him" immediately upon his joining the club. In fact, all the video club kids except Brendan wanted to exclude Chase—their faculty advisor had to inform them that the school rules required them to accept him. It was only after interacting

with Chase and realizing that he was conforming to the video club's own values—kindness, diligence, an interest in film—that the other club members began to accept him. Readers can infer that Shoshanna's anger at Chase and loyalty to her brother Joel, whom Chase bullied, are distorting her judgment and rendering her an unreliable narrator.

## Chapter 14: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☞ "I never wore it. Not that I was ashamed of it, but it didn't feel right—like I'd be saying, 'Look how great I am. I've got a better medal than you. Any dimwit can win a Purple Heart.'"

**Related Characters:** Mr. Solway (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Shoshanna Weber

**Related Themes:**  

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 119

### Explanation and Analysis

Through an unexpected series of events, Chase and Shoshanna are now collaborating to interview decorated Korean War veteran Mr. Solway for the National Video Journalism Contest. Shoshanna finds the empty box that used to contain Mr. Solway's Medal of Honor and, after failing to unearth the medal elsewhere in Mr. Solway's closet, asks when Mr. Solway last wore the medal. Mr. Solway admits that he "never wore it" because doing so "didn't feel right." This admission reveals that Mr. Solway rejects not only his reputation as a war hero but the social hierarchy that that reputation seems to set up.

Mr. Solway has already told Chase that his reputation for heroism in war—physically symbolized by the Medal of Honor he was awarded—doesn't accord with his sense of self. He thinks the action for which he won the medal was arguably stupid and, furthermore, he can't even remember it because it was so traumatically violent. Here, he clarifies that he's not "ashamed" of the medal or his reputation even if he doesn't believe they're deserved, which implies that he thinks violence is legitimate (even if regrettable) during wartime—so it isn't shame over the lives he took that prevents him from wearing the medal.

Rather, Mr. Solway believes that wearing his medal would be a way of asserting his higher social status relative to other veterans who had won Purple Hearts—the military decoration for members of the U.S. military who are

wounded or killed while serving—or other medals more common than the Medal of Honor (which is the rarest U.S. military decoration). By implication, Mr. Solway doesn't believe in trying to enforce social hierarchies among groups like veterans, people bound together by shared service or shared traumatic experiences.

## Chapter 16: Shoshanna Weber Quotes

☞ “I don't know if he's changed and I don't care. The person he was broke up this family. What he did to Joel is unforgivable. That means he can never be forgiven.”

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose, Shoshanna Weber, Joel Weber

**Related Themes:** 

**Page Number:** 135

### Explanation and Analysis

Shoshanna and Joel's parents have just discovered that Shoshanna is working with Joel's former bully Chase for the National Video Journalism Contest. They immediately stage an intervention forbidding Shoshanna from becoming friendly with Chase. When Shoshanna points out that Chase's personality has changed dramatically since his amnesia-causing head injury, Shoshanna's mother, Mrs. Weber, denies that any personal growth on Chase's part is relevant: “he can never be forgiven” because “the person he was broke up this family.”

Chase is a former bully who, after getting amnesia, can't remember his bullying and no longer wants to bully. This situation poses questions about identity and responsibility: is it fair to define Chase according to past actions he can't remember and wouldn't endorse in the present? When judging Chase, should people focus on his past self, his present self, or his future potential?

Here, Mrs. Weber takes the harsh position that certain actions are so “unforgivable” that they permanently define the person who commits them. She doesn't “care” whether Chase has changed because—to her—he will always be the person who bullied her son Joel so badly that Joel had to leave town. In this view, a person's past is sometimes all that matters, because that person's present and future actions can never change what that person has already done. Despite Mrs. Weber's harshness here, however, she seems to forgive Chase provisionally when Joel is able to come home from boarding school because Chase no longer poses a threat to him—which implies that neither the novel nor

(ultimately) Mrs. Weber herself endorses what she says here.

## Chapter 17: Joel Weber Quotes

☞ There's something about being bullied that you could never explain to someone who hasn't had it happen to them. It's worse than the sum of the rotten things that are done to you. Even when no one is bothering you, you're still under attack because you're dreading the next strike, and you know it can come from anywhere, at any time.

**Related Characters:** Joel Weber (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Shoshanna Weber

**Related Themes:** 

**Page Number:** 139

### Explanation and Analysis

Joel has transferred back to his hometown school, Hiawassee Middle School, from Melton because Shoshanna has convinced their parents that Chase is no longer a threat to him. Although Shoshanna has reassured Joel that Chase has changed dramatically after his amnesia-causing fall, Joel is still anxious about seeing him again. This quotation reveals how harmful bullying can be—and emphasizes to the reader that Chase has some genuinely bad things to atone for.

Joel reveals how damaging being bullied was to him in two main ways. First, he says that “you could never explain to someone who hasn't had it happen to them” how bad being bullied is, which warns readers who haven't been bullied that they may not fully understand his pain even when he describes it. Then he goes on to explain that bullying victims are always “under attack” even when no one is currently hurting them because they are constantly terrified, anticipating the next awful thing to be inflicted on them. This terrified hyper-vigilance, Joel suggests, is what makes being bullied “worse than the sum of the rotten things” that bullies inflict on their victims.

Joel's perspective is important because it makes clear that Chase, prior to his accident, wasn't just engaged in harmless pranks: he was really hurting the people he bullied, psychologically as well as physically. Readers may understandably be sympathetic to Chase because they have access to his perspective and know that he no longer wants to bully anyone—but this quotation emphasizes that even if readers are sympathetic to Chase, they shouldn't excuse or minimize how he acted before his accident.



## Chapter 18: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☞ I guess having the power to torture another person made us feel like big men. Especially when we picked somebody smaller and weaker, who was into music instead of sports.

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose (speaker), Brendan Espinoza, Aaron Hakimian, Joel Weber, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 148

**Explanation and Analysis**

Chase has just asked Brendan how bad the bullying he inflicted on other kids really was. When Brendan tells him, Chase is horrified—both by Brendan’s matter-of-fact account of Chase’s past cruelty and by the fearful way Joel Weber looked at him upon returning to Hiawassee Middle School. Trying to understand why he, Aaron, and Bear committed such cruel acts of bullying, Chase speculates that it made them “feel like big men,” especially when their victims were “into music instead of sports.” These speculations suggest that a problematic masculine ideal, based in violence, domination, and dislike of femininity, may have motivated some of Chase, Aaron, and Bear’s behavior.

When Chase speculates that “having the power to torture another person” may have made him and his accomplices in bullying “feel like big men,” he’s suggesting that they believed masculinity requires violent physical domination of others—or at least the ability to dominate others violently and physically if you want to. He suggests that they may have felt particularly masculine when bullying Joel Weber because Joel likes “music instead of sports,” which suggests that the bullies’ view of masculinity involved policing the masculinity of other boys—attacking the ones less interested in traditionally masculine pursuits like athletics and more interested in supposedly feminine pursuits like playing piano.

Thus, while Chase is not condemning masculinity per se, he is arguing that a rigid, intolerant view of masculinity as powerful, violent, and hostile to anything feminine may have contributed to his horrible behavior before his accident.

## Chapter 20: Brendan Espinoza Quotes

☞ That’s when it hits me how this must seem to the teachers. The music room is a disaster area. Instruments, music stands, books, and papers are strewn everywhere, the whole place buried in foam. The school’s three most notorious bullies are right there. One of them—Chase—still wields a fire extinguisher. And their number one target—Joel—is down on the floor with a rapidly swelling face, obviously the victim of an assault.

“It isn’t what it looks like!” I gasp, and then bite my tongue. What if it’s *exactly* what it looks like?

**Related Characters:** Brendan Espinoza (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Aaron Hakimian, Joel Weber, Bear Bratsky, Kimberly Tooley

**Related Themes:**   

**Page Number:** 166

**Explanation and Analysis**

Aaron and Bear burst into the music room while Brendan, Joel, and Kimberly were filming a video and sprayed them with fire extinguishers. They claimed Chase had sent them; after Kimberly ran to get Chase, Chase fought with Bear over one of the fire extinguishers and accidentally hit Joel in the face with it. When teachers arrive on the scene, Brendan knows that the teachers will blame Chase as well as Aaron and Bear—and while he initially tries to defend his new friend, he immediately has doubts about Chase’s involvement. This quotation emphasizes how hard it will be for Chase to change his reputation as a bully while complicating the novel’s portrayal of loyalty.

Though Brendan doesn’t know it for sure, Chase is, in fact, innocent: he didn’t send Aaron or Bear to harass the video-club kids, and he hit Joel by accident. Yet he, Aaron, and Bear have more than earned their reputation as “notorious bullies” due to their persecution of “their number one target” Joel (as well as other lower-status kids). At first, Brendan does assume that “it isn’t what it looks like”—that Chase didn’t participate in Aaron and Bear’s bullying this time—but while he tries to correct the snap judgment teachers are likely to make due to Chase’s reputation, he himself also wonders whether that reputation isn’t still true. Brendan was the first of Chase’s former victims to see his personality changes and befriend him, so his distrust of Chase here emphasizes how hard it will be for Chase to alter his reputation and get people to trust him fully.

Brendan’s reaction complicates the novel’s portrayal of loyalty. The novel largely portrays loyalty as a negative attribute, in that it distorts characters’ judgments and

prevents them from seeing the truth about each other. Yet in this case, Brendan's initial, loyal reaction is correct: Chase really isn't a bully. This wrinkle in the novel's portrayal of loyalty suggests that loyalty can sometimes be a good thing—but only insofar as you have legitimate reasons to be loyal to a given person, as Brendan has legitimate reasons to be loyal to Chase now that Chase has changed.

## Chapter 21: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☞ Dad says the old Chase is back. I wanted that once. But right now the new Chase is the life I'd rather have.

And I've lost that too.

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose (speaker), Shoshanna Weber, Brendan Espinoza, Mr. Solway, Aaron Hakimian, Joel Weber, Frank Ambrose, Bear Bratsky, Dr. Fitzwallace

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 178

### Explanation and Analysis

When Chase, Aaron, and Bear are called into principal Dr. Fitzwallace's office, Chase backs up Aaron's lies about why Aaron and Bear sprayed Brendan and Joel with fire extinguishers. Chase only lies because he doesn't want to be punished for something he really didn't do—but everyone believes that if he's willing to lie for Aaron and Bear, he must have collaborated in their bullying after all. After his father Frank drives him home from school, Chase sits on the roof and contemplates having "lost" the "new Chase" he was constructing after his accident.

This scene is important because it reveals who Chase really wants to be. Up to this point, as an amnesiac, Chase has wanted a stable identity and has sought it in two places: with Frank, Aaron, Bear, and the football team on the one hand, and with Brendan, Shoshanna, Mr. Solway, and the video club on the other. He associates the former with the "old Chase" and the latter with the "new Chase," but he didn't seem sure which one he wanted to be—or whether he even had to choose between them.

When Aaron and Bear start bullying the video club kids again, it makes clear that Chase has to make some choices between the "old" and the "new" Chase—and that he would rather have chosen the video club kids, the bullying victims, rather than Aaron and Bear, the bullies. Unfortunately, he believes he has "lost" that option because his lie to Dr. Fitzwallace has made his video-club friends believe he's still a bully too.

## Chapter 22: Shoshanna Weber Quotes

☞ "He's like a cobra. He lured us in until we trusted him. Then he struck. And now he's slithered back to his old life as if nothing ever happened."

**Related Characters:** Shoshanna Weber (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Brendan Espinoza, Aaron Hakimian, Joel Weber, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:**   

**Page Number:** 182

### Explanation and Analysis

When Brendan tries to convince Shoshanna that Chase may not have intentionally participated in Aaron and Bear's renewed bullying of Joel, Shoshanna refuses to believe him: she compares Chase to a "cobra" that lulls its prey into a false sense of security, strikes, and "slither[s]" away. This comparison reveals that Shoshanna stereotypes popular kids and bullies much in the same way they stereotype her. By comparing Chase to a predatory animal, Shoshanna suggests that his bullying is natural, instinctive, and incapable of change—effectively, she is not only stereotyping him but also dehumanizing him by arguing that he is too set in his ways to ever improve as a person.

Shoshanna's over-the-top comparison of Chase to a "cobra" emphasizes yet again that her loyalty to Joel distorts her thinking. Brendan has raised several reasonable doubts about Chase's participation in the bullying, but Shoshanna refuses to listen to them because she feels guilty for telling her parents to bring Joel home and because (implicitly) she thinks that even considering Chase's innocence would be disloyal to her brother and her family.

## Chapter 23: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☞ It's no problem escaping Aaron and Bear. But I'll never be able to get away from myself.

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose (speaker), Mr. Solway, Aaron Hakimian, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:**  

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 191

### Explanation and Analysis

Aaron has just revealed to Chase that Chase, just prior to his accident, stole Mr. Solway's Medal of Honor. He, Aaron, and Bear were planning to sell the medal and split the proceeds. Chase is horrified, for obvious reasons: he has just learned that he used to be the kind of person who would steal a veteran's military medal and that he has stolen specifically from Mr. Solway, a friend Chase deeply admires.

Chase's claim that he will "never be able to get away from [him]self" suggests that, in his horror, he has come to accept the harsh take on personal growth that Mrs. Weber suggested earlier: namely, some actions are so bad that they permanently define the individual who commits them. In this view, the theft that pre-accident Chase committed is so bad that post-accident Chase will never be able to "get away from" or move past the version of himself that engineered the theft.

Previously, the Medal of Honor has symbolized the gap between how Mr. Solway thinks of himself and his reputation as a war hero. Once the novel reveals that Chase stole the medal before his accident, however, the medal takes on additional symbolic meaning: it comes to represent the gap between amnesiac Chase's sense of self and his well-earned reputation as a troublemaker, the sort of boy who would steal from an elderly veteran.

## Chapter 25: Chase Ambrose Quotes

💡 Maybe it'll come back to me in bits and pieces like some of my past. But when? It could take *years*. What if Mr. Solway dies in the meantime? How will I ever make it right?

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose (speaker), Mr. Solway, Aaron Hakimian, Joel Weber, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:** 

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 200

### Explanation and Analysis

Chase now knows that prior to his amnesia-causing accident, he stole Mr. Solway's Medal of Honor—but he can no longer remember where he put it. He's terrified that if he waits until his memory comes back, elderly Mr. Solway will already be dead by the time he remembers.

Prior to this point, Chase has distanced himself from his earlier identity as a bully and troublemaker by ceasing to engage in the relevant behaviors: he stopped hurting other kids, stopped participating in his friends Aaron and Bear's

cruel taunting of seniors at the assisted living facility, and so forth. While he did apologize to his former bullying victim Joel Weber, he hasn't done much else to make active amends for his past offenses.

By asking himself, "How will I ever make this right?", Chase's character develops in an important way. He has implicitly realized that to change his identity from bully and troublemaker to "good kid," he needs not only to stop doing damage but to repair the damage he's already done. While he worries that repairing the damage may be impossible—for example, if Mr. Solway dies before Chase finds the medal—he is still thinking about how to take active control of the situation. If the medal represents the gap between Chase's well-earned reputation and how he sees himself in the present, then, returning the medal to Mr. Solway and making amends for his past theft will be one way of narrowing that gap.

## Chapter 26: Joel Weber Quotes

💡 It's hard to watch, but it's not as hard as I thought it would be. *This is not who I am*, I tell myself. *It's just something that happened to me*. Somehow, seeing it unfold in real time, in high-definition video, I'm able to expand the fracas in the band room to include every rotten bullying thing that was ever done to me. And here I am, alive, undamaged—well, except my eye.

*I've been victimized, but I don't have to let that define me as a victim.*

I'm back—back at home and back to myself.

**Related Characters:** Joel Weber (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Brendan Espinoza, Aaron Hakimian, Bear Bratsky

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 212

### Explanation and Analysis

Brendan has discovered footage of Aaron and Bear's attack on the music room that proves Chase hit Joel in the face accidentally. When he screens it for the video club kids, Joel finds watching himself be physically victimized unexpectedly empowering—a culmination of Joel's character development from bullying victim to brave, proud musician.

Up to this point, Joel has allowed other people and his context to define him. For example, although he's an excellent piano player, he allows the context of Melton Prep and Musical Conservatory to convince him that he's mediocre simply because he's surrounded by other talented

kids. Additionally, he doesn't protest being sent away from Hiawassee Middle School because Aaron, Bear, and Chase's bullying has convinced him that "bullying victim" is his identity—and all he can do about it is flee his bullies.

By watching Aaron and Bear bully him through a camera's neutral viewpoint—"in real time, in high-definition video"—Joel is able to step outside of his own narrow, terrified, psychologically embattled perspective. This distance allows him, despite his terror, to separate his negative subjective experiences of bullying from his more objective judgments about his life and his identity. By realizing that victimhood doesn't "define" him, Joel feels like he has come "back to [him]self"—back to the identity he had before the bullying made him feel like a different person.

## Chapter 28: Shoshanna Weber Quotes

☞ "It was the old you!" Brendan mumbles around a rapidly swelling jaw.

"There's only one me." Chase says it so quietly that I can hardly hear him.

**Related Characters:** Chase Ambrose, Shoshanna Weber, Brendan Espinoza (speaker), Mr. Solway

**Related Themes:**  

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 223

### Explanation and Analysis

Chase has just returned Mr. Solway's stolen Medal of Honor and confessed to stealing it prior to his amnesia-causing accident. Brendan, seeing Chase's guilt and shame, tries to comfort Chase by saying that the theft was the work of the "old" Chase. In response, Chase denies that there are two versions of him: "there's only one" Chase Ambrose.

Prior to this point, Chase has frequently thought of himself before his accident as the "old Chase" and his present, amnesiac self as the "new Chase"—as if they were different versions of him or perhaps entirely different people. By asserting that the old, "bad" Chase and his current self are the same person, Chase takes full responsibility for righting the wrongs that he committed in the past—a mature gesture illustrating how much he has grown since his accident.

The Medal of Honor symbolizes the gap between characters' reputations and how those characters see themselves. By claiming that "old Chase" and "new Chase"

are the same person, Chase is implicitly admitting that he deserves to suffer under the bad reputation he earned prior to his accident—and yet, ironically, he proves yet again that his bad reputation and his current identity are mismatched precisely by returning the medal and taking responsibility for its theft. Thus, this important plot point also reinforces the symbolism surrounding the medal.

## Chapter 29: Chase Ambrose Quotes

☞ "I just didn't know the new you yet. It takes strength to eat the blame and not rat out Aaron and Bear, especially when they more than deserve it. Or to try to make things right with Solway or even the Weber kid, whether they appreciate it or not. You're strong, all right."

**Related Characters:** Frank Ambrose (speaker), Chase Ambrose, Mr. Solway, Aaron Hakimian, Joel Weber, Bear Bratsky, Helene

**Related Themes:**  

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 228

### Explanation and Analysis

Chase is waiting to attend a juvenile court hearing at which he will be tried for stealing Mr. Solway's Medal of Honor. While he waits, he has a conversation with his father about his decision to return the medal and confess to the theft. Prior to this point in the novel, Frank has expressed a clear preference for the "old" version of Chase, hounding his son to return to football and expressing distaste for his new, un-macho behaviors like joining video club and playing dolls with his little half-sister Helene.

At this point, however, Frank finally realizes that the "new," amnesiac Chase has been displaying the kind of masculine strength that Frank values—just not in the physical, athletic way that Frank expects. As Frank says, "[i]t takes strength"—that is, courage and a firm sense of right and wrong—to take full responsibility for one's past negative actions and try to make amends for them. Since Chase wants his father's approval—and since Frank's obsession with masculine strength implicitly motivated some of Chase's past bullying—Frank's admission toward the end of the novel that Chase can demonstrate strength without being an athlete or a bully suggests that Chase will have much better family support than he used to in maintaining his improved personality going forward.



## SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

## CHAPTER 1: CHASE AMBROSE

Chase remembers falling—but he wonders whether he only *thinks* he remembers it because he knows it happened. When he wakes up, someone demands a doctor. Blinking, he sees a dark-haired woman break down crying. A young man (Johnny) comforts her. A doctor appears and asks Chase how he's feeling. Chase, sore and confused, asks who the people in the room are. When the woman, shocked, calls him "Chase" and identifies herself as his mom, he realizes he can't remember anything. He asks whether he's Chase and demands a mirror. His mom gives him her mirrored compact; he doesn't recognize his reflection.

The doctor tells Chase he has amnesia caused by a fall from his roof. Chase wonders why he can remember the word "amnesia" but nothing about himself or why he was on the roof. The young man, Johnny, Chase's college-aged older brother, explains that Chase often climbs through his bedroom window onto the roof. When Chase asks whether anyone warned him of the danger, his mom says she did for years, but she gave up because nothing bad happened and he was "such an athlete."

The doctor explains that amnesia comes in many forms; Chase's amnesia has taken only his identity and memories. When Chase sarcastically calls himself "lucky," the doctor points out that at least he remembers how to care for himself—he won't need toilet training. Chase admits to himself that that is lucky; he doesn't want to know how his bathroom needs were handled during his four-day coma.

When the doctor asks whether Chase can remember anything, Chase concentrates—and recalls an approximately four-year-old girl in a lacy dress. His mom asks whether it's Helene. When Chase asks who Helene is, Johnny explains that she's their half-sister. The doctor asks whether Chase and Helene are close, and Chase's mom points out that Chase's dad (Frank) has only come to the hospital once, during which time he yelled and hit the ER wall. This is characteristic of Chase's relationship to her former husband and "his new family."

*Without his memories, Chase can't recognize himself in a mirror—an inability that underscores the importance of memories to identity. Yet, while memory is important, it can be untrustworthy: Chase thinks he may have fabricated a memory of his fall just because he knows it happened.*



*Chase has some impersonal, factual knowledge—he can speak and knows the definitions of various words, for example—but no knowledge of himself or his motivations, and this foreshadows a journey of self-discovery as he tries to understand his past self. Here, readers learn that Chase's mom has tried and failed to control Chase's behavior in the past, in part because he was "such an athlete," hinting that the social status athleticism confers on boys like Chase may have made him harder to discipline.*



*Chase's acknowledgment that he doesn't want to know how the hospital dealt with his bodily functions during his coma is humorous—yet it may also hint that there are other events in Chase's past he won't want to remember.*



*Chase's mom talks about Chase's dad's "new" family as if she, Johnny, and Chase are an "old" model of car that Chase's dad traded in. This phrasing implies that she resents Chase's dad. The behavior she attributes to him—yelling and punching walls in moments of stress, not visiting his comatose son—reveals that he adheres to an aggressive, emotionally closed-off model of masculinity.*





Chase says he doesn't remember Helene, but the girl was blond. His mom says Helene is a brunette. When Chase asks the doctor whether he's "crazy," the doctor replies that Chase's ability to remember the girl means Chase's "access" to his memory is offline, but his memories still exist; some should return. He asks Chase to try to remember more about the girl. Dr. Cooperman determines Chase has only a concussion and a shoulder injury. When Chase's mom drives him home, he sees the window that opens onto the roof. It's lower than he'd have guessed; he thinks wryly that that feels like "an insult to [his] manliness."

*The doctor's assurance that Chase will regain "access" to his memories and his recommendation that Chase try to recall the little blond girl both foreshadow that remembering more about the blond girl will be important to Chase's character arc later. Chase's half-joking thought that the low window is "an insult to [his] manliness" shows that he implicitly believes cultural ideas about boys needing to be physically tough but also acknowledges that they can be taken to ridiculous extremes—e.g. thinking it's unmanly to sustain a concussion after falling off a roof.*



When they enter the house, people inside yell "surprise." A stocky man grabs Chase and gives him a noogie. Chase's mom, horrified, tells the man (whom she calls Frank) that Chase has a concussion. The man (who calls Chase's mom Tina) retorts that Chase is an "all-county running back." Johnny (who calls Frank "Dad") points out that the doctor said Chase couldn't play football this year. In response, Chase's dad insults the doctor for being skinny and tells Tina not to make Chase "a wimp" like Johnny.

*Frank gives Chase a noogie even though Chase has a concussion, refers to Chase's status as an "all-county running back" as if prowess in football makes one immune to head injuries, and calls his own son Johnny "a wimp"—behaviors suggesting recklessness about physical safety and an excessive investment in sports and traditional masculine toughness.*



Tina demands to know why Frank came, when she's already asked him not to use his keys. Frank retorts that he pays the mortgage and says he wanted to see "the conquering hero." Chase denies that he's a hero; Frank's boldness discomfits him. He's introduced to Frank's wife Corinne and their daughter Helene. Noticing that they seem uneasy, he wonders what he "ever did to them." Tina demands that Frank leave so Chase can rest. As Frank, Corinne, and Helene leave, Chase compliments Helene's doll; she recoils in fear.

*Frank calls Chase a "conquering hero," indicating that he prefers to see his adolescent son as an idealized masculine victor rather than a physically vulnerable, injured boy. Chase's worry about what he "ever did to" Corinne and Helene, combined with Helene's fear of him, may hint that Chase has had negative interactions with his father's second family he can't now remember.*



Tina leads Chase up to his room. When she sees him notice a big crack in his door, she says she likely shouldn't have let him and his friends play sports in the house. Inside his room, he finds trophies, newspaper clippings about his football victories, and a cracked cell phone without charge. He finds a charger and plugs the phone in. When it comes alive, he sees the home screen is a selfie of him with two other large boys on Halloween; he's holding a "mangled" jack-o'-lantern on the tip of a bat and looking pleased with himself. He wonders: "What kind of person am I?"

*When Tina says she shouldn't have let Chase and his friends play sports in the house, the novel again hints that Tina has found adolescent Chase difficult to parent in part due to his masculine athleticism. When Chase wonders, "What kind of person am I?" after looking at a photo of himself apparently smashing pumpkins on Halloween, it highlights that Chase—lacking memories about himself—will have to use external evidence like photos and other people's testimonies to reconstruct his identity.*



## CHAPTER 2: SHOSHANNA WEBER

Shoshanna messages her twin, Joel, to let him know that “Alpha Rat” (Chase) fell off his roof and just left the hospital. When Joel asks whether “Beta and Gamma Rats” fell too, Shoshanna tells him not to be “greedy” but asks whether he’s happy. His muted response worries her enough that she calls him. When he answers, she asks whether his time at Melton Prep and Musical Conservatory is improving. He calls it “exile,” and Shoshanna privately agrees—even though her brother’s musically talented, he would be entering eighth grade with her in their hometown, Hiawasse, “if it weren’t for what happened.”

Shoshanna asks about the other Melton students. Joel replies that he’s unlikely to be bullied because all the Melton kids are “losers” like him. When Shoshanna protests that kids end up at Melton due to their skills, Joel retorts that he’s at Melton because of Chase, not because of his skill at the piano.

Shoshanna agrees: Chase and his friends Aaron Hakimian and Bear Bratsky bullied Joel relentlessly enough that her and Joel’s parents sent Joel away. The principal Dr. Fitzwallace tried to punish Chase, but the school board mitigated the punishment because (Shoshanna speculates) Chase is “the town sports hero—and the son of the last town sports hero.” The one real punishment he, Aaron, and Bear got was community service for hiding cherry bombs inside Joel’s piano during a recital, and that was only because they damaged the instrument. Sometimes Shoshanna thinks about pushing Chase off a roof—but she wouldn’t, because she’s superior to Chase.

The day before school starts, Shoshanna’s parents always take her and Joel to a frozen yogurt shop called Heaven on Ice. Shoshanna doesn’t want to go without Joel, but her dad pressures her into it. At the shop, after getting her frozen yogurt, Shoshanna spots Chase wearing a sling. When he sees her glaring at him, he gives her “a shy smile.” She’s so incensed that she yells about his “nerve,” upends her frozen yogurt on his head, and storms outside. She’s especially furious because Chase looked at her like he didn’t recognize her, after everything he did to Joel.

*Shoshanna and Joel call Chase “Alpha Rat,” a nickname that reveals both their dislike of him and their belief that he’s an animal who acts on instinct and is incapable of personal change. Context suggests that “Beta and Gamma Rats” are friends of Chase’s, perhaps the boys in the Halloween photo. Joel’s belief that he’s in “exile” and Shoshanna’s musings about “what happened”—together with the twins’ hatred of Chase—hint that Chase may somehow bear responsibility for Joel enrolling in a prep school.*



*Joel derisively refers to himself and other talented young musicians as “losers,” implying that he may have been bullied for his interest in piano and may have internalized the cruel things bullies said about him. That he blames Chase for his “exile” at Melton implies, in turn, that Chase was one of his bullies.*



*Chase wondered uneasily what kind of person he was when he saw a photograph of himself gloating over a Halloween pumpkin that he and his friends had mangled. Shoshanna’s thoughts reveal that before Chase’s accident, he was a bully—but given amnesiac Chase’s unease at the thought of Halloween mayhem, it’s possible he won’t want to be a bully anymore. Chase got away with bullying because he and his father had “sports hero” status, which indicates that the town values traditional masculine attributes like physical prowess so highly that they are willing to overlook cruel behavior in high-status men who are good at sports.*



*Amnesiac Chase’s “shy smile” shows that he’s willing to be friendly to Shoshanna. Shoshanna, unaware of Chase’s amnesia, misinterprets his smile as “nerve”—a callous indifference to the history between him and Shoshanna’s family. This incident indicates that Chase’s pre-accident actions will shape how people react to him, even though he doesn’t remember any of said actions.*



## CHAPTER 3: CHASE AMBROSE

Tina drives Chase to his first day of eighth grade. They're alone (Johnny has gone back to college). Chase is troubled because when he told Tina about a girl (Shoshanna) dumping frozen yogurt on his head, Tina downplayed the event's importance and claimed not to know what girl would have done that—but Chase thinks Tina does know. As Tina pauses the car in front of the school, Chase asks her to tell him whatever she hasn't been saying. Tina, turning bright red, tells him he's likely to hear "good and bad" stories about his past, and he should just stay calm.

*Tina's claim that Chase will hear "good and bad" things about himself at school indicates that he has a good reputation with some people and a bad one with others, which may make it harder for him to discover what he was really like before his accident. Her warning that he should stay calm hints that some of his past actions may upset him now that he has amnesia—implying a split between the person Chase is at his core and the person that context conditioned him to be.*



As Chase enters the school, he notices some students giving him funny looks, which he attributes to his visible injuries. Soon, large boys surround Chase, slapping his back despite his injured shoulder. Chase identifies two of them as the boys in his cell phone background, whom Tina explained were his friends Aaron and Bear. When one boy asks whether Chase will have healed in time for their first football game, Chase says he can't play; the doctor doesn't want him risking head injuries during recovery. Several of the boys voice disappointment and disagreement.

*The other football players casually strike Chase's injured shoulder and suggest he should play football against his doctor's orders; these actions show that they, like Frank, value stereotypical masculine toughness over prudence. Aaron and Bear participated in Chase's Halloween antics and, per Shoshanna, his bullying of Joel—but it isn't clear whether their friendship led pre-accident Chase down a bad path or vice versa.*



Aaron tells the other boys to stop; they should know that sometimes football players get injured. He and Bear pull Chase away down a crowded hallway—shoving students out of the way as they go. They come to a bench occupied by a sixth grader. Chase asks whether the rest of the bench is taken, but rather than wait for the boy's reply, Bear scares him off.

*Aaron's protectiveness toward Chase and his matter-of-fact claim that football players have to deal with injuries suggest he may be a real friend to Chase despite both boys' bad behavior—and he may also be smarter than some of the other football players. When Bear casually terrorizes the sixth grader, it shows that bullying is a routine part of Aaron and Bear's behavior.*



After the three boys sit down, Chase explains that he has amnesia. At first, Aaron and Bear are skeptical, even suspicious, but eventually they realize Chase is serious. Aaron worriedly asks whether Chase's memory will return. When Chase says the doctors don't know, Aaron and Bear look "freaked out," which makes Chase feel friendlier toward them. He reassures them that he's the same person even if he lacks his memories and that they'll do even "better stuff" together than before. Bear expresses hope that even if Chase can't play football, he'll be better for lacrosse in the spring, and Aaron says they'll support Chase—while slapping Chase's injured shoulder.

*When Chase reveals his amnesia, Aaron and Bear are suspicious of him, hinting that although Chase is telling the truth now, he may have been a liar in the past. He interprets Aaron and Bear's "freaked out" reaction to his lost memories as concern for him, which makes him like them more—but their reaction may hint that there's something specific they want Chase to remember. Chase's focus on doing "better stuff" in the future indicates that he wants to focus on what he can do, not on what he's lost, while Aaron and Bear's reactions—focusing on sports, hitting Chase's injury—show that the boys' friendship centers on stereotypically masculine preoccupations like toughness and physical prowess.*



An adult in a suit approaches Chase, Bear, and Aaron, and introduces himself as principal Dr. Fitzwallace. When Dr. Fitzwallace tells Chase that they've met before, Bear blurts, "You can say that again." Dr. Fitzwallace leads Chase into his office, where Chase sees a photo that he recognizes from his own bedroom: Chase in football gear, holding up a trophy. Beside it is another, much older photo with another boy holding up a trophy. Dr. Fitzwallace explains that the older photo is of Frank, who was on the football team the only other time the school won state.

Chase, surprised, admits he didn't know his father Frank had won state. Dr. Fitzwallace invites Chase to take a seat, tells him the school's staff has been informed of Chase's amnesia, and tells him not to waste his "completely fresh start." Chase, shocked, wonders how awful he must have been pre-amnesia for Dr. Fitzwallace to give him this advice.

*When Bear blurts, "You can say that again," it indicates that Chase has been in trouble with the principal many times. Together with Aaron and Bear's rudeness and physical roughness, this detail suggests the boys may be troublemakers or bullies. Yet Dr. Fitzwallace's office also contains photos of Chase and his father Frank winning the state championship in football, illustrating that the school community values athletic success whether the winning athletes are kind people or not.*



*In an earlier scene, Frank fixated on Chase continuing to play football despite his concussion. Together with the revelation that Frank was also a state football champion, this detail suggests that Frank wants Chase to follow in his footsteps even if it risks Chase's health. Yet when Dr. Fitzwallace calls Chase's amnesia a "fresh start"—rather than a painful personal tragedy—it implies that Chase was pursuing a bad path prior to his accident.*



## CHAPTER 4: BRENDAN ESPINOZA

Brendan is filming cliques in the cafeteria and commenting on them as if he were making a nature documentary. When he sees Chase, he calls him an "*apex predator*" and "*Footballus herois*." Chase, carrying his meal, approaches Brendan. Brendan is terrified that Chase may realize Brendan was mocking him. One time, Chase and his friends made Brendan stand against the pole while they played tetherball until the tether had tied Brendan to the pole—and then they left him there. Chase asks whether he can sit with Brendan, who (utterly baffled) says sure.

When Chase puts a napkin across his lap, Brendan is shocked by his "civilized" behavior. He realizes that the rumor that Chase has amnesia may be true. When Chase has trouble cutting his chicken with his arm in a sling, Brendan offers to help. Though Chase turns him down, Brendan comes around the table and does it anyway, which earns him a disapproving look from Shoshanna passing by. Chase thanks him.

*Brendan treats the social hierarchies in the middle-school cafeteria as if they were as natural as differences between various kinds of animal. When he calls Chase a "predator" and a "Footballus herois"—a fake scientific name, as if football heroes were a species like "homo sapiens"—he implies that Chase's past cruel behavior and identity as a bully are as impossible to change as his species. Yet Chase's actions upend Brendan's assumption that Chase's identity is static and unchanging: Brendan thinks that Chase wants to bully him, but Chase just wants to eat lunch with someone.*



*Chase's "civilized" behavior surprises Brendan, emphasizing that Chase's past behavior toward Brendan was barbaric. Yet the boys get along now that Chase has lost his memory, which suggests that Chase's past behavior was the product of his environment, not his essential character—nurture, not nature.*



When Brendan tries to sit back down in his own seat, he falls—and sees Bear, who is holding Brendan's chair. Bear puts the chair down on top of Brendan like a cage. Aaron, standing with Bear and some other football players, tells Chase he's "at the wrong table." Chase removes the chair from Brendan, helps him up, and apologizes. The football players again call for Chase to come sit with them. Brendan tries explaining to Chase that the football players are his best friends, but Chase seems almost unhappy with this fact. Brendan returns to his seat, checks his camera, and realizes it captured audio of the whole interaction.

*Amnesiac Chase apologizes for his friends' bullying and dismissive behavior toward Brendan, again showing that Chase's past bullying behavior wasn't a product of his essential character but of his environment. He even seems distressed that he's friends with bullies, which suggests that without his memories of and loyalty toward them clouding his judgment, he judges them negatively. Aaron's claim that it's "wrong" for Chase to sit with Brendan, by contrast, shows that Aaron—like Brendan—believes middle-school social hierarchies are natural and can't or shouldn't be changed.*



## CHAPTER 5: CHASE AMBROSE

Two weeks later, Chase has shed his shoulder wrap and is out walking when he sees a little girl on a playground, which reminds him of the mysterious blond girl in his one memory. Then he realizes the little girl on the playground is Helene. When she falls off the top of the slide, Chase darts toward her, catches her, and zooms her around in the air. She loves it until she realizes who has caught her, at which point she screams for her mother. When Chase tries to reassure her that it's just him, her brother, she starts crying and demands to be put down. He puts her on her feet, and she runs for Corinne, who's approaching.

*Helene reacts with fear to Chase's attempts to help her and play with her. From the intensity of her fear, readers can guess that Chase has bullied her in the past: a disturbing implication, since Helene is only four years old.*



Chase apologizes to Corinne for frightening Helene. Though Corinne thanks Chase for stopping Helene's fall, Chase thinks her tone is a little cold. When Chase speculates that Helene dislikes him, Corinne says no, it's only that Chase scares her. Chase, alarmed, wonders what he did to scare his little sister.

*Corinne confirms that Helene fears Chase, implying that Chase has purposely scared Helene in the past. That this implication disturbs Chase shows again that losing his memory has changed his moral judgments: the thought of scaring his own little sister doesn't sit right with him anymore.*



Frank pulls up in a truck labeled Ambrose Electric and calls to Corinne to start the grill at home, because he plans to buy steak. When Frank sees Chase, he asks why Chase isn't at practice. Chase says the doctor doesn't want him practicing because of his concussion. Frank pooh-poohs the doctor and invites Chase over for steak, calling it better than Tina's "rabbit food." Chase politely declines but mentions seeing Frank's state championship photo. Frank says that "Ambrose men" have a gift and warns Chase not to let Tina "coddle it out of" him, which is what happened to Johnny. Frank drives off, and Chase says goodbye to Helene, who can't or won't hold his gaze.

*Frank adheres almost cartoonishly to stereotypes of masculine toughness: he wants to grill steak and contemptuously refers to less meat-heavy dishes as "rabbit food," mocks the doctor warning Chase to be cautious after a serious head injury, and calls his ex-wife's less rough-and-tumble parenting style "coddling." His criticism of Chase's older brother Johnny is disturbing; it suggests that before the accident, Chase may have acted tough to the point of cruelty in order to avoid harsh and dismissive criticism from his father.*





Chase can tell he has a reputation at school, though not whether it's positive or negative. He and his jock friends seem to rule the school, but he's not sure how much he likes his friends. They're physically violent and verbally cruel to one another as a matter of course. Aaron and Bear try to shield Chase from some of it due to his injury. He respects what they're doing but doesn't like being treated as if he's "weak." Also, he finds Aaron and Bear's constant questions about his memory anxiety-inducing. When he admits that his sole memory is a little blond girl, they're at first shocked and then find it hilarious.

Students not on the football team avoid looking at Chase; some even flee from him. When he asks Aaron and Bear why people would be frightened of him, they trade loaded glances; Aaron notes that Chase really has amnesia. Bear interrupts Chase's follow-up questions by saying that he and Aaron have to go do community service in an assisted living community, unlike Chase, who was "excused" due to injury.

Chase is shocked that a court must have ordered him, Aaron, and Bear to do community service. When he asks what their offense was, Aaron explains that they hid cherry bombs inside a piano being used in a recital. He claims that the prank "was awesome" and that taking a little punishment wouldn't have bothered the old Chase. Tentatively, Chase replies: "nobody got hurt, so what's the big deal?" Bear laughs and comments, "Yeah, right."

Aaron tells Chase that they only got in such big trouble because everyone in town envies their status and freewheeling behavior. When Chase suggests that that's "not fair," Bear jokingly bewails the injustice, and Chase thinks that Bear and Aaron are "the toughest." He thanks them for being honest with him, saying that his mom Tina hid the truth and Frank mentioned she might "coddle" him. Bear praises Frank and expresses hope that Chase will be back on the football team soon. Chase wonders whether his mom was wrong to trust the doctor who said Chase shouldn't play; he also wonders whether she's hiding additional information from him.

*A person's reputation is, essentially, hearsay about them. When Chase says he has a reputation, it means that other people who have little direct experience of him have heard of him and believe they know things about him. Having a reputation seems to disturb Chase, perhaps because he knows less about himself than apparent strangers do. Chase's negative reaction to Aaron and Bear's loyal protection of him—he doesn't want to seem "weak"—suggests that he has already internalized some of Frank's macho worldview since waking from his coma.*



*Though Chase can't yet tell whether his reputation is positive or negative, the fearful reactions he receives from many other students suggests that it's largely negative. Aaron's snarky reference to Chase's amnesia, meanwhile, suggests that Chase earned his reputation as a scary bully.*



*Blowing up a piano doesn't seem particularly "awesome"; Aaron and Bear's enthusiasm for destruction illustrates their childish view of what strong men do and like. Chase's focus on whether anyone "got hurt" shows his greater empathy and care for others post-accident, while Bear's "Yeah, right" disturbingly suggests that people did, in fact, get hurt during the incident.*



*Rather than accept that they were punished for cruel and dangerous behavior, Aaron childishly insists that adults punished him, Chase, and Bear out of jealousy. Chase interprets Aaron and Bear's juvenile dismissal of legitimate criticism as "tough[ness]," which shows how too much unreflective investment in masculine strength can justify bullying. Chase's worry that Frank was right about Tina, meanwhile, suggests that Frank's overinvestment in Chase's masculinity and sports career may have undermined Tina's attempts to responsibly parent Chase in the past.*



Later that day, when Tina gets home from work, Chase confronts her about hiding his arrest and community service from him. Seeming tired, she admits that she has been trying not to disturb him with past events while he's healing from his traumatic injuries. When Chase asks what other events she's been hiding, she says that she believes Chase is good "deep down"—but he hasn't always acted in good ways. Chase, nauseated, recalls all the kids who've acted scared of him at school. He wonders whether he earned Shoshanna Weber's rage.

Then Chase remembers Aaron and Bear's take on the events, so different from Tina's. He acknowledges that his behavior was unkind but asks why the school reacted so harshly, since it was still just a "prank." Tina, stonily, points out that the prank made everyone at the recital think an assault was being launched on the school. Only luck prevented audience members from being harmed in the "panic," and it makes sense that the principal Dr. Fitzwallace called the police. Tina's account of events makes Chase feel terrible, yet he notes that everyone he meets—Tina, Frank, Aaron, and Bear—interprets him and his behavior differently. He wonders which interpretation he should trust.

*Tina distinguishes between who Chase is "deep down" and his past behavior. This distinction suggests that people can change—for good or bad—despite having certain essential characteristics. Readers may wonder how Chase's essential characteristics will express themselves now that he's forgotten his past—especially since his sickened reaction to the thought of others fearing him suggests that, in his "restarted" state, he no longer wants to be a bully.*



*Chase has no memories, no direct experience of himself from before the accident. As such, he can only judge his past self based on others' accounts of him: that is, on his reputation. Yet the different people to whom he speaks have wholly different experiences of pre-accident Chase. That a person's reputation can be internally contradictory in this way suggests that reputations aren't a trustworthy guide to who a person really is. Nevertheless, Tina's description of the fear and possible harm the "prank" could have caused does suggest Aaron and Bear aren't taking it seriously enough.*



## CHAPTER 6: BRENDAN ESPINOZA

Brendan Espinoza is trying to persuade other members of the school video club to help him shoot a video for YouTube. They tell him his video idea is crazy; when he pleads with Shoshanna, she says they'd "get arrested." The other members of the club walk off, leaving Brendan alone at his locker to bemoan their lack of "loyalty." He scans the crowded hallway for other potential helpers, but no one will look at him. Despite—or due to—his leadership in the video club and his academic success, he's very uncool.

Brendan notices Chase coming over to him. At first, he panics, thinking Chase will violently bully him; then he realizes Chase is trying to remember who he is. Brendan gives his name and reminds Chase that they met in the cafeteria. When Chase gives his name in turn, Brendan laughs and says the whole school knows who Chase is. Though Brendan used to be terrified of Chase, Chase seems different since his amnesia—so Brendan asks whether Chase will help him shoot a video.

*Brendan's belief that "loyalty" should have compelled the video-club members to go along with a dangerous idea that could "get [them] arrested" sheds light on Chase, Aaron, and Bear's prank and arrest: peer pressure and group loyalty can lead kids to do stupid, dangerous things. Meanwhile, Brendan's lack of coolness despite his academic success shows that his middle school's social hierarchy values athletic prowess far more than intelligence or leadership in non-physical pursuits.*



*When Brendan says that everyone in school knows who Chase is, it reinforces what readers have already learned: many people believe they know who Chase is whether they've had substantive interactions with him or not. Interestingly, however, Brendan quickly notices that Chase's personality has changed—revealing that Brendan is more open-minded and less swayed by people's reputations than his peers.*



To Brendan's surprise, Chase comes with him, laughs at the video idea, and says he can't be the one "going in" because it would scare his doctor and his mom. Brendan, hiding his surprise that popular kids like Chase have parents, tells Chase that he only has to run one of the cameras. When they go to Brendan's house to get a tricycle, Brendan's mother reacts with alarmed hostility when she sees Chase, though Chase reintroduces himself politely and Brendan assures her that they're working on a video together.

Chase and Brendan take the tricycle to a car wash. While Chase diverts the car wash attendants—which his status as local sports hero helps him do—Brendan straps a camera to his head, gets on the tricycle, and starts riding through the car wash. Chase films him from the sidelines. Water and soap suds blast Brendan as he peddles. When he gets through the wash, the car wash manager starts yelling at Chase for endangering Brendan, mentions the cherry bomb incident, and threatens to call the police. Brendan explains that he planned the video and that he's president of the school's video club. He promises to advertise the car wash in the yearbook—which mollifies the manager.

On their way back to Brendan's house, Brendan apologizes to Chase for the manager's threats. When Chase points out that Brendan saved him from the police, Brendan says that that was only because of Chase's "reputation." Chase replies that it was Brendan's reputation that seemed to save them and suggests Brendan must be "special." Brendan is shocked to realize that Chase is right: his "record as a nerd and goody-two-shoes" is what saved them.

Brendan and Chase sneak past Brendan's mom—who would likely blame Chase for Brendan's wrecked appearance—into Brendan's room. They watch their footage, which makes them laugh hysterically. Brendan notes that Chase is a talented camera man. They edit the video, set it to dramatic music, and upload it to YouTube, where Brendan gives Chase a coproducer credit. Chase tells Brendan that making the video is the most enjoyable thing he's ever done. When Brendan points out he's likely forgotten the most enjoyable thing he's ever done, Chase says it was great anyway. Brendan invites Chase to video club—and then thinks that, given Chase's bullying history, he's basically "invit[ed] a shark over for sushi." Chase asks when the club meets.

*Brendan's surprise that Chase has a mother reveals that the middle-school social hierarchy that deifies Chase makes him seem less human to the kids "below" him in the hierarchy: they can't imagine him having parents the way they do. Brendan's mother's reaction to Chase again emphasizes that Chase has a bad reputation because he used to be a bully.*



*This scene shows the two sides to Chase's reputation. His reputation as a successful athlete gets him positive attention; this positive attention is what enables him to distract the car wash attendants for Brendan. Yet on the other hand, his reputation as a bully means that his actions are sometimes interpreted in an unfairly negative light; this negative pre-judgment causes the car wash manager to assume Chase is bullying Brendan, not helping him shoot a video.*



*Brendan realizes that Chase's reputation almost got Chase unfairly arrested—but he doesn't realize that his own reputation as a "goody-two-shoes" saved Chase until Chase points it out. When Chase says Brendan must be "special," it shows amnesiac Chase's rejection of the social values of his middle school, which prioritizes athletics over intelligence or moral character.*



*Brendan recognizes that Chase's reputation attracts unfair blame; for this reason, the boys sneak past Brendan's mom to prevent her blaming Chase for the physical damage Brendan brought on himself. Yet Brendan still thinks of having invited Chase to video club as having "invit[ed] a shark over for sushi," revealing that Brendan may still think of Chase's bullying as an animalistic, unchanging instinct, not something Chase can outgrow. While Brendan may not be sure Chase can change, Chase's enjoyment in helping Brendan suggests that—absent the football team and the middle-school social hierarchy constraining his behavior—he may be interested in a variety of activities, such as film.*



## CHAPTER 7: SHOSHANNA WEBER

Brendan's car wash video puts the video club in a state of admiration and hilarity—until they see Chase listed as a coproducer in the credits. Shoshanna, furious, asks whether Brendan wanted to get hurt. Brendan retorts that Chase was a great camera man, superior to anyone in video club. When Shoshanna says, “You *didn't*!”, Brendan admits that he did, in fact, invite Chase to join the club. The whole club starts shouting out stories about Chase, Aaron, and Bear bullying them. Brendan asserts that they bullied him most of all but that the amnesia has changed Chase: “maybe he forgot what a jerk he was.”

Shoshanna, furious, points out that Joel left the school because of Chase and that no one in the club wants Chase to join. The club's faculty advisor, Ms. DeLeo, reminds them that student clubs can't exclude students—Chase can join if he wants. A moment later, Chase enters. He notices the hostility in the room, but when Brendan assures him that their video was well received, he asks what video club does other than film wild behavior. Shoshanna, miffed, thinks that an idiot like Chase would only notice Brendan's “moronic stunts” and not his intelligence or potential. She thinks: “The simplest way to make the world a better place would be to kick out Chase Ambrose.”

The faculty advisor Ms. DeLeo tells Chase that some club members will enter the National Video Journalism Contest. Brendan, laughing, says that only Shoshanna will be doing that. Shoshanna informs Brendan that if he weren't so obsessed with YouTube, he might realize that the contest guidelines for this year—to interview a senior citizen with fascinating stories—are really interesting. Ms. DeLeo also tells Chase that the club produces the “video yearbook” and suggests he should profile the school's sports teams. Chase points out that he doesn't know the school's athletes anymore, though they know him. Shoshanna realizes that Chase really does have amnesia, wonders whether he's changed, and concludes that even if his memories are gone, his personality must be the same.

That evening, Shoshanna messages Joel to fill him in on Chase's amnesia. When Joel says he feels weird about his bully not remembering the bullying, Shoshanna predicts that Chase will remember soon—or Bear and Aaron will fill him in. When Joel expresses surprise at how much she seems to know about Chase, she avoids explaining that Chase has joined video club—the fact that the club kids are tolerating Chase's presence will only make Joel feel terrible.

*In the last scene, Brendan seemed worried that Chase's tendency to bully uncool kids was an unchanging characteristic, as instinctive as a shark's tendency to eat fish. Yet now he argues that amnesia might have made Chase “forg[e]t what a jerk he was”—an argument suggesting that memory and experience are as important to shaping an individual's personality as that individual's baseline mental and emotional makeup.*



*Shoshanna assumes that Chase is ignoring Brendan's good qualities and focusing on his “moronic stunts.” Readers know that isn't true: Chase has already praised Brendan as “special”—and he thought the tricycle stunt was hilarious, not moronic. Shoshanna's incorrect interpretation of Chase's question shows how her anger and her loyalty to Joel are warping her judgment. Her desire to exclude Chase from video club and “kick [him] out” of the “world,” meanwhile, show that social hierarchies can work both ways: while the kids at the top of the hierarchy bully those below, the kids at the bottom may develop excessively negative judgments of those at the top and try to prevent them from participating in “nerdy” activities.*



*Dr. Fitzwallace told Chase that he alerted the school's faculty to Chase's amnesia—yet the video-club faculty advisor, Ms. DeLeo, still stereotypes Chase and assumes he'll want to interview other athletes. Similarly, Shoshanna assumes that Chase's pre-accident personality must have resulted solely from who he is “deep down,” not from the memories and experiences he no longer has access to. This negative stereotyping of Chase and refusal to admit he might change shows how adults and “uncool” kids can prop up social hierarchies and cliques in the same way that popular kids and bullies do.*



*When Shoshanna chooses not to tell Joel that Chase has joined video club, it implies that she views their “toleration” of Chase as disloyal to Joel, whom Chase bullied. This view is unfair—the video-club kids can't control who joins the club, as their faculty advisor explained—and shows how a fixation on loyalty is distorting Shoshanna's reasoning.*



Shoshanna implies that she knows about Chase's amnesia only because the whole school is gossiping about it. When Joel bemoans the school's idiocy, she asks whether Melton is an improvement—and Joel emphatically denies it. When Shoshanna points out that Joel felt wretched back at home, Joel retorts that by Melton standards he's mediocre at piano, whereas back home he was "special." Shoshanna feels another burst of anger toward Chase.

*Joel's claim that he was "special" at his original school implies that different social spheres within the larger social hierarchy respect different values: among the nerdy and uncool kids at his original school, Joel was valued for his musical talent, even as the cool kids bullied him. At Melton, everyone is excellent at music, so Joel no longer feels valued—he misses the status his musical talent gave him among his nerdy peers back home, even though the kids at the top of the hierarchy bullied him.*



## CHAPTER 8: CHASE AMBROSE

That Saturday, Chase is filming a preseason scrimmage between his old football team, the Hurricanes, and another school's team. The football field evokes no memories or emotions in him. He thinks about how much he loved filming with Brendan and how video club feels like "the place for" him. Someone yells "Champ!" at Chase. It's Frank, on the bleachers with Helene. He tells Chase that he attends each one of the Hurricanes' games and that Helene is beginning to like them. Chase notes that Helene is playing with dolls and completely ignoring the game.

*Amnesiac Chase likes Brendan and loves video club—which suggests that, prior to his accident, he failed to pursue more friendships and different activities due to social pressure, not due to his inherent personality. When Frank calls Chase "Champ," it suggests that Frank narrowly defines Chase according to his athletic prowess and—specifically—the state football championship his team won. Adult Frank's obsession with a middle-school football team and his refusal to recognize that his four-year-old daughter Helene likes dolls, not sports, show his overinvestment in his adolescent athletic career and in stereotypical macho pursuits.*



As the scrimmage progresses, Frank gets angrier and angrier, criticizing the players and telling Chase how much better he was than they are. Chase realizes he understands the game even if he can't remember playing it; he also notices that the Hurricanes aren't that good and feels surprised they won a championship. When he comments to Frank that the players are "out of sync," Frank vehemently agrees and slaps Chase too hard on his injured shoulder. Chase grasps that he craves Frank's "approval."

*Frank's angry responses to a middle-school football scrimmage—one in which his son isn't even playing—again show his overinvestment in athletics and in stereotypical masculine pursuits. When he hits Chase on his injured shoulder, it shows his reckless indifference to his son's physical wellbeing. Chase's realization that he craves Frank's "approval" hints that some of Chase's cruel, macho, bullying behavior may have derived from his relationship with Frank.*



Helene, done playing with her dolls, asks Frank whether they can leave. When Frank says no dismissively, Chase offers to shoot a movie of her dolls. Helene starts reassembling her dollhouse. Meanwhile, the Hurricanes throw an interception, and Frank blows up, demanding to know why Chase is recording the game rather than playing. Sensing that Frank will react badly if he explains about yearbook, Chase blurts that he wants to play—and he will, as soon as the doctor says it's fine. Frank, appeased, asserts: "We're Ambrose men. We're the doers. Other people take pictures of us!"

*Frank ignores the interests and preferences of his daughter, which again emphasizes his overinvestment in masculinity and contempt for femininity. Chase fails to explain that he likes filming because he thinks his father will react badly, illustrating how Frank's obsession with football may have steered Chase away from exploring non-athletic interests in the past. Frank's brag that "other people take pictures" of "Ambrose men," not vice versa, suggests that he doesn't value film because he thinks of it as an insufficiently active or masculine pursuit.*





Chase chats about football with Frank but simultaneously films the doll story that Helene is puppeteering for the camera. When he shows her the footage, she “squeals” happily—which triggers in Chase a memory of Helene squealing while holding back tears after he tore off her beloved teddy bear’s head. Chase announces that he’s remembered something. Frank asserts that Chase is fine and will be playing again soon. Chase focuses on the game again, realizes that he knows how to play better than the guys on the field, and realizes: “I am a player”—an assertion that helps him ignore what he’s just remembered about how he’s treated Helene.

*Chase can talk about football with Frank and help Helene with dolls simultaneously, which indicates that he doesn’t need to choose between stereotypically masculine and stereotypically feminine pursuits: he’s capable of both. Yet when entertaining Helene triggers in him a memory of bullying her, he chooses to focus on football and define himself as a “player” to distract himself from his previous bad behavior, a mental move that suggests he may have used his identity as a football star to repress his own misgivings about his cruel, macho, bullying behavior.*



## CHAPTER 9: CHASE AMBROSE

When Chase goes to the locker room door after the scrimmage, he comes upon Aaron shutting out another video club member, Hugo. Hugo explains to Chase that he’s trying to film the football team. Chase asks why, given that Ms. DeLeo assigned him that task; Hugo admits the video club worried Chase would “forget.” Bear, having heard Chase’s voice, opens the door and drags him inside the locker room. Chase manages to get Hugo in too by telling Bear that they’re both there to film the team for video yearbook.

*The video-club kids thought that Chase would “forget” the video-yearbook assignment that the club’s faculty advisor Ms. DeLeo gave him. Here, “forget” seems to be a euphemism for “blow off”—the video-club kids aren’t yet willing to believe that their former bully is capable of changing or exploring interests beyond football.*



When Chase explains why he’s there, the football team is upset; they were hoping he’d tell them he could play again. They criticize him for following his doctor’s orders and hanging out with the video club. Aaron defends Chase, saying that sidelining Chase was his wimpy doctor’s decision and that he’s covering the Hurricanes to make them look good in the yearbook. Chase tells everyone he’ll start playing football again as soon as the doctor says he can—which makes Hugo look at him funny. A football player throws a ball at Chase; he catches it easily, making him feel like he’s regaining “an old self.”

*The football team fails to understand that concussions are dangerous and criticize Chase for taking his seriously. Even Aaron, who defends Chase out of loyalty, blames the doctor’s “wimpiness” rather than pointing out that Chase has a serious head injury. This irrational obsession with toughness hints that too much investment in stereotypical masculinity can be dangerous. Meanwhile, Chase likes the feeling of getting “an old self” back, even though he has private misgivings about who he used to be, which illustrates how important having an identity (even a negative one) is to him.*



The football players give Chase good interview quotes, though they’re monosyllabic with Hugo. Chase feels so happy and at “home” with the team that when Aaron announces he and Bear have to go do community service, Chase says he’ll go too. Aaron reminds him he has a medical excuse not to go, and Bear suggests he’s *really* an amnesiac if he wants to go back to the assisted living facility where they do community service, but Chase insists.

*The football players’ willingness to talk to Chase, even though he now belongs to the video club, suggests that they still see him as “one of them,” even as he pursues new interests. Chase’s desire to continue feeling at “home” shows how much lacking a stable identity has disturbed him.*



At the Portland Street Assisted Living Residence, Chase, Aaron, and Bear report to head nurse Nurse Duncan. Though taken aback that Chase is voluntarily completing his community service, Nurse Duncan quickly assigns the three boys to the snack cart. Aaron and Bear pilfer the cart for snacks and call all the residents “Dumbledore” or “Dumbledora,” while Chase ends up volunteering to do various small tasks for residents, like finding lost items.

*Albus Dumbledore is the elderly headmaster at Hogwarts School for Witchcraft and Wizardry in J. K. Rowling’s Harry Potter series; Aaron and Bear show their disrespect for the elderly by referring to all the seniors by variants of Dumbledore rather than their real names. Nurse Duncan’s surprise that Chase would voluntarily help the seniors implies that, prior to his amnesia, Chase was as disrespectful as Aaron and Bear still are—an implication that emphasizes how important memory is to identity and behavior.*



When Aaron makes a rude comment about the facility, Chase tells him to keep it down so the residents don’t hear. Bear claims they *can’t* hear, and Chase snaps that one woman certainly heard Bear farting in her room. Aaron finds this hilarious. Chase thinks mean jokes are funny among the three of them, but the residents—many of whom have interesting, historical life stories—merit “more respect.”

*Unlike Aaron and Bear, Chase recognizes that mean jokes are appropriate in some contexts and not others: you shouldn’t “punch down” by insulting people who can’t hear, and you should show the elderly “more respect” than you might show your peers.*



In room 121, the resident (later revealed to be Mr. Solway) is asleep in his chair. Chase is leaving snacks on his table when he notices a black-and-white photo of the resident as a younger man accepting a **Medal of Honor** from President Truman. Aaron and Bear, uninterested, try to hurry Chase out of the room, but Chase wonders aloud what the man won the medal for. Aaron suggests the man “slew a triceratops”—and the man, waking up, snarks: “It was a pterodactyl.” Then he tells the boys that he’s occupied (though he clearly isn’t), so they should leave. The boys leave.

*President Harry S. Truman (1884–1972) was president of the United States from 1945 to 1953. The Medal of Honor is the highest decoration a member of the U.S. military can receive. A medal is something like a physical symbol of a person’s high status and good reputation; it makes sense that Chase, who has a high social status but a bad reputation, would be curious about how the elderly man earned his reputation. Aaron and Bear are uninterested because the man is old, as evidenced by Aaron’s joke that the man killed a “triceratops” (that is, a dinosaur)—while the old man’s comeback that he killed a “pterodactyl” suggests that he’s mentally quick and sarcastic.*



Aaron and Bear inform Chase that they only have one more resident to visit, an old woman so confused she thinks she’s staying at a hotel. Sure enough, the woman is very confused, but Chase doesn’t find it funny the way Aaron and Bear seem to. He helps her rearrange her furniture, and then they deposit her snacks and begin to leave, when she tries to hand Chase a \$20 tip. Chase tries to refuse it. Then Bear swipes it, grinning, and says: “Enjoy your stay.”

*Chase doesn’t find an elderly woman’s cognitive decline amusing, showing that—without his memories and history of bullying—he doesn’t like to “punch down” on people who are suffering. By contrast, Bear is willing to take money from the elderly woman under false pretenses.*



Bear and Aaron bolt from the old woman's room. Chase runs after them. When he tells them they're stealing, Bear retorts that it's "discrimination" to say that the woman can't tip them just because she's elderly and confused. Chase points out that if anyone realizes they're taking money from the residents, they could be punished with more than community service. Bear retorts that Chase doesn't need to do community service anyway, and Chase demands the money back.

Aaron, trying to mediate, says that returning the money and rubbing the old woman's nose in her confusion will upset her. Chase recognizes that Aaron's argument is self-serving but "kind of right." He suggests that they give the money to charity instead—and Bear suggests donating it to the "Take a Bear to Lunch Fund." Aaron and Bear get their timesheets signed by Nurse Duncan, and the three boys head out for pizza—but Chase feels so bad that, without explaining to his friends what he's doing, he runs back and slips a \$20 under the old woman's door.

Walking back out of the facility, Chase checks the nameplate on Room 121: Mr. Julius Solway. The door's ajar. Mr. Solway spots Chase and demands to know what he wants. Chase asks which war he won the **medal** in. Mr. Solway claims it was the Trojan War—but, after Chase apologizes for bothering him and begins to leave, he admits he won it during the Korean War. When Chase marvels at Mr. Solway's heroism, Mr. Solway says the heroes are among the dead—he just happened to be picked to be honored. Chase asks what he did to get the medal. Mr. Solway claims to have forgotten and slams the door on Chase.

*Chase doesn't want Bear to take the woman's money both because it's cruel to trick an elderly person in cognitive decline and because he recognizes there could be serious negative consequences for him, Aaron, and Bear. Bear, who lacks Chase's thoughtfulness, discounts Chase's objections to his bullying a helpless elderly woman and uses the language of fairness to claim—in entirely bad faith—that not accepting her money would be "discrimination."*



*Aaron is more thoughtful than Bear, in that he's capable of inventing a "kind of" reasonable justification for bullying behavior toward a confused, elderly woman. Yet Aaron isn't troubled by conscience any more than Bear is: when Bear suggests that they could donate the old woman's money to the "Take a Bear to Lunch Fund" rather than a real charity, Aaron immediately goes along with it. Chase, by contrast, sacrifices his own money rather than stealing. Since Chase hung out with Aaron and Bear a lot prior to his accident, it seems likely that Chase's conscience is resurfacing due to his lack of memories—another indication of how important memories and experiences are to individuals' behavior.*



*The Trojan War is the subject of the ancient Greek poet Homer's epic poem [The Iliad](#), which was composed sometime around the 8th century BCE. When Mr. Solway claims to have won his medal during the Trojan War, he's making another sarcastic comment about his own age. The Korean War (1950-1953), in which Mr. Solway won the medal, was a conflict between capitalist South Korea and communist North Korea; U.S. soldiers fought on behalf of South Korea. Mr. Solway denies his own heroism, even though Medals of Honor are supposed to be awarded for extraordinary acts of military bravery; his denial suggests that the medal represents not who Mr. Solway is but the gap between his reputation and how he sees himself.*



## CHAPTER 10: KIMBERLY TOOLEY

Kimberly adores pep rallies and football, despite not understanding the rules. She thinks the football players look good in uniform; in particular, she likes Chase, though he didn't seem to know anything about her even before his amnesia. She's confused that he's joined video club: the other members are "nerds." After the pep rally ends, Kimberly sees Brendan Espinoza getting shoved around by football players—until Chase shoves one culprit, Joey, into a wall, telling him to leave Brendan alone. Confused fighting ensues, and Aaron and Bear attempt to break it up.

*Kimberly likes football players and thinks that the video-club kids are "nerds," but she's not cool enough for football-star Chase to have noticed her prior to his amnesia, which suggests that she exists somewhere in the middle of the school's social hierarchy. Amnesiac Chase immediately defends Brendan against another football player, which suggests that—absent his memories—he dislikes bullying.*



When Chase demands to know why Joey is bullying Brendan, Joey points out that Chase used to bully Brendan too. Chase—clearly not remembering that—retorts: “We were shooting your pep rally to make you look good.” The football players become visibly unhappy—because, Kimberly realizes, Chase is identifying himself with the video club against the football team. Joey says that the football team used to be close with Chase, but now they don’t know him.

All the football players but Aaron and Bear disperse. Aaron tells Chase he should have acted differently because Joey has defended him in the past. When Chase asks whether he should have allowed Joey to hurt the much smaller Brendan, Aaron claims that Joey would have backed off if Chase had asked. He points out that Chase isn’t “perfect” either and warns him to “think about who your friends are.” Then he leaves.

Brendan thanks Chase; other video club members do too. Shoshanna, incredulous, points out that Chase has bullied them all in the past, he was just being violent again, and he’s still responsible for what happened to her brother Joel. She leaves in a huff. Remembering Joel, Kimberly gets sad: “A lot of this stuff feels kind of harmless until something like Joel Weber happens.” The other video club members apologize for Shoshanna, thank Chase again, and leave.

Alone with Kimberly, Chase turns to her and admits he doesn’t remember that Shoshanna had a brother. Kimberly explains that Joel was a piano player who switched schools due to bullying. Though she leaves out that Chase was the main bully, she wonders whether he regretted his behavior when he learned Joel’s parents were sending him away—but she recognizes that the truth about Chase’s feelings may be lost forever, since Chase doesn’t remember them.

Chase asks Kimberly whether he helped bully Joel. She avoids answering. He confesses how strange it is that other people remember his life when he can’t. Kimberly introduces herself and claims that Chase calls her Kimmy (he didn’t, but she always wanted him to). Chase tells her he has to go to video club, says, “See you—Kimmy,” and leaves. Kimberly, elated, decides that he must not remember that he’s “out of [her] league”—and decides to join video club.

*Chase refers to the video-club kids as “we” and the football team as “you,” which—as Kimberly notes—reveals he thinks of himself as a video-club kid now, not a football player. When Joey says that the football team doesn’t know Chase anymore, he implies that if Chase is missing his memories and doesn’t identify as a football player, he lacks a recognizable identity entirely.*



*Aaron isn’t wrong to point out that Chase could have asked Joey to stop Brendan before resorting to physical force. Yet he also claims that Chase isn’t “perfect” and that he should “think about who [his] friends are,” which implies that he’s less bothered by Chase getting physical than by Chase’s moral judgment of bullying and his lack of loyalty to the football players. Again Aaron is using his intelligence to rationalize his own and his friends’ bad behavior, whereas Chase uses his intelligence to interrogate and judge his own and others’ bad behavior.*



*Kimberly’s sadness at the thought of “something like Joel Weber happen[ing]” reveals that even a girl who has a crush on Chase and thinks the video-club kids are losers believes Chase and his friends went too far bullying Joel. Her reaction emphasizes that Shoshanna’s anger at Chase’s past behavior is justified, even as Shoshanna continues to interpret Chase’s present, improved behavior unfairly due to her anger and her loyalty to her brother Joel.*



*Chase’s sad admission that he can’t remember Joel and Kimberly’s curiosity about pre-accident Chase’s attitude toward Joel leaving town both hint that Chase’s past actions and attitudes really are important to understanding who Chase was and is, even though Chase himself has lost direct access to those actions and attitudes.*



*Kimberly’s realization that Chase has forgotten he’s “out of [her] league” is intended to be funny, but it also demonstrates how Chase’s pre-accident social status blinded him to possible connections with lower-status kids. Now that he’s an amnesiac, he’s willing to talk to and perhaps befriend a wider variety of people.*



## CHAPTER 11: AARON HAKIMIAN

Aaron wonders why amnesiac Chase seems like a completely different person—and why he wants to hang out with social outcasts like the video club instead of the football team. He can't decide whether the Chase he knew will ever return. That matters not only because Aaron wants his friend back, but also because Chase may not know that he's in possession of an object that he, Aaron, and Bear co-own.

Bear wants to demand the object back. When Aaron points out that Chase may not remember having it, Bear suggests that Chase is feigning memory loss to monopolize the “valuable” object. Aaron tells Bear that he's a “jerk” for talking about their friend like that—though he almost wishes Chase were fooling them if it meant they could have their friend back. Then he explains to Bear that they can't confront Chase about the object because the new, amnesiac Chase is a moralizer who might snitch on them. When Bear suggests again that Chase is lying about his memory loss, Aaron says they have to “wait and see.”

Aaron thinks the easiest place to finagle information out of Chase should be community service—except all the assisted living residents love Chase now and keep monopolizing his time. To Aaron's dismay, Chase has become especially friendly with “the one resident he should be staying away from—the crotchety old warhorse in 121” (Mr. Solway). Chase is interested in Mr. Solway's stories about the Korean War. When Bear asks what Chase and Mr. Solway could possibly talk about, Chase insists that Mr. Solway is an intriguing, unusual person; after all, he won a **Medal of Honor**. Aaron hates that Chase keeps mentioning this fact; it makes him “nervous.”

When Bear insists that Mr. Solway must have narrated the entire Korean War to Chase already, Chase laughs and calls Mr. Solway “nice.” Bear points out that, in fact, Mr. Solway is mean and widely disliked. After Chase goes to help another resident, Aaron suggests to Bear that maybe Chase just enjoys “war stories.” Bear retorts that he never used to. Aaron acknowledges the truth of this: they don't understand new, amnesiac Chase, and so they don't know “how worried [they] should be.”

*Aaron's belief that Chase has become a totally different person since losing his memories may or may not be true, but in either case, it emphasizes the importance of past memories and experiences to an individual's present behavior: without his memories guiding him, Chase really does act different.*



*The revelation that Chase is in possession of this mysterious, “valuable” object sheds new light on Aaron and Bear's skeptical, suspicious, and disturbed responses to the news of his amnesia: Bear thinks Chase might be lying about the amnesia to keep the object, while Aaron is disturbed because amnesiac Chase may no longer know where the object is. Aaron's claim that amnesiac Chase might snitch on them, meanwhile, hints that pre-accident Chase, Aaron, and Bear shouldn't have taken the mysterious object in the first place. Finally, Aaron's criticism of Bear for suspecting Chase of lying and his longing to have his friend back both show Aaron's loyalty and his emotional depth—despite his other bad behavior.*



*It isn't clear whether Aaron thinks Chase should “be staying away from” Mr. Solway because Mr. Solway is “crotchety” and has dangerous military experience—or for some other, as-yet-unrevealed reason. Regardless, Aaron and Bear's bafflement that Chase is befriending elderly people shows yet again that Aaron and Bear's commitment to the middle-school social hierarchy has narrowed their possibilities for friendship, while Chase's complete forgetting of the hierarchy has widened his. Chase's interest in the Medal of Honor emphasizes Chase's fascination both with heroism and with people's reputations.*



*Because Chase doesn't know Mr. Solway's reputation as a mean old jerk, he's able to interact with Mr. Solway in a friendly way, creating an opportunity for a pleasant social connection. This reveals how reputations can cloud people's judgment and narrow their social possibilities. Aaron and Bear's uncertainty and worry over what amnesiac Chase might do next, meanwhile, emphasizes yet again how important individual's memories are to determining their behavior.*





## CHAPTER 12: CHASE AMBROSE

Tina has been sharing photos with Chase, hoping to jog his memory. When she shows him a photo of Johnny's dorm, Chase retrieves a memory: as a seventh grader, he went with Tina to drop a terrified Johnny off at his freshman dorm—and felt contempt for his older brother's perceived wimpiness. Chase is shocked by his past negative opinion of Johnny, given how caring Johnny visited him while he was in the hospital. He realizes Johnny's care probably wasn't payback for any "wonderful brotherly loyalty" he'd given Johnny, and he wonders once again exactly how different he was before the accident.

At Chase's next appointment, the doctor tells him that his brain is fine, as evidenced by his ability to remember everything that's happened since his accident. Chase, queasily, remembers with particular clarity how good it felt to stop Joey from bullying Brendan using "physical power." He wonders whether Shoshanna's right that he's a violent person—whether the physical aggression he engaged in before the accident is reemerging. He feels as though he knows himself less well the more he learns about his past.

The doctor tells Chase that even though he seems recovered, he shouldn't play football this season because doctors still don't fully understand concussions' effects over the long term. Noting how upset Chase looks, Tina tries to sympathize, but Chase isn't sure she understands that he's upset because of how integral football was to his past identity. His father Frank only seems to talk to him about his football playing. Aaron and Bear are his only former friends who still speak to him, and he suspects they only do that because they hope he'll come back to the team.

Chase knows that Aaron and Bear judge him for enjoying community service, but he enjoys helping people—especially knowing that he's hurt people in the past. He enjoys learning things from the assisted living residents, too. In particular, he thinks that Mr. Solway—who once threw a grenade into an enemy tank—is amazing. By contrast, Mr. Solway doesn't think that that one action defines him; he says that he'd never have done it if he'd stopped to consider it.

*Macho Frank has repeatedly criticized Johnny's supposed wimpiness in front of Chase. Though this scene doesn't explicitly say so, it's implied that pre-accident Chase became contemptuous of Johnny by witnessing their father Frank's contempt of him. Because Chase now has very few memories of Frank and Johnny's relationship, he's able to judge Johnny on his own terms and recognize for himself that Johnny is a good person, caring for Chase not to reciprocate "brotherly loyalty" but because it's the right thing to do. Chase's recognition of his own past poor judgment makes him wonder, yet again, about his pre-accident identity.*



*Chase's enjoyment of exercising "physical power" over others suggests that while he doesn't want to bully anyone physically anymore, physical bullying isn't totally alien to his personality. His belief that the more he learns about his pre-accident identity, the less he knows himself indicates that his instincts and values "deep down" are at odds with the choices he was making prior to his accident.*



*Chase mourns the loss of football not because he cares about football, per se, but because he wants some stable identity—any stable identity—and because several of the people closest to him, including his own father, seem to value him primarily as a high-status, macho athlete rather than as an individual in himself. Chase's sense that his father and friends only value him for his athleticism may have contributed to his past antisocial behavior.*



*Mr. Solway argues that a single action doesn't define his life. He also argues that that reputation-defining action isn't representative of who he is because he didn't have time to think before he acted. Contrary to people who believe impulsive actions are the most revealing of identity, then, Mr. Solway believes that the choices you make after thinking about them are the ones that define you. Mr. Solway's beliefs indirectly reflect on Chase, who seems to be thinking about and reflecting on the morality of his actions much more now than he did before his accident.*



Mr. Solway can't find his **Medal of Honor**. He believes he lost it somehow, and he blames cognitive decline that dates to his wife's death. When he tells Chase that his life has been functionally over since she died, Chase tries to give him a pep talk, telling him he has friends. Mr. Solway informs Chase that everyone at the assisted living facility hates him; even the nurses call him "Mr. Happy Face" sarcastically. When Chase says he thinks he used to be a Mr. Happy Face too, Mr. Solway tells him he was—the accident improved his personality.

*Mr. Solway's loss of his Medal of Honor implies two things. One, it implies that he doesn't care that much about his reputation: if he did, he would have tracked much more carefully the medal that symbolizes his reputation for great military bravery. Second, it symbolizes his loss of a good reputation in the assisted living facility, where even the nurses think of him as a miserable jerk. Mr. Solway's casual assertion that amnesia has improved Chase's personality, meanwhile, highlights both Mr. Solway's blunt personality and the real changes Chase has undergone since his accident.*



When Chase points out that the accident took his memories, Mr. Solway quips that "[m]emory is overrated" and admits he can't remember the act for which he earned his **Medal of Honor**: the army medic told him he lost the memory due to the trauma of seeing a grenade explosion inside the occupied tank. Chase tries to comfort Mr. Solway by telling him that he was fighting an enemy during wartime, but Mr. Solway retorts that he still prefers to "forget the whole rotten business."

*The Korean War (1950-1953) was a brutally violent conflict during which both sides committed atrocities. Mr. Solway thinks of the war as a "rotten business," believes "memory is overrated," and found the incident for which he won a Medal of Honor so traumatically violent that he repressed it—details suggesting both that society may value traditionally masculine, violent, military bravery too highly and that people's reputations may not square at all with their memories or their self-conceptions.*



Chase wonders whether he can't remember being a bully because he doesn't want to, the way that Mr. Solway has repressed traumatic memories. He concludes that the situations aren't parallel; besides, he's begun remembering decontextualized images—though he's not convinced they're "real." He dreams about cherry bombs going off in a kid's piano, but when he checks an old yearbook, he discovers Joel Weber wasn't the kid in his dream. He even dreams about blowing himself up during the Korean War because he can't bring himself to drop a live grenade into a tank. His realest-seeming memory is still of the girl in the fancy dress.

*When Chase considers—only to reject—a possible parallel between his amnesia and Mr. Solway's repression of traumatically violent war memories, it shows his growing thoughtfulness. His suspicions about the "real[ity]" of his memories emphasizes that while memory is important to identity, it isn't always trustworthy. Finally, his dream about the cherry bombs in the piano show his growing guilt about his past as a bully.*



Chase is helping video club with the yearbook. So many kids flee when he comes to interview them that he's started preemptively mentioning Brendan's name. Though most video club kids are fine with Chase now, Shoshanna still makes snide remarks about him joining. Kimberly has joined too. She's terrible at film, but Brendan defends her so spiritedly from criticism that Chase suspects he likes her.

*Just as Chase's bad reputation got him in trouble at the car wash and Brendan's good reputation saved them, so Chase's bad reputation hampers his ability to get projects done for video yearbook while Brendan's good one helps him. Clearly, reputation doesn't entirely track social status, as desperately uncool, low-status Brendan still has a better overall reputation than Chase.*



After Brendan shows the club his latest YouTube short, Shoshanna tells him he should stop wasting his time and contribute to her National Video Journalism Contest project, which could be great if they choose the right interviewee. Chase suggests Mr. Solway. Shoshanna just glares, but Kimberly asks who Mr. Solway is. When Chase explains that he's a veteran who won the **Medal of Honor**, Shoshanna asks how Chase would know "someone like that." Chase awkwardly admits he knows him from community service. When faculty advisor Ms. DeLeo compliments Chase's idea, Shoshanna looks furious.

*When Shoshanna asks how Chase would know "someone like" Mr. Solway, i.e. the recipient of a Medal of Honor, she implies that Chase shouldn't even know someone with a reputation for heroism—emphasizing, yet again, the gap between people's reputations and their lived reality that the Medal of Honor symbolizes.*



## CHAPTER 13: SHOSHANNA WEBER

Shoshanna is furious that the video club kids have forgiven Chase just because he's a cool kid who pays attention to them—but her research suggests that the **Medal of Honor** is a rare award, so she decides to meet Mr. Solway. As she's walking to the assisted living facility, Joel messages to ask what she's doing. When she explains that she's meeting a war hero for her video project, Joel asks how she discovered him. Shoshanna doesn't want to tell Joel that Chase has insinuated himself into video club, of which Joel used to be a member, so she answers evasively.

*Shoshanna believes that the low-status video-club kids are giving Chase a second chance because his higher status in the social hierarchy has overawed them—an unfair interpretation of the club's behavior, given that all of them but Brendan initially wanted to exclude him from the club. Shoshanna's unfair interpretation, motivated by her anger and loyalty to Joel, is ironic inasmuch as she's interested in interviewing Mr. Solway precisely because his Medal of Honor marks him as a high-status person with a significant reputation, whatever he's actually like as an individual.*



In the facility, Shoshanna finds Mr. Solway's room and explains to him that she wants to interview him for a school video project because he won a **Medal of Honor**. Mr. Solway angrily tells her he's not superior to many other veterans and that he doesn't want gratitude or attention. Feeling defeated, Shoshanna privately compares him to Joel—determined to be loudly unhappy—though she thinks Joel has a right to be unhappy, whereas Mr. Solway is "just plain mean."

*Mr. Solway's anger at Shoshanna's request emphasizes that he feels his reputation for heroism, symbolized by the Medal of Honor, is undeserved: many soldiers who were as brave as he was never received such a medal. Shoshanna's internal response to Mr. Solway reveals her judgmental tendencies: she immediately decides that Mr. Solway reacts the way he does because he's "just plain mean," without considering other options, and indirectly criticizes Joel's vocal unhappiness at Melton even as she acknowledges his unhappiness is legitimate.*



Chase enters the room with a snack for Mr. Solway. Instantly, Mr. Solway looks happier. Shoshanna concludes that these two awful people would naturally get along. Chase tries to say hello to Shoshanna, though he cuts himself off when she gives him an angry look. When Mr. Solway asks whether Shoshanna is Chase's friend, Chase explains that they're in video club together and he suggested Mr. Solway as an interviewee. Abruptly, Mr. Solway changes his mind about being interviewed: he wants to help "the two of you out." Shoshanna, horrified that Chase is apparently now her partner in the contest, wonders what she'll say to Joel.

*Shoshanna observes that Chase and Mr. Solway are friendly and happy to see one another. Rather than alter her opinion of Chase or Mr. Solway in the face of new evidence, she decides they're friendly to one another because they're both terrible. Yet again, her love and loyalty to her brother are warping her judgment. Interestingly, however, when Mr. Solway is willing to help "the two" of them—that is, Shoshanna and Chase together—Shoshanna assumes that she has to work with Chase now. This unthinking assumption—she doesn't refuse to work with Chase, though she obviously could—reveals how much she cares about producing a great video for the contest.*



## CHAPTER 14: CHASE AMBROSE

Frank drives Chase home from dinner in his loud new Mustang (he wouldn't "be caught dead in Corinne's van"). When Chase mentions that he and Helene are friendlier now, Frank pulls a face, says that's because Chase "played princess with her," and notes that Chase didn't used to care whether he was friends with a little girl. Chase suggests it's preferable to Helene fearing him. Frank claims that she didn't really, but Chase used to be "tougher," like Aaron and Bear. Chase recalls both his past as a bully and as a sports star—he's ashamed of the former, but the latter made him feel "important and confident and powerful" in a way he's not ready to write off.

As Chase gets out of the car, Frank quickly mentions that he's found a doctor to give Chase a "second opinion." When Chase asks why, Frank says that this new doctor might tell him he could play football this year, giving him a shot at winning two state championships, something Frank never did. Chase, awed that Frank would suggest Chase might surpass him, decides to do it and says he'll tell Tina. Frank orders him not to, so as not to "worry her." Then he assures Chase that he'll have his "old life" back soon. Chase is excited to make up with his friends and get the positive feeling of being a sports star again.

Chase, Aaron, and Bear play catch with a football on their way to community service, endangering other pedestrians in the process. Chase hasn't told them about his appointment with the new doctor because he doesn't want to get their hopes up, but he himself is hopeful. At the assisted living facility, Chase spots Shoshanna entering—and quickly throws a distracting pass, because he doesn't want to explain to Aaron and Bear that he's partnered with her on a project.

*Frank criticizes his own wife's perfectly functional van, insists on driving a muscle car, expresses distaste for Chase making friends with his little sister Helene because it involves "play[ing] princess with her," and even implies that it would be better for Chase to scare her a little so long as Chase was "tougher." In sum, Frank's obsession with himself and his son embodying traditional masculinity is intense and unreasonable. Chase, more thoughtful than his father, sees both his negative past as a bully and his positive past as a successful athlete as characteristic of traditional masculinity: he wants to eschew the former but still appreciates how "important and confident" the latter made him feel.*



*Even though one doctor has already suggested it might be dangerous for Chase to play football for a while, Frank has hunted down a "second opinion" and instructed Chase not to "worry" his mother with the information. That is, Frank is trying to get Chase back on the football field by whatever means necessary and hiding this potentially dangerous course of action from his ex-wife, who would likely object. Though Frank's obsession with athletic success and traditional masculinity are unreasonable, Chase wants his father's approval so badly—and wants a stable, positive identity like "star athlete" so badly—that he goes along with the dubious plan.*



*There is nothing inherently wrong with athletics, but the fact that Chase, Aaron, and Bear play catch in a way that endangers other pedestrians suggests that the social status athletic success confers on them makes them reckless, careless, and mean to other people. Though it isn't yet clear why Chase doesn't want Aaron and Bear to know that he's working with Shoshanna, his concealment of the fact suggests that he feels a tension between resuming his old identity of sports star and pursuing his new interests, e.g. film.*



It's Chase's third day filming Shoshanna as she interviews Mr. Solway. Though many of his stories are tragic, a lot are funny: it turns out Mr. Solway was the army's version of a "class clown." During one such funny story, Aaron and Bear appear in the door, looking shocked. Chase calls for an intermission in filming and goes to talk to them in the hallway. Aaron's angry that Chase would work with Shoshanna after her family got them community service. When Chase suggests that maybe if he helps Shoshanna, the family will be "forgiving," Aaron tells him that will never happen—but he can ditch his friends to hang out with people who hate him if he wants.

Chase feels bad, as if he's betrayed Aaron, because he concealed the project from him and Bear. Bear goes on to complain about Chase befriending Mr. Solway in particular. When Chase protests that Mr. Solway is a fascinating "war hero," they both give him strange looks. Eventually, Aaron says they know that. When Chase says he thought they might've forgotten, Aaron and Bear get defensive and storm away—though not before Bear makes a crack about Chase's own memory. Internally, Chase berates himself for making his friends feel like "they can't trust [him] anymore."

When Chase goes back into Mr. Solway's room, Shoshanna is hunting through the stuffed, messy closet. She tells Chase that she wants shots of Mr. Solway's mementos to intersperse with footage of him being interviewed. As Mr. Solway looks on curiously, Chase notes how much livelier Mr. Solway seems; he speculates that his and Shoshanna's visits and interviews have given Mr. Solway a new reason to engage with life after his wife's death. In the closet, Shoshanna finds several mementos, including the case for his **Medal of Honor**. Yet when she opens the case, it's empty.

*The revelation that Mr. Solway used to be the army's "class clown" may conflict with readers' assumptions about how a decorated war hero would act—a conflict emphasizing once again the gap between what people assume about individuals based on their reputations and how those individuals actually behave. Aaron's anger at Chase for working with Shoshanna highlights that he values loyalty over morality: he wants Chase to be angry at Shoshanna and her family because, he, Aaron, and Bear were punished for bullying Shoshanna's brother, even though Chase, Aaron, and Bear are absolutely guilty of the behavior in question.*



*Aaron is angry at Chase for not showing him and Bear irrational loyalty; Chase, who wants to think well of his friends, willfully misrecognizes Aaron's anger about his supposed "disloyalty" as anger about Chase's actual dishonesty, and he feels guilty for acting in a way that makes his friends feel like they "can't [trust] him." Meanwhile, when Chase reminds his friends that Mr. Solway is a war hero, Aaron and Bear's insistence that of course they know this is a little strange. After all, Aaron and Bear refuse to learn even the residents' names, referring to them as "Dumbledore" and "Dumbledora." Aaron and Bear's acute awareness of Mr. Solway's war-hero status suggests that Mr. Solway's background may be important to Aaron and Bear in a way that Chase has yet to realize or has forgotten.*



*Elderly Mr. Solway has a new lease on life after making friends with two eighth graders, while Chase and Shoshanna are learning a tremendous amount of history from interviewing Mr. Solway. This unlikely fact shows how rigid social hierarchies and social spheres can prevent people of disparate kinds from making friendships that would enrich their lives. The empty Medal of Honor case, meanwhile, suggests that Mr. Solway was correct in supposing that he no longer had possession of his medal; his unemotional response to losing the medal shows his lack of personal investment in his own war-hero reputation, which the medal symbolizes.*





Shoshanna and Chase can't find the **medal** anywhere else in the closet. Shoshanna asks when Mr. Solway last wore the medal. At first, he responds sarcastically; then he admits he never wore it, because wearing it would have felt like a strange form of bragging in front of other, less decorated veterans. His wife took it out, cleaned it, and put it back in its case every Veterans Day; he suggests that she may have lost it during her cognitive decline before her death. Chase knows that it's hard for Mr. Solway to talk about his wife, so he and Shoshanna soon make excuses to leave him be.

Shoshanna suggests that it's strange of Mr. Solway to win a **Medal of Honor** and then treat it with such indifference. When Chase suggests that older generations are "more modest," Shoshanna insists it's still strange to bury a Medal of Honor in your closet. Abruptly, Chase intuits that Mr. Solway didn't bury the medal—someone *stole* the medal and buried the medal case in the closet to hide the crime. He remembers Bear taking a \$20 from the confused elderly woman and Aaron going along with it for pizza money. Shoshanna asks whether Chase is all right, noting that he looks strange. Chase claims he is, but internally, he's wondering whether he's a bad friend for suspecting Aaron and Bear of stealing the medal—and wondering what he should do.

*Mr. Solway never wore his Medal of Honor because it felt like a form of bragging. In other words, he felt that objects like the medal—physical symbols of an excellent reputation—reinforced a social hierarchy within the category of veterans that he didn't believe in or want to support. Mr. Solway, a cynical but empathetic "class clown" type, doesn't really respect reputations or hierarchies.*



*Chase is correct that Mr. Solway is modest, in that Mr. Solway doesn't want to rub his war-hero reputation, symbolized by the Medal of Honor, in other people's faces. Yet Shoshanna's insistence that Mr. Solway's cavalier attitude is strange triggers Chase's realization that the medal may have been stolen. Chase has good reason to believe that Bear and Aaron may have stolen it: he's witnessed Bear stealing from a resident at the facility before. Yet loyalty makes him worry that his reasonable suspicions render him a bad friend.*



## CHAPTER 15: BRENDAN ESPINOZA

Brendan has a massive crush on Kimberly, but she clearly likes Chase. Brendan develops a plan: he'll impress Kimberly by getting her to collaborate with him on a YouTube short, which will lead her to realize he's "destined" to be "famous." She refuses the collaboration, however, until Brendan tells her that Chase will work on it too. When Brendan asks for Chase's help with the short—which Brendan has titled *Leaf Man*—Chase says he's too busy with Shoshanna and Mr. Solway, but he eventually gives in to Brendan's wheedling.

*Brendan's plan to woo Kimberly is based on a belief that the higher your social status, the more people like you. Brendan, an "uncool" kid, currently has low social status—but he wants to convince Kimberly that eventually he'll be a "famous" YouTube star, i.e., a much higher-status person. Yet it isn't at all clear whether Brendan's assumptions about Kimberly are correct: after all, her crush on Chase has persisted even though he isn't currently playing football, and she's joined the "uncool" video club in order to spend more time with him.*



Brendan, Chase, and Kimberly meet in the park, where Brendan puts on rollerblades and asks Chase and Kimberly to cover him in syrup. When Kimberly, baffled, asks why, Brendan explains that he's going to rollerblade into a pile of leaves and come out as "Leaf Man." Chase and Kimberly pour syrup on Brendan and film him rollerblading at dangerous speed into the leaves. After crashing, Brendan catches his breath a moment, stands up covered in sticky leaves, and yells, "Leaf Man!" Then every dog in the park rushes over to lick syrup off him. Chase films it, laughing hysterically. Kimberly doesn't understand why it's funny—but despite that, Brendan's even more infatuated with her than before.

*Like Chase, Aaron, and Bear putting cherry bombs in a piano, Brendan has an eye for stupid, dangerous, visually spectacular stunts. The relevant difference is, Brendan's stunts aren't intended to frighten, intimidate, or bully anyone, and the only person they endanger is Brendan himself.*



## CHAPTER 16: SHOSHANNA WEBER

Joel, deeply unhappy at boarding school, keeps calling Shoshanna and their parents to ask about things at home. Shoshanna still avoids telling him about the contest video, Chase, and Mr. Solway, though she's started hanging out with Chase and Mr. Solway even when they're not working on the project. Though it feels disloyal, Shoshanna can't help but notice that Chase's personality has totally changed: he's become kind, almost like a "grandson" to the childless Mr. Solway. Chase's friendship with Mr. Solway is much deeper than hers; Mr. Solway thinks of her as Chase's friend or, possibly, girlfriend. When Mr. Solway calls her that, she and Chase both blush and correct him—but Mr. Solway just thinks they're in denial.

Though Mr. Solway is much friendlier now, he's still ornery, argumentative, and sometimes tiresome—even to himself. One day, after he falls asleep on himself, Chase and Shoshanna decide to leave him in peace, go get food, and watch the footage they've collected. Shoshanna suggests the frozen yogurt shop for food, promising not to dump hers on Chase this time. While watching footage, they agree that they'll keep visiting Mr. Solway after the project is over.

Someone in the shop says Shoshanna's name. It's her mother, staring in shock at her daughter working comfortably with Chase. When Shoshanna tries to explain, her mother demands that Shoshanna go get in the family car. Chase tries to speak, and Shoshanna's mother interrupts, criticizing his nerve and telling him not to come near anyone in the Weber family. As Shoshanna's mother forces her out the shop door, Shoshanna asks whether they can at least talk—and her mother assures her that they *will* talk.

Shoshanna's mother and father stage an intervention at home, telling Shoshanna she can't be friends with Joel's bully. Shoshanna explains that they aren't friends, exactly—Chase joined the video club and found the subject for Shoshanna's contest entry. When Shoshanna's father suggests that Chase might have nefarious ulterior motives for working with her, she says that she hated the old Chase, but he's changed since his amnesia, and she's starting to like him as a person. Her mother says that it doesn't matter whether Chase has changed, because what he did to Joel was "unforgivable."

*Shoshanna is a smart girl. Though loyalty to Joel has distorted her judgment up to this point, she can't help but recognize that amnesia has seriously affected Chase's personality and that Chase and Mr. Solway have developed a real friendship, almost like the familial love between grandfather and "grandson." Mr. Solway's casual supposition that Shoshanna and Chase are dating—though they aren't—even hints that the two kids may be developing crushes on each other.*



*Chase and Shoshanna's agreement to keep visiting Mr. Solway after the video is over makes clear that they value his friendship, though the two kids and Mr. Solway exist in such different social spheres that they might never have interacted were it not for Chase's community service and the video context. This fact emphasizes that interacting with people in different social spheres from one's own can be a valuable, generative experience.*



*Shoshanna's mother's anger at Chase is justified: before his accident, Chase bullied her son Joel so badly that she felt she had to send Joel to boarding school. Yet her refusal to listen to what Shoshanna has to say about Chase suggests that she is too invested in her own narrative about who Chase is to alter her opinion based on new evidence.*



*Shoshanna's mother claims that even if Chase's personality has altered, what he did was "unforgivable" and so Shoshanna can't become friends with him. This harsh concept of responsibility entails that even if an individual grows and changes after committing a bad act, it's reasonable to despise them forever if the act was bad enough. Yet Shoshanna's mother and father haven't interacted with Chase since his accident; it's unclear whether they will remain so harshly judgmental if they do.*



Shoshanna's father speculates that Shoshanna hasn't told Joel she's working with Chase. Shoshanna admits she hasn't—and then says that maybe she should: Joel hates boarding school, but since Chase doesn't even remember the version of himself who bullied Joel, maybe Joel can come home. Though her parents are clearly struck by the idea, her dad asks what will happen if Shoshanna is incorrect in her assessment of the situation. Shoshanna isn't sure, but she wants Joel to come home, so she messages him saying they have things to discuss.

*While Shoshanna's mother claims Chase can never be forgiven for his bullying, both she and Shoshanna's father are immediately distracted from judging him when Shoshanna breaches the possibility that Joel could return home—an action that would partially reverse the damage Chase did. This reaction suggests that pain over Joel's absence is partially motivating the Weber parents' extremely harsh attitude toward post-accident Chase.*



## CHAPTER 17: JOEL WEBER

Back home, Joel feels like his life is out of whack. He loathed Melton—though a talented pianist, he wasn't obsessed with his instrument the way the other students were—but now that he's where he wants to be, his parents are nervously overattentive, while Shoshanna won't stop mentioning Chase. When Joel snaps at her about it, she points out he'll have to interact with Chase if he returns to video club. He responds sarcastically, but she comments, understandingly, that he must be nervous. He is: the bullying he suffered took a toll. He's still shaking off the terrified mentality it engendered in him.

*Joel's lingering fear illustrates that bullying is wrong not only because of the immediate physical harm or fear it may engender but because of the long-term psychological damage it causes: Joel is still only beginning to recover from last year's bullying.*



When Joel returns to school on Monday, a few kids whisper about him in the hallway, but most don't even seem to have noticed he was gone—which rankles him. Shoshanna hovers over Joel with such annoying protective energy that he tells her to leave him alone. In one class, Brendan tells Joel all about his latest YouTube shorts and about Chase's fabulous new personality, the latter of which annoys Joel; he wishes the whole video club hadn't become Chase fans. In another class, Bear starts bullying Joel—but Aaron drags him away so they don't get in more trouble.

*It may be reasonable for the video-club kids to give Chase a second chance after Chase has demonstrated significant personality changes, but it also makes sense that Joel dislikes how enthusiastic his friends are now about the kid who viciously bullied him—which explains why characters from Shoshanna to Aaron care so much about loyalty, even when it's irrational. That Aaron stops Bear from bullying Joel again—for the moment—reminds readers that Aaron is smarter than Bear, though perhaps for that reason ultimately a more dangerous bully.*



Joel enters video club after school while they're screening footage of Mr. Solway. The club's faculty advisor Ms. DeLeo pauses the video, all the kids crowd around Joel, and then Shoshanna performs a formal (re)introduction of Joel and Chase. Chase, looking horribly unhappy, says that he's hugely regretful about what he did to Joel, even though he can't remember any of it. Joel, to his own surprise, realizes that he believes in Chase's amnesia and in his apology—but still loathes him anyway.

*Joel hates Chase even though he believes that Chase is genuinely sorry for what he did—which suggests that, on an emotional level, he cares less about Chase's present identity than he does about Chase's responsibility for his past victimization.*



## CHAPTER 18: CHASE AMBROSE

In the cafeteria, Chase is reading the court sentence commanding him, Aaron, and Bear to community service, which he found while looking for his birth certificate for Frank to give to the new doctor. Brendan touches his shoulder, and Chase startles so badly that Brendan leaps backward. When Brendan asks what has upset him, Chase thinks about the judge's extremely negative take on his character, Helene's fear of him, Corinne's discomfort around him, and the loyalty that the morally dubious Aaron and Bear have always showed him.

Chase asks how terrible he really was before his accident. At first, Brendan avoids the question, but then he points to a scar on his face: Chase shoved Brendan's head into a water fountain and strolled on like nothing had happened, but Brendan needed stitches. Chase, speechless, thinks about how meaningless the loyalty he, Aaron, and Bear share must be. Brendan somberly assures Chase that he's changed since then and leaves. Yet Chase is coming to believe that even if some of the people he's wronged accept him now, he can't change the things he's already done. He's horrified that he and his friends hurt weaker kids to feel "like big men."

Chase's past sins notwithstanding, he and Shoshanna are working well together on the video project and continuing to visit Mr. Solway. On their way to the assisted living facility, Shoshanna often stops at her house to back up ongoing edits to their video project. Chase waits outside, aware he isn't welcome in the Weber house. One day, while waiting, Chase hears Joel playing the piano superbly and—without thinking—walks to the window to listen. Miserable that he bullied Joel for being talented, Chase doesn't notice the Webers' dog barreling toward him till it's already bitten him. He topples into some bushes.

When the Webers discover Chase in their bushes, Shoshanna explains what he's doing there—narrowly preventing her mother from calling the police. Mrs. Weber, somewhat resentfully, takes Chase inside to disinfect his scratches from the bush he fell into (the dog didn't bite through his clothes). Chase notices that she, Joel, and even Shoshanna take a little pleasure in his obvious physical pain. Knowing the reason behind their pleasure makes him feel awful. Yet the next time Chase is waiting outside the house for Shoshanna, Joel opens the window while practicing—apparently so that Chase can enjoy the music more easily.

*Although Chase's court sentence is another external report on him, not as immediate as a memory, the judge may be more objective than the other people who have been giving Chase an understanding of his pre-accident reputation. With this more objective document harshly judging him, Chase begins to see Helene and Corinne's unease around him as a damning indictment of the person he used to be.*



*Here, Chase realizes that loyalty can be an irrational and even a destructive force if it leads you to defend and cooperate with people who are doing bad things. He also makes an explicit connection between his desire to embody stereotypical masculinity—a desire inculcated in him by his father—and his bullying; he believes that he and his football-player friends physically harmed kids like Brendan because they wanted to feel macho, "like big men."*



*In the previous passage, Chase concluded that he bullied kids like Brendan because he wanted to feel masculine. Here, he assumes that he bullied Joel because Joel was talented—suggesting either that he was jealous of Joel's talent or that he held Joel in contempt for being talented at something not currently associated with rugged masculinity, like playing the piano extremely well.*



*Yet again, Chase's (well-earned) bad reputation puts him in danger of arrest, even though he wasn't trying to harm anyone. The Webers' amusement at Chase's physical pain reveals how much they resent Chase for bullying Joel—despite Chase's prior awful behavior, it is disturbing that an adult woman, Mrs. Weber, is enjoying a 13-year-old's pain, even if she's ultimately trying to help him. At the same time, Joel seems to recognize and respond to Chase's genuine pleasure at his musical talent, which suggests that Joel is coming to appreciate more fully just how much Chase is growing and changing.*



Chase is finding lunch at school stressful. He alternates between eating with the football team and the video club; the football team is constantly criticizing him for hanging out with the nerdy video club, and the video club is awkward about Chase and Joel being anywhere near each other.

Bear criticizes Chase for spending time near Joel, whom Bear blames for their community service. Chase replies that they weren't sentenced because Joel snitched—they boobytrapped a piano in an auditorium full of witnesses. Though Aaron tries to get them to stop sniping at each other and move on, Chase demands to know why Bear thinks Joel is extra-deserving of bullying—is it his size or his musical talent? Bear angrily points out that Chase targeted Joel in the first place because he thought it was hilarious to watch Joel lose his mind. Even if Chase didn't feel good about Joel switching schools, he was more focused on his own community service at that point. Chase is horrified by this insight into his own former mindset.

Later that day, after Chase and Shoshanna have finally finished editing their video project, they stop by Shoshanna's house to back it up before going to show it to Mr. Solway. Though Chase is planning to wait outside as usual, Shoshanna asks whether he'll come in. Chase, startled and trepidatious, follows her inside. Both Mrs. Weber and Joel pause when they see him, but then they go back to what they were doing—and the dog actually seems friendly. This reaction fills Chase with a strong, unnamed feeling.

## CHAPTER 19: BEAR BRATSKY

The school is summoned to an assembly to watch Chase and Shoshanna's documentary project about Mr. Solway. When Bear and Aaron realize what they're watching, they're furious. Aaron complains that Chase has not only made them look bad by voluntarily doing community service but also boasted about his own virtue through the video—and teamed up with Shoshanna, whose family got them in trouble. Bear adds darkly that it can't be a "coincidence" that they chose Mr. Solway to interview. When Aaron reminds Bear that Chase can't remember "that," Bear again expresses doubts that Chase really has amnesia.

*Chase's decision to split time between the football team and the video club causes angst in both camps, which shows not only the middle school's extreme social stratification but also the lingering effects of Chase's past bullying of Joel.*



*Bear blames Joel, the victim of his and his friends' bullying, for their well-deserved punishment, which shows that Bear isn't self-reflective enough to recognize that they're responsible for the consequences of their own actions. Chase, by contrast, has come to recognize that he and his friends are—as the saying goes—lying in the bed they made. Aaron's attempt to make peace between Bear and Chase demonstrates his continued loyalty to both his best friends. When Chase keeps snapping at Bear, Bear snaps back that active, sadistic enjoyment of Joel's psychological suffering (not mere callousness) motivated Chase's bullying of Joel. Bear may or may not be right—it's not clear how insightful he is—but Chase, already disturbed by his own past behavior, is more than ready to believe his condemnation.*



*The Webers—somewhat cautiously—accept Chase's presence in their house, a sign that they recognize how his identity is evolving in a positive direction even if they haven't entirely forgiven him for bullying Joel. Their cautious acceptance moves Chase so deeply that he's not even sure exactly what emotion he's feeling.*



*Bear and Aaron's references to a "coincidence" and "that" hint that they and Chase had some meaningful encounter with Mr. Solway that Chase can't remember. Additionally, Aaron believes that Chase is showing off his moral fiber by working with Mr. Solway and betraying them by teaming up with Shoshanna, whose family Aaron blames for their community service—a paranoid interpretation of Chase's behavior as "disloyal" that betrays how unwilling Aaron is to take responsibility and deserved punishment for his own participation in bullying Joel.*





When the documentary shows a clip of a generic **Medal of Honor**, Shoshanna's voiceover explains that Mr. Solway was so modest that he forgot where he put his. Bear says: "Yeah, right." Aaron shushes him fiercely. After the video ends, everyone claps, annoying Bear, who's sure the other kids found the video as tedious as he did. Ms. DeLeo reads out a letter from the assisted living facility's director praising Chase and Shoshanna. This infuriates Bear, who feels that everyone at the facility hates him. When he complains, Aaron suggests doing something to "remind [Chase] who his real friends are."

Bear's "Yeah, right" could be expressing disbelief either about Mr. Solway's modesty or about Mr. Solway having lost his medal. If the latter, the novel may be hinting that Bear knows what really happened to the medal. Bear's anger that people at the facility like Chase but dislike him once again shows his difficulty taking responsibility for his own behavior: after all, people at the facility dislike Bear because he mistreats and disrespects them. The last time Aaron told Chase to remember "who [his] friends are," he was criticizing Chase for disloyalty after Chase got between Brendan and a football player who was bullying Brendan. By echoing that line here, Aaron implies that he wants to punish Chase for his perceived disloyalty.



## CHAPTER 20: BRENDAN ESPINOZA

Unfortunately, while Leaf Man got a lot of views, it didn't go viral—and it made Kimberly think Brendan might be crazy. Brendan decides to make another video to impress her: he'll splice himself playing a whole bunch of instruments into a single frame so that he appears to be an entire orchestra. Joel reserves the band room for Brendan—and no one's suspicious, because Joel is "known to be a good kid." Joel and Kimberly will work the cameras, since Chase is busy retaking a test he missed for a doctor's appointment.

Brendan persists in trying to create a viral video to impress Kimberly rather than stopping and wondering whether she cares as much about social status as he's been assuming. By stereotyping Kimberly as a girl who only likes high-status boys, Brendan illustrates that "uncool" kids stereotype others in the same way "cool" kids do. Meanwhile, Joel is able to get away with aiding Brendan in questionable behavior because he's "known to be a good kid," showing yet again how people's reputations largely shape how their actions are interpreted.



With Kimberly watching, Joel films Brendan while he fakes playing each instrument in turn, until, finally, he reaches a marching-band tuba. Brendan wriggles into the tuba-holding position, and Joel hits play on the tripod-mounted camera. Then Aaron and Bear burst into the room and spray them with fire extinguishers. As they cover Joel with foam, Kimberly laughs, thinking it's part of the video. Brendan yells at her to get help. Bear sarcastically suggests they fetch their "friend" Chase. Brendan, thinking that's a good idea, tells Kimberly to run for Chase. Aaron scornfully claims that Chase sent them to the band room to get revenge on the person who caused their community service. Nevertheless, Kimberly runs out the door.

Brendan presumably thinks that Chase may help them because, quite recently, Chase physically stopped another football player from bullying Brendan. Yet Bear calls Chase the video-club kids' "friend" in a sarcastic tone, and Aaron claims that Chase masterminded this current bullying incident. Since Aaron just suggested to Bear that they should prove to Chase who his "real" friends are, readers may infer that Aaron and Bear are trying to show Chase that the video-club kids aren't loyal friends.



When Bear kicks a French horn, Joel begs him not to damage the instruments—which sends Bear and Aaron into a frenzy, throwing instruments around. Brendan tries to stop them, but he's helpless, unable to get out of the tuba. Chase and Kimberly sprint into the room. When Chase demands to know what's going on, Bear claims it was Chase's plan and hands him a fire extinguisher, while Aaron urges Chase to "bring it home." Chase is frozen. Bear, annoyed by Chase's hesitation, tries to take the extinguisher back. They fight over it—and when Chase wins, the release sends him spinning so that he hits Joel in the head with it.

A half dozen teachers run into the room. When Brendan sees Joel bruised, the music room trashed and foamy, and Chase holding a fire extinguisher, he realizes what the teachers will think and yells that it "isn't what it looks like!" Right afterward, though, he worries that it *is* what it looks like: maybe Chase did orchestrate the bullying like Aaron and Bear claimed.

The teachers ignore Brendan. One escorts Joel to the nurse, while the others take Chase, Aaron, and Bear to the principal's office. Kimberly follows Chase. Brendan, trapped in the tuba, mourns that Chase is still all she can think about. He scolds himself for caring more about Kimberly than about Chase's possible betrayal and then argues with himself about whether Chase has changed. Suddenly, Kimberly reappears and offers to help Brendan escape the tuba. He immediately feels more optimistic.

## CHAPTER 21: CHASE AMBROSE

As Aaron, Bear, and Chase wait for principal Dr. Fitzwallace outside his office, Chase demands to know why Aaron and Bear just pulled a prank that could get them kicked off the football team. Bear, grinning, points out that *they* didn't smack Joel Weber. When Chase protests that that was an accident, Bear says that Dr. Fitzwallace won't believe that—and the video club won't confirm Chase's story.

*From Brendan's perspective, it seems Chase hit Joel with the fire extinguisher by accident. Yet Chase has a (well-earned) bad reputation and has bullied Joel in the past. Readers may ask: will Chase's personal growth and changes in identity be enough to absolve him, or will everyone assume that Chase went back to his old ways? This is what Aaron and Bear are clearly hoping everyone will assume.*



*Brendan was the first of Chase's former bullying victims to realize that Chase had changed, and he and Chase are now good friends. If even he wonders whether Chase was involved in the bullying, it seems likely that everyone else will decide Chase is guilty based on his pre-accident behavior and bad reputation.*



*Due to Chase's past actions and bad reputation, the teachers seem so sure that Chase as well as Aaron and Bear are guilty—and so worried about Joel—that they ignore Brendan, who has not only yelled that the situation "isn't what it looks like" but is also lying on the floor, covered in foam, wearing a tuba. Kimberly, however, comes back to help him, which hints that he may have misjudged her by assuming she only cares about high-status boys.*



*This conversation confirms what readers likely already suspected: Aaron and Bear engineered this situation to show Chase that none of his new friends will loyally believe his innocence in a situation where it looks like Chase is bullying Joel Weber again.*



Chase accuses Aaron and Bear of “fram[ing]” him and of getting themselves in trouble just to spite him. Aaron says that they’re Chase’s friends and that they’re the ones who will protect him—he just has to follow their lead. When Dr. Fitzwallace ushers them into his office, he’s furious and disappointed. Before Chase can say anything, Aaron claims that an electrical short in the video equipment in the band room caused a fire as he and Bear were walking by. They ran in with fire extinguishers. Chase, hearing the noise, came to help. When Dr. Fitzwallace says the video club members describe the incident differently, Bear suggests they’re scared they’ll be punished for starting a fire.

Dr. Fitzwallace asks Chase whether Aaron’s story is true. To Chase’s surprise, the principal’s expression suggests that he wants Chase to say yes. Chase deduces that seriously punishing students is a lot of work—and suspending or expelling Aaron, Bear, and Chase will ruin the school’s football season. Reluctantly, Chase says Aaron is telling the truth.

Dr. Fitzwallace gives Chase, Aaron, and Bear a lecture about calling for adult help, but no punishment. As the boys wait for their parents to come get them, Bear gloats over Aaron’s successful lies, and Aaron celebrates how Chase “came through.” Chase, miserable, reflects that lying and getting away with bullying must have been a pattern in his pre-amnesia life. After Aaron and Bear’s parents have taken them away, Frank shows up, grinning, and praises Chase. When Chase tells him the situation “wasn’t great,” Frank retorts that avoiding punishment is “pretty great.” Truthfully, Chase isn’t sorry to have avoided serious punishment, but he hates how it happened.

*Chase is correct that Aaron and Bear are “fram[ing]” him, but their subsequent lies to Dr. Fitzwallace make clear that they don’t want to get Chase (or themselves) in official trouble. They simply want to alienate Chase from his new video-club friends by showing that said friends will discount Chase’s personality changes and attempts to take responsibility at the first hint of new bullying. Because Aaron and Bear judge actions in terms of loyalty and disloyalty, not right and wrong, they assume that Chase will abandon his new friends if they are “disloyally”—yet justifiably—suspicious of him.*



*Dr. Fitzwallace isn’t fully invested in holding Chase, Aaron, and Bear to account for bullying, both because it’s a lot of effort and because their athletic success helps the school. This disturbing fact illustrates how adult authorities can be complicit in athletes’ bullying of other students. Chase’s decision to back up Aaron’s lie is understandable—he doesn’t want to be punished for bullying Joel when he genuinely wasn’t bullying Joel—but also binds him more tightly to Aaron and Bear, who have just cruelly manipulated him and separated him from his new friends.*



*When Aaron tells Chase that he “came through,” it suggests that Aaron sees Chase’s lie as a demonstration of renewed loyalty to him and Bear, not the attempt to avoid undeserved punishment that it actually was. Frank tells Chase that avoiding punishment is “pretty great” even after Chase tries to tell him that the situation itself was bad—an irresponsible attitude for a father to take, one hinting that Frank’s macho immaturity actively encouraged Chase’s poor pre-accident behavior.*



The next morning, the video-club faculty advisor Ms. DeLeo finds Chase and tells him he's no longer in video club. When he asks whether Brendan explained that he's "innocent," she tells him that that's not exactly how Brendan described it—and that supporting Aaron and Bear's lies has made him look bad. Chase realizes that by lying, he's convinced the club that he's up to his old, nasty tricks. He promises Ms. DeLeo, shakily, that he'll avoid the club. Angry at Aaron and Bear, he avoids them all day—easier that day, because Frank is picking him up early for his appointment with the new doctor. Brendan is avoiding Chase in turn, and Shoshanna, when she sees him, gives him a death glare.

The new doctor clears Chase to play football—though, privately, Chase thinks he would "clear a dead man." As Frank drives Chase back, he celebrates Chase returning to the team. Chase reminds him that, according to the rules, he has to practice for three weeks before playing a game. Frank is pumped anyway. Chase isn't—he doesn't want to be the person he was when he was a football star—but he feels like he has to return to the team because he's lost the video club. Frank tries to tell Chase that the video club doesn't matter; he even praises the "statement" Chase made with Joel. Chase doesn't bother to explain that that's not what he was doing.

Frank drops Chase off at home, reminding him to go to football practice later that afternoon. Chase agrees listlessly. Back in his bedroom, he looks out his window onto the roof and feels as if he can remember sitting there. Impulsively, he climbs out onto the roof. From there, he can see the school, the football field, the assisted living facility, and the park where he and Brendan filmed *Leaf Man*. This last memory chokes him up: he preferred his new video-club identity to his old one, but it's been taken from him.

## CHAPTER 22: SHOSHANNA WEBER

Shoshanna now believes that Chase tricked them all into believing he was a new person to pull another horrible prank on Joel. Feeling stupid, angry, and ashamed, she wants to get rid of the video project she and Chase did on Mr. Solway. Brendan tries to tell her that Chase may be innocent—he only arrived after Kimberly went and got him, and he may have hit Joel by accident—but Shoshanna insists that his lie to cover for Aaron and Bear is "proof."

*Brendan did believe that Chase might be "innocent," though he wasn't sure. Mrs. DeLeo's account suggests either that Brendan changed his mind after Chase lied or that the other video-club kids refused to listen to Brendan's doubts—or perhaps both, as Brendan seems unwilling to interact with Chase, and Shoshanna is actively furious with him. In other words, Aaron and Bear's plan worked to prove the video-club kids' "disloyalty" worked—though it isn't clear whether it would have worked if Chase hadn't backslid in his personal growth and lied to avoid punishment, suggesting both that Aaron and Bear's concept of "loyalty" is deeply flawed and that Chase shouldn't have lied to protect himself, even though he didn't deserve to be punished.*



*Chase wants both a stable identity and friends. He thought he had found that with video club—but now that Aaron and Bear have taken that away from him, he feels that he has to "settle" for being the football team's star, even though he actively dislikes the person that identity encouraged him to be. Frank is disturbingly unhelpful: he praises the "statement" that Chase made with Joel—which is to say, he praises his son for hitting a smaller boy in the face with a fire extinguisher, apparently assuming that his son did it on purpose. This irresponsible parenting hints yet again that Frank's obsession with Chase's athletic prowess and macho identity ultimately led him to encourage pre-accident Chase's reckless and even violent behavior, including his bullying.*



*Chase can't really remember being a football player. Nevertheless, his negative moral judgment on the person he was as a football star leads him to believe that he would have preferred being a video-club kid. This belief shows Chase's personal growth: he prefers being a low-status video "geek" to being a high-status star athlete and a bully.*



*Chase's lie isn't actually "proof" that he hit Joel on purpose. Nevertheless, Shoshanna, as a smart girl, feels ashamed that the boy who bullied and victimized her brother might have "fooled" her into believing that he'd changed, so she is doubling down on her earlier judgments and rejections of him.*



Brendan acknowledges that Chase's lie seems bad but suggests that maybe they should give him "the benefit of the doubt." Shoshanna retorts that if Aaron and Bear framed Chase, they nearly got him into terrible trouble—but Chase is still going to football practice and eating lunch with them. When Brendan points out that video club won't let Chase eat lunch with them anymore, Shoshanna says that they're "protecting Joel." She compares Chase to a snake that has struck its prey and wriggled away.

Shoshanna believes that the whole video club agrees with her—even Brendan agrees, deep down. Yet they all keep mentioning Chase: how well he filmed, what good ideas he'd had, etc. Eventually Shoshanna blows up at them, telling them Chase is a terrible person who ought to stay with the football jocks. Yet Joel, unexpectedly, says the video club has gotten worse: no one has done anything as good as Chase and Shoshanna's video project. When Shoshanna pushes back, he informs her that the club can mention Chase if they want—he won't break, and he won't leave town again. Shoshanna realizes that Joel is maturing.

*Brendan wants to give Chase "the benefit of the doubt," which indicates not blind loyalty to Chase but a sense that Chase has earned, with his post-accident behavior, some further investigation before the video club condemns him. When Shoshanna compares Chase to a snake, she implies that he bullies people on vicious, predatory, animal instinct—that he's fundamentally incapable of change. Chase's supposedly unchanging cruelty means that the video-club kids can't ever trust him but can only try to "protect[] Joel" from him.*



*Chase, Aaron, and Bear's bullying of Joel was cruel not only because of the physical harm they did to him but also because of the state of constant fear they put him in. By asserting that he can handle mentions of Chase and won't "break" under emotional pressure again, Joel is asserting that he can limit the power their bullying has over him. Shoshanna sees this assertion as evidence of new maturity in Joel.*



## CHAPTER 23: CHASE AMBROSE

Chase is back at football practice—in a non-uniformed, non-contact capacity. Due to this special treatment, the other players lightly bully him, preventing him from drinking any of the team's Gatorade. Nevertheless, as Chase regains his football muscle memory, he realizes he enjoys playing. He thinks a person could be a football player and a video club kid, in theory, and he wonders why more people don't try activities outside of their comfort zone. He's also beginning to get along with the football team. He now understands, even if he doesn't condone, the way the violence of their sport affects how they interact with each other and with other students. He's so angry with how Aaron and Bear sabotaged his relationship with video club that he's still not talking to them, though.

*Here, Chase seems to distinguish between (on the one hand) the genuinely violent and cruel bullying he, Aaron, and Bear engaged in and (on the other hand) the mild hazing and occasional aggression the football players show to their teammates and other students: the former is far more destructive than the latter, even if the latter sometimes also goes too far. Chase shows how much he valued his friendships with Brendan, Shoshanna, and the other video club kids by refusing to speak with Aaron and Bear even though they've positioned themselves as his only friends.*





At the end of practice on Friday, the coach makes Chase run extra laps. While he's running, Bear tackles him into the ground—and Aaron claps. Bear accuses Chase of faking his amnesia and says they need to get even. Angry and confused, Chase demands to know why he would fake amnesia. Bear retorts that he'd do it to avoid paying his friends what he "owes." Chase denies owing them anything and says they're lucky he doesn't report them to the police for stealing Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**. Aaron, thunderstruck, says that Chase really does have amnesia—and informs him that he's the one who stole the medal.

Chase is about to punch Aaron when a memory hits him of taking the **medal** from its case. He realizes he should have known: before his accident, he was even worse than Aaron or Bear. When Aaron explains that they had a deal to split the value of the medal three ways, Chase says that he can't remember where the medal is—and if he finds it, he'll return it to Mr. Solway. Aaron claims he and Bear have a right to the value of the medal under the terms of their deal with the old Chase, and Bear threatens Chase. Chase yells at them and flees home, crying and hating himself.

## CHAPTER 24: BRENDAN ESPINOZA

After Chase was kicked out of video club, Kimberly stopped coming to meetings, which makes Brendan sad. He's even sadder that Chase is gone. The club has gotten much less innovative, and Brendan is mad at the other members for refusing to consider that Chase might be innocent. Though it was bad of Chase to back up Aaron and Bear's lie, Brendan doesn't believe he was just pretending to be the other video club members' friend and collaborator the whole time.

*Chase has suspected for a while that Aaron and Bear may have stolen Mr. Solway's Medal of Honor, but his suspicions make him feel like a bad, disloyal friend, so he doesn't voice them—until Aaron and Bear's manipulative, hostile behavior pushes him too far. Yet when Aaron accuses Chase of having stolen the medal, it makes perfect sense: Aaron and Bear have been worried from the novel's beginning about getting access to a mysterious, valuable "object" in Chase's possession that none of the boys seemed to have a legal right to. Just as the medal has previously symbolized the gap between Mr. Solway's reputation and his sense of self, so now the medal—which pre-accident Chase stole—symbolizes the gap between Chase's well-earned bad reputation and who he has tried to be since his accident.*



*Chase wants to take responsibility for his previous bad actions—in this case, stealing Mr. Solway's medal—and to make reparations. Just as Aaron and Bear have tried to thwart other positive changes in Chase's personality, here they claim they'll prevent him from returning the stolen medal. Bear even threatens Chase, revealing the limits of his and Aaron's supposed "loyalty."*



*Brendan actually cares more about Chase's friendship than he does about Kimberly's affections, which shows that he was Chase's "real friend" despite Aaron and Bear's claims to the contrary. Notably, he refuses to believe Aaron and Bear's frame job not out of loyalty but because he's witnessed the changes in Chase's identity with his own eyes and finds it hard to believe they were faked.*



To perk up the club, Brendan decides to make a new video. He sees a slug climbing a building and pulls out a camera to film it. When he tries to record, nothing happens, and the viewfinder informs him that the camera's memory is full—though the club's faculty advisor Mrs. DeLeo usually requires video club members to download their footage and wipe the cameras every day. Brendan plays what's on the camera and realizes it's from his orchestra video project, interrupted by Aaron and Bear. The footage shows both that there was no fire and that Chase hit Joel with the fire extinguisher accidentally. Excited, Brendan texts Chase, Shoshanna, and Joel to come to his house the following morning to see "something important." Then he sends the same text to Kimberly, adding that Chase will be there.

Everyone except Brendan interpreted Chase's ambiguous behavior during Aaron and Bear's frame job according to Chase's past identity as a bully and his bad reputation. Though Brendan believes in Chase, he can't convince anyone to share his belief—until he finds video footage.



## CHAPTER 25: CHASE AMBROSE

When Chase receives Brendan's text, he's confused about what Brendan could have to show him, but he decides to go anyway. He'd like to laugh at one of Brendan's videos; right now, he's miserable because he's learned he's a "criminal" in addition to having an overbearing father (Frank) and nasty friends (Aaron and Bear). He's terrified that, due to his amnesia, he won't be able to find the **Medal of Honor** and give it back to Mr. Solway before Mr. Solway dies.

To take responsibility and make amends for his theft, Chase wants to give the Medal of Honor back to Mr. Solway: this is the only way to bring his present self into alignment with the person he wants to be. Ironically, though, Chase can't make amends because he can't remember where he put the medal, a detail emphasizing that memory is important not only to understanding oneself but to taking responsibility for one's past behavior.



The idea of going to Brendan's house is a little hurtful for Chase. He worries that the video club's quick judgment about his return to bullying means they were never really his friends. Yet he's glad Brendan has resumed contact with him. As he leaves his own house for Brendan's, he sees that his neighbors are moving—and, to his shock, two movers are carrying a painting that represents the little blond girl from his first memory. He realizes that he was remembering a painting, not a person.

Although Chase doesn't have the same rigid views on loyalty and friendship that Aaron does, he still worries that the members of the video club were never really his friends if they reverted to distrusting him at the first sign he might have done something wrong—a natural worry for an adolescent to have. Then, suddenly, the little blond girl from Chase's first post-accident memory appears, though the significance of her being a character in a painting is not yet clear.



Chase runs to his neighbor, Mrs. Tottenham, and asks whether she ever showed him the painting. She says no and points to the upstairs solarium where the painting used to hang. Chase realizes that he must have seen the painting through the solarium window while sitting on his own roof. He runs back into his own house, goes upstairs, and climbs out onto the roof. He inches to the highest point, trying to find the place from which he saw the painting. Though he does find it, it doesn't trigger any memories. Climbing back down, however, he catches sight of Mr. Solway's **medal** stuffed behind a "loose shake."

Chase finds Mr. Solway's medal while trying to determine where he saw the little blond girl, the content of his only memory. This apparent coincidence suggests that Mr. Solway's medal is somehow centrally important to Chase's loss of memory and identity, though readers don't yet know how.



Suddenly, Chase remembers his accident: he had just hidden the **medal** and was laughing at his overweight neighbor Mr. Tottenham doing yoga in spandex in the solarium. He tried to sneak a phone picture of Mr. Tottenham, lost his balance, and slid off the roof. Defeatedly, Chase wonders whether he would have just shown the photo to Aaron and Bear or spread it all over the internet. He feels “grateful” he’s not that person anymore. Medal in hand, Chase climbs back into his house. He blasts past Tina (who’s yelling at him for climbing on the roof), yells over his shoulder that he’s headed to the assisted living facility, and runs off to return the medal to Mr. Solway.

*Chase fell off the roof and lost his memory while hiding Mr. Solway’s medal and trying to harvest material with which he could cyberbully his neighbor. This revelation suggests that, according to the novel’s internal logic, Chase lost his memories and identity as comeuppance for stealing Mr. Solway’s “identity” (that is, the medal symbolizing his good reputation) and bullying. It is only by taking responsibility and making amends—returning the medal to its rightful owner—that Chase can start becoming the better person he has realized he wants to be.*



## CHAPTER 26: JOEL WEBER

Joel thinks that his family members are more disturbed by his bruise than he is. His parents worry that bringing him home might have been a mistake, even though he assures them he was miserable at Melton. Joel is worried about the bullying too—somehow, it made him feel like he deserved to suffer—but he’s more upset that Chase’s apparent reformation fooled him. Shoshanna, meanwhile, keeps describing the horrific tortures she’d like to inflict on Chase. When Joel tells her she would never actually do those things to a person, she says she’s talking about “Alpha Rat,” not “another human being.”

*The novel has previously made clear that Chase, Aaron, and Bear’s bullying of Joel harmed him psychologically by making him afraid all the time. Here, readers learn that it also harmed him by undermining his self-esteem, making him believe he somehow deserved their bullying. Thus, the novel drives home that bullying’s negative effects extend beyond short-term physical or emotional pain. Shoshanna has reverted to calling Chase “Alpha Rat” and denies that he’s a human being, emphasizing that she stereotypes bullies as animals acting on predatory instinct rather than people with flaws who might be capable of change.*



As Joel and Shoshanna walk to Brendan’s house, Joel wonders aloud what Brendan wants. When they run into Kimberly in front of Brendan’s, Shoshanna asks whether Kimberly got Brendan’s text too. Kimberly nods and says Chase will be coming as well. Shoshanna tries to pull Joel back the way they came. Brendan exits the house and asks where they’re going. When Shoshanna says neither she nor Joel will be interacting with Chase, Brendan blurts that he has video evidence that Chase didn’t mean to hurt Joel. Shoshanna insists they’re leaving anyway, but Joel says he’ll stay: he wants to know what happened.

*Despite the bullying that Joel has suffered, he has decided to face his painful experiences; moreover, he refuses to pass judgment on who Chase is without seeing all the available evidence—even though Chase has treated him terribly in the past. Joel’s bravery, curiosity, and fairness in this moment demonstrate how he has matured over the course of the novel.*



Joel, Shoshanna, and Kimberly enter Brendan’s house. They wait about 30 minutes for Chase. Then Shoshanna claims Chase is indifferent to the situation and tells Joel they should leave; Joel, standing his ground, asks Brendan to play the video without Chase there. Brendan does. Joel is apprehensive about witnessing Aaron and Bear bully him, but he finds it easier to handle than he expected: being bullied is an event in his life, not his whole identity. He feels like returning home has given him “back to himself.”

*Watching the bullying from the objective, external perspective of a camera helps Joel acknowledge the bad things that have happened to him without letting them define him. When Joel recognizes that being a victim of bullying doesn’t define who he is, he regains control over his identity: in his words, he is given “back to himself.”*



Chase enters the video. Joel carefully watches as Chase and Bear struggle over the fire extinguisher, Chase pulls it away, and the extinguisher hits Joel's face. Brendan pauses the video and says that it was an accident. Joel seconds Brendan's interpretation. Meanwhile, Shoshanna's internal conflict is showing all over her face; after a pause, she says that Chase still lied. Brendan cedes the point but asks whether Shoshanna wouldn't lie too rather than be punished for bullying she hadn't committed. Shoshanna claims she'd never face that dilemma because she doesn't spend time with "pond scum."

Joel tells Shoshanna that they should talk to Chase. Unexpectedly, Shoshanna agrees. When Brendan suggests that they should apologize, Shoshanna says that's not her priority. When Kimberly, frustrated, asks where Chase is anyway, Brendan calls Chase's mom and finds out that Chase ran off to the assisted living facility. Joel asks whether Chase forgot about Brendan's summons. Brendan says no: Chase texted earlier, confirming he'd come. Shoshanna suggests that they all head to the assisted living facility.

*Shoshanna has difficulty admitting that she was wrong—that she misjudged Chase based on his horrible pre-accident behavior and bad reputation. When she has to admit that Chase hit Joel by accident, she comes up with other criticisms: Chase lied, and he wouldn't have felt pressured to lie if he didn't hang out with "pond scum," (Aaron and Bear). In other words, even though Chase isn't a bully anymore, Shoshanna thinks he hasn't changed enough because he's still too loyal to his bully friends.*



*Brendan thinks the video-club kids should apologize to Chase for assuming that he was bullying again, implying that they owed Chase loyalty and generosity. Shoshanna disagrees. Implicitly, she suggests that, given Chase's history as a bully, it made sense to assume he was acting badly; she shouldn't have to apologize for making a rational assumption, even if it was "disloyal" to a new friendship.*



## CHAPTER 27: AARON HAKIMIAN

Aaron and Bear entertain themselves by tormenting a resident at the assisted living facility: she wants them to help her set up a table, and they invent reasons to delay. After she leaves in a huff, Aaron and Bear spot Chase hurrying down the hall. Bear asks what Chase has in his pocket. Chase, not answering, keeps walking. Aaron and Bear block his path, and Aaron yanks the object from Chase's pocket. When it falls to the floor, he and Bear see that it's Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**. Chase recovers the medal, but Aaron says he and Bear are going to take it.

The resident that Aaron and Bear were tormenting returns to ask about the table. Chase agrees to help her and follows her into another room to escape Aaron and Bear. Aaron and Bear stake out the doorway, waiting for Chase to emerge. Chase sets up a flowerpot on the table, knocks it off, and grabs a vacuum to clean up the mess. Then he drops the **medal** and vacuums it up too. He grabs the vacuum in his arms and rushes Aaron and Bear. Using the vacuum, he knocks them both over and escapes down the hallway—but soon Aaron and Bear are on their feet and ready to chase him.

*Aaron and Bear have repeatedly claimed that amnesiac Chase is being disloyal to them—but here, they show the limits of their own loyalty: when Chase wants to make amends for their past bad behavior toward Mr. Solway, Aaron and Bear bully and threaten him. If the medal symbolizes people's reputations, Aaron and Bear's desire to keep it shows that they deserve their reputations as bullies.*



*Given that the medal symbolizes people's reputations—whether inaccurate or accurate—Chase's determination to return the medal to Mr. Solway suggests that he no longer deserves his bad reputation as a troublemaker: he's trying to change and make amends. On the other hand, his clever and athletic tactics to get past Aaron and Bear show that he does deserve his reputation as a star athlete.*



## CHAPTER 28: SHOSHANNA WEBER

As Shoshanna marches toward the assisted living facility, she contemplates the “mix of good and bad” in Chase and worries that she can never unsay some of the false, cruel things she’s said about him. She, Joel, Brendan, and Kimberly barrel into Mr. Solway’s room. Mr. Solway comments sarcastically on all the strangers Shoshanna has ushered into his space. When she asks whether he’s seen Chase, Mr. Solway says that neither she nor Chase has visited for days. Guiltily, Shoshanna explains that she and Chase had a fight and were avoiding each other. Amused, Mr. Solway comments he’s glad he’s not young anymore.

Loud noises fill the hall. When Shoshanna goes to investigate, she sees Chase sprinting down the hall, holding a vacuum cleaner. Then he falls, and she sees that Aaron knocked him down by tugging on the cleaner’s trailing cord. Bear jumps on Chase and starts hitting him. Shoshanna yells in anger—as does Kimberly, who has joined her in the doorway. The girls rush to yank Bear off Chase. When Bear shoves them into a wall, Brendan comes to their defense, throwing passionate though inept punches at Bear. Bear punches Brendan in the face, knocking him to the floor, but Brendan jumps up and moves to continue fighting. Chase and Mr. Solway—who uses his wheelchair like a battering ram—join the action.

Shoshanna sees Joel coming down the hall with Nurse Duncan and some security guards; she admires her brother’s intelligence at going for backup. The arrival of authority figures breaks up the fight. Bear blames the situation on Chase. When Nurse Duncan demands to know what, exactly, the situation is, Chase opens the vacuum bag onto the floor and picks out Mr. Solway’s **Medal of Honor**. He explains, miserably, that he stole it before his amnesia. When Brendan tries to reassure him that that was the “old” Chase, Chase denies that there are two versions of himself.

*Chase has been trying to become a better person, but that doesn’t mean that he’s a better person already: he still defaults to solving conflicts with physical violence sometimes, and he’s still too eager for his father’s dubiously valuable approval. Shoshanna recognizes this “mix of good and bad” in Chase but feels guilty for criticizing him too harshly anyway. Her guilt suggests that she believes you should judge people by who they’re trying to become, not just by who they are and who they’ve been.*



*Shoshanna, Kimberly, Brendan, and even Mr. Solway rush to defend Chase and each other from Aaron and Bear’s physical attacks, even though Aaron and Bear are large, aggressive football players. Their eagerness to defend each other highlights their bravery and their earned loyalty to one another; it also suggests that the video-club kids have finally had enough of Aaron and Bear’s bullying.*



*While Shoshanna, Kimberly, and Brendan’s willingness to defend each other and Chase is brave, it isn’t very smart of them to try to fight two large football players. The novel suggests that Joel’s approach—quickly finding adult authority figures—is a better response to adolescent bullying. When Chase denies that the “old” and “new” version of him are different people, he publicly takes responsibility for stealing the medal even though he can’t remember the theft—and, in so doing, asserts that he earned his bad reputation even if that reputation is no longer accurate. The medal, for Chase, thus represents both his well-earned bad reputation and the gap between that reputation and who he is now.*





Mr. Solway asks whether Aaron and Bear were “in on it.” Chase claims he acted alone; he fell off the roof while hiding the **medal**, so he supposes he “got what [he] deserved.” Mr. Solway looks stunned, Joel and Shoshanna are struck dumb, Brendan’s jaw is swelling shut, Kimberly’s confused, and Aaron and Bear don’t want to say anything to incriminate themselves—so everyone stands there in silence until Nurse Duncan announces that she’s calling the police.

*Chase is lying or at least omitting relevant truths when he claims he acted alone in stealing the medal: Aaron and Bear certainly were “in on it.” It isn’t clear whether he lies because he feels residual loyalty to his old friends or because he believes he’s the guiltiest party; given his anger at Aaron and Bear and his self-loathing claim that he “deserved” his head injury, the latter seems more likely. In saying that he “deserved” the accident that caused his amnesia, Chase is suggesting that he deserved to lose his memories and identity because he stole Mr. Solway’s identity, that is, the medal that symbolized the reputation as a hero that he earned during the Korean War (1950–1953).*



## CHAPTER 29: CHASE AMBROSE

The police arrest Chase, and he stays out of school until his appearance in juvenile court. While he waits, he stewes about what everyone must think of the kid who stole from war hero Mr. Solway and bitterly regrets having wronged “the person [he] respect[s] more than anybody.” He thinks Mr. Solway will never want to interact with him again—and he wishes he didn’t have to interact with himself. Though Brendan, Shoshanna, Aaron, and Bear call Chase’s house, Tina won’t let them speak to Chase. Chase is fine with that. He can’t bear Shoshanna’s criticisms, and he doesn’t want Aaron and Bear’s thanks for taking all the blame, since as their former leader in crime he feels responsible. He thinks he might end up in juvenile detention and wonders whether he was a “delinquent” influence on Aaron and Bear.

*This passage makes clear that Chase has concealed Aaron and Bear’s involvement in his crime not because he’s still loyal to them but because—full of self-loathing—he believes he bears the most responsibility. He even wonders whether his influence turned Aaron and Bear into “delinquent[s],” though given Aaron and Bear’s behavior toward the video-club kids and the assisted living facility residents, the two boys seem perfectly capable of cruelty and bullying on their own.*



Tina continues to support Chase, and Johnny visits home to be with them during the trial—but that just makes Chase feel bad, like he’s ruining Johnny’s time at college. Chase also spends time with Frank, Corinne, and Helene. Oddly, Corinne is emotionally supportive and positive about “the kind of person” Chase is. When Chase tries to apologize for how he treated her and Helene before his accident, Corinne dismisses it, implying that the present is more important. Moreover, because Helene is too young to understand Chase’s problems, Chase finds some solace in playing dolls with her.

*Johnny comes home from college to support Chase, suggesting that Johnny is a kind, generous, mature person. Meanwhile, Corinne now believes in “the kind of person” Chase is, even though she used to dislike him on Helene’s behalf—which shows that the adults who have had the opportunity to observe Chase recognize the positive changes he’s made.*



One day, Chase is helping Helene play with her dolls when he notices Frank filming them on his phone. Chase expresses confusion, given Frank’s previous slighting comments about Chase befriending a little girl. Frank says that if they show the video in court, it will prove to the judge that Chase is a good brother and help him get back to football.

*Up to this point, Frank has seemed like a one-dimensional character: a macho man unhealthily fixated on his son’s middle-school football career and dismissive of anything “feminine.” This scene suggests that Frank at least recognizes that Chase has become a better brother to Helene by doing “feminine” things with her, even if Frank only wants to use that fact to get Chase out of legal trouble.*



Chase comments that Frank probably thinks he's stupid for returning Mr. Solway's **Medal of Honor**. Frank disagrees: while it would have been smarter for Chase to return the medal anonymously, Chase didn't "earn" it, and it mattered to Mr. Solway—so Chase "did the right thing." Chase questions whether the medal mattered to Mr. Solway, who can't remember earning it any more than Chase can remember his own past. Frank points out that past events exist whether you can remember them or not.

*While Frank has previously enabled Chase's bad behavior—and even praised Chase for hitting Joel in the face—he admits here that Chase shouldn't have taken something he didn't "earn" and so "did the right thing" by giving back Mr. Solway's medal. Despite Frank's monomaniacal machismo, then, he does have some moral standards: he thinks people should have to earn the kind of excellent reputations symbolized by the Medal of Honor rather than getting them through dishonest means. He also seems to believe that because the past objectively exists whether people remember it or not, you should hold yourself responsible even for past actions you've forgotten.*



Frank goes on to say that though he "loved" Chase's pre-accident self, he respects Chase's new personality and recognizes that it makes certain things possible, like Chase's friendship with Helene, which would never have been possible before. Chase says he thought Frank believed "that kind of stuff [was a] weakness." Frank, blushing, says that he's come to recognize the character it took for Chase to shield Aaron and Bear from blame, as well as to make restitutions to Mr. Solway and Joel. Chase has done some idiotic things, but everybody does, on occasion; Chase shouldn't let that "cost [him] the game." To Chase's surprise, he realizes that Frank is proud of him.

*When Chase reminds Frank that he used to think of Chase's "girly" playing with Helene as a "weakness," Frank blushes—an embarrassed reaction suggesting he knows how immature his past criticisms of Chase and Helene's burgeoning friendship were. Frank's admission that it took grit for Chase to take the blame and make amends for his past behavior, meanwhile, shows that he is coming to value Chase's new strength of character as well as his physical strength and athleticism—though he still tends to talk about character in terms of sports, like how he tells Chase not to let his mistakes "cost [him] the game." Unexpectedly, then, Chase gets the approval from Frank that he's always wanted by acting like his own person, not like a copy of Frank.*



When Chase enters juvenile court, he has a sudden flashback to entering it with Aaron and Bear the last time. He remembered being furious that he, a great sports star, was being held to account for his behavior. Now he's so conscious of his own guilt that he doesn't even want to defend himself—an attitude that irritates his lawyer, Mr. Landau. Walking into the courtroom with Tina and Frank, Chase sees that a lot of people have come to the hearing: the football coach and some players, including Joey; Shoshanna, Joel, and their parents; Ms. DeLeo and some teachers. Chase assumes that they've come to gloat. He's miserably shocked at how much they hate him.

*Whereas Chase previously felt that he—a high-status athlete—shouldn't face consequences, now he hates himself and believes that everyone in the court hates him too. The contrast between Chase's past and present attitude shows how much he has changed for the better since his accident.*



The judge enters, rereads Chase's file, and asks what he has to say in his own defense. Chase says that he has no defense: he stole Mr. Solway's **medal**, even if he can't remember the crime and would never commit it now. The judge says that that admission should make the hearing "easier, if not any more pleasant."

*Once again, Chase is taking responsibility for his past actions and accepting that he earned his bad reputation (represented by the theft of the medal), showing how much he has grown since he committed the theft.*



Mr. Landau asks to call character witnesses in Chase's defense. On the stand, Tina explains how much Chase has changed since his accident. Then Frank suggests that Chase has improved so much as a person that it makes Frank wish *he'd* had a traumatic accident at Chase's age; this testimony shocks Chase, who thought Frank only liked Chase insofar as Chase took after Frank. Afterward, Chase's original doctor gives his expert opinion that Chase's accident really was severe enough to cause both amnesia and a "personality change," though neuroscience is still mysterious enough that he can't say whether the change will be permanent.

When Shoshanna takes the stand, Chase assumes she'll criticize him harshly and asks Mr. Landau to stop her. She testifies that Chase has behaved badly in the past and is guilty of the crime in question—but he's trying to improve and, even though she's been his harshest critic, she firmly believes that he'll "be a good person" in the future. The judge thanks Shoshanna but points out that the issue is Chase stealing the **Medal of Honor**, not his future character. He asks whether anyone else wants to speak in Chase's defense. Everyone stands: teachers, video club members, football players—and Joel and his parents. Chase, shocked, tears up.

The judge acknowledges that Chase seems to have changed, but he asks whether Chase can assure him that he's really a distinct entity from the thief of Mr. Solway's **medal**. Chase doesn't believe that his past and present selves are entirely "separate." He knows he could lie to the judge and save himself, but that's "what the old Chase would do." Instead, he says that he doesn't feel like the person he used to be and doesn't want to act like that person, but he can't swear that the old Chase has been annihilated.

*Frank's claim that he wishes he'd had a personality-altering head injury like Chase's is humorous. Yet it makes clear that Frank not only recognizes the improvements in Chase's personality but, as a result, is coming to realize that his own hyper-macho, bully-enabling personality could also use some improvement. Ironically, Chase has been a better role model for his father Frank than Frank has been for Chase. Meanwhile, the doctor suggests that Chase's "personality change" is due to physical trauma—but it seems possible that amnesiac Chase simply forgot the negative influences that shaped his bully identity, allowing his better characteristics to surface.*



*At this point, Shoshanna and other people who interact with Chase in regular life care more about who he is now and whether he'll "be a good person" going forward than about what he's done in the past. By contrast, the judge, who represents the justice system cares primarily about the bad things Chase has done in the past—about his well-earned reputation, represented by the stolen Medal of Honor. This contrast implicitly criticizes a justice system focused more on past guilty acts than on the guilty party's present character and future rehabilitation.*



*Before showing Chase leniency, the judge demands assurances that amnesiac Chase is a "separate" person from the boy who stole the medal. This demand suggests that the judge doesn't believe in rehabilitation: he doesn't want to hear that Chase has changed over time but that he's a brand-new person, the Chase who committed the theft having effectively disappeared due to head trauma. Though Chase lied to Dr. Fitzwallace earlier to protect himself from punishment, he refuses to do that again because it's "what the old Chase would do." Thus, by refusing to claim that the "old Chase" is dead forever, amnesiac Chase ironically proves that he really has grown and changed for the better since his accident—the bad reputation that the theft of the medal symbolizes no longer represents who he really is.*



The judge sighs, says Chase has “left [him] no choice,” and is about to pronounce a sentence—when Mr. Solway busts into the courtroom, using his walker and wearing his **Medal of Honor**. He announces that he has his medal back, so the case should be over. When the judge says that a happy ending doesn’t wipe away a crime, Mr. Solway claims no crime occurred: he lent Chase the medal. When Chase protests, Mr. Solway tells him that he has amnesia, so his account is less credible than Mr. Solway’s. When the judge implies that Mr. Solway might not be telling the truth, Mr. Solway insists that, speaking truthfully, Chase is a “good kid” whom he’d trust with his medal.

When Mr. Landau claims that Mr. Solway’s testimony is cause for “reasonable doubt,” the judge laughs mockingly—but he decides to dismiss the charges, warning Chase not to “prove [him] wrong.” The whole courtroom celebrates. The football players in attendance hoist Chase onto their shoulders and parade him around, which triggers a flashback to their championship win the previous year. Once they put him down, Chase—feeling tremendously grateful—thanks everyone and hugs several people, including Shoshanna, which causes Joel to laugh at them and Shoshanna to jump away blushing. Before she leaves, she too tells Chase not to “prove [her] wrong.”

Chase walks to Mr. Solway, who tells him that he almost “blew it.” When Chase insists that Mr. Solway never lent him the medal, Mr. Solway retorts that since he’s elderly and Chase has amnesia, no one can know for sure—and besides, he “would have” lent Chase the medal. When Chase thanks him shakily, Mr. Solway suggests he should thank Corinne instead. Chase spots Corinne near the doorway with Helene, holding the keys to her van. Contemplating all the support he’s received, Chase decides that his accident was “the best thing that ever happened” to him.

*Mr. Solway wears his Medal of Honor when he comes to Chase’s defense. Implicitly, he wears the medal not only to show that Chase righted the wrong relevant to the case but also to bolster his own testimony: he’s a hero, so the judge should listen to him. Though Mr. Solway doesn’t believe that his own reputation as a hero is accurate, he doesn’t believe that Chase’s reputation as a troublemaker is accurate anymore either—so he uses his own inaccurate reputation (war hero) to give Chase a more accurate one: “good kid.”*



*The judge’s laughter suggests that he doesn’t believe Mr. Solway’s story about lending Chase the medal at all—but he may be unwilling to call an elderly war hero a liar. Thus, Mr. Solway’s reputation saves Chase. Yet the judge and Shoshanna both warn Chase not to “prove [them] wrong” indicating that Chase isn’t fully absolved of his past behavior: he needs to keep taking responsibility for his actions and improving himself to deserve his second chance. Chase’s flashback to the football championship, meanwhile, suggests that his moral victory in the courtroom—refusing to lie and getting a second chance—is as valuable as a more conventional, high-status success like winning a state championship.*



*The novel heavily implies that Mr. Solway did not lend Chase the medal; Chase really stole it. Nevertheless, Mr. Solway’s insistence that he “would have” lent Chase the medal shows the depth of their friendship, which in turn illustrates how people can gain meaningful relationships when they make connections outside of their usual social sphere. The revelation that Corinne drove Mr. Solway to court to testify on Chase’s behalf, meanwhile, emphasizes that Corinne and Helene have forgiven Chase for his past bullying. Thus, the accident is “the best thing that ever happened” to Chase not only because it made him a better person and gave him new friendships but also because it improved his family relationships.*



## CHAPTER 30: BRENDAN ESPINOZA

To Brendan's shock, Kimberly has started liking him back—she admires how he defended her and Shoshanna from Bear during the fight at the assisted living facility, though she claims she's mostly just surprised he survived. Brendan is no longer jealous of Kimberly's crush on Chase, either, because he thinks Chase and Shoshanna might like each other.

Chase has started playing in football games again; the video club, including Shoshanna, attended his first game back. The football coach so admired the footage they took that he made them the team's "official videographers." Even Joel is now the leader of the pep band. All the football players (except Aaron and Bear) have started being friendlier to the video club, and Chase is part of the football team *and* video club—in fact, the video he and Shoshanna made about Mr. Solway won the National Video Journalist Contest.

The video club has "adopted" Mr. Solway, though he won't let them refer to him as their "official war hero," as he doesn't believe he's a hero and doesn't like war. Brendan thinks he's a hero just because he stood up for Chase in court, but when he asks Mr. Solway about his heroism, Mr. Solway claims not to remember and tells Brendan to ask Chase what that's like. Actually, Chase is remembering more; sometimes, Brendan sees Chase looking miserable and deduces that he's recalled another awful thing he did in the past.

Brendan has realized that the best thing about video club isn't the possibility of creating a viral video, but the people with whom it connects you—like Mr. Solway, or Kimberly (now his girlfriend), or Chase (formerly his bully, now his close friend). He does, however, have a viral video now: Kimberly uploaded the footage of him trapped in a tuba and covered in fire-extinguisher foam to YouTube, and the video now has hundreds of thousands of views. This unexpected success shows Brendan that "*anything* is possible," including his romance with Kimberly and Chase becoming a kind person.

*Just as Frank came to appreciate Chase's strength of character as much as his physical strength and athleticism, so Kimberly comes to appreciate Brendan's bravery even though he lacks physical strength: there is more than one way to be an admirable boy or man. Moreover, Kimberly's appreciation of Brendan's bravery suggests that he misjudged her when he assumed that she would only like him if he gained social status somehow.*



*The reconciliation between the video club and the football team—as well as Chase's participation in both groups—shows that groups of kids don't need to hate each other just because they have different interests. So long as one interest group doesn't bully the other—as the football team used to bully the video club—the kids can celebrate each other's talents and collaborate productively, as when the video club films football games or when the musicians play at pep rallies.*



*Mr. Solway's refusal to accept the "official war hero" title shows that, while he is willing to use his reputation to help his friends, he still doesn't "believe his own hype:" there's a large gap between how other people think of him and how he sees himself. Meanwhile, Chase is proving that the judge and Shoshanna were right to trust him by continuing to despise his past actions as a bully.*



*This last passage emphasizes that social status—whether it comes from viral videos or football—matters less than good relationships. Yet the novel ends on a humorous note by revealing that viral videos and good relationships are compatible: Brendan's new girlfriend, a terrible videographer, managed to make a viral YouTube video of him, so "anything is possible."*







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